Love Takes Time

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42864771.

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Explicit

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Part 1 of Stages of Love

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by Batatadeuces

Summary

After so much time apart could any feeling still be there? After a life apart could anyone even be friends? Be lovers? Be anything at all? They were so different, no longer the kids they knew, no longer each other's everything. Now adults with only a shared past. Nothing but memories to each other.

Ghost of The Past

— **F**inn, did you pack all of your things? You can't leave anything behind, we won't be able to get it back. Not for a couple of months. — Catra screamed at them, hoping they would actually listen for once. — And no bringing that obnoxious drum stick to the front seat. It goes in the bag, you play when you get there. — The groan coming from the almost teenager made her quite sure they were listening.

— Mom. I can't find Mini Finn. — The 12 year old screamed from their room. — I swear I put them in my backpack.

— Check under your bed.

— It's here!

Catra was finding very fascinating to live with a pre-teen, they had such childish arges, everyday fighting for more independence and to be treat like an adult while also asking to sleep in her bed, to bring their favorite plushie with them in the car, they even still asked her to slice their oranges. As someone who dealt with bipolarity she would never joke about it, but it really felt similar to her, as if her child was fighting to see which part would win, the kid or the growing teen inside of them.

The moving was very welcome by Finn, no one really wanted to be in the Fright Zone. The pollution had gotten so bad she needed to move, no way she could raise a child in such a hostile and decaying place. It brought her pain to leave it behind, but it was going to be fine, she was going to work in Brightmoon, she was going to be the biggest, the most important advisor to the only company who could help the Fright Zone. At least she hoped Glimmer's words weren't in vain, she would still have Scorpia by her side. And that made everything better, living in a place where she didn't know anyone was very scary, Finn was definitely more optimistic about that part than her, friends were never her strong suit.

As they left the almost deserted city, she kept seeing the horde billboards all over town, wondering how could anyone allowed them to destroy everything, to pretend they were helping, selling their lies, telling everyone they had jobs to offer, that they would make the city great and well known when all they did was destroyed it and make everyone leave. Catra hated them so much. What they did to her, to her city, and especially the people that left her because of them.

— Mom, are you okay? — The blonde kid asked as Catra's claws started to damage the wheel.

— Yes baby. Just thinking too hard. — As they passed the military school, it felt like getting punched in the heart, so many hard memories coming at her at once.

She could still clearly hear Adora's voice saying 'You can't ask me to say here! There's nothing here for me! Nothing!'. She would never forget that, how she felt like nothing for the longest time. But that was in the past, she had Finn now, she had a new job, a new house and finally enough power to make a difference. Adora had always been about fighting, never about changing, Catra couldn't count on her fingers the many times Adora appeared on tv as she led protests. It felt so surreal to see her again when it first happened, so angry and prepared to take down the horde and she did it, she got the people she met a Brightmoon to help, to use their status and power to close all of their factories. And yet the Fright Zone was in shambles, because Adora only wanted to fight, not change, not make it better, she focused so much on the horde as if the city didn't even matter to her. No protest to help clean, no protests to rebuild. Catra had plans, she was going to make it a better place, a place for people to belong.

Adora's activism didn't bother Catra, it was her lack of involvement with rebuilding the Fright Zone that did.

— Can we stop on the way to get some lunch? — Finn asked with the biggest smile they could master. — Please.

— Okay. We can do that.

X

It was 1 in the morning and Adora couldn't sleep, couldn't ignore her body. Why was she so horny all the time? So needy? After everything had settled down, she felt like her body had had enough of being a second thought. Almost 10 years of fighting, of trying to get the Horde to leave, she had imagined she would feel immense relief, accomplishment even but no, she's met with an overwhelmed, exhausted, touch starved, almost depressed body. She didn't want to masturbate, it felt too weak to just do whatever her body told her, she kept telling herself she's the one who controls it, it doesn't control her. However it was pointless. She had done that for long enough, she had pushed herself to her body limits, she had starved, she had walked for hours although every muscle in her body hurt, she had ignored severe injuries, all so she could make the Horde leave. Her body was done listening to her, done letting her decide. Why couldn't she understand it was her? Her needs, her pain, her body was her, not something else, not something to be tamed, but something to embrace, to listen to, to love, not hurt.

Adora groaned. She hugged a pillow and fought the tears coming, once again ignoring her body. She knew she needed to listen to Bow and see Perfuma, she couldn't handle what she felt alone, she barely even understood it. So Adora did the one thing she remembered using from a martial arts class, she sat up, closed her eyes and crossed her legs. She did the breathing exercise for almost 6 minutes till she felt her body was calm. Sleeping after that came easy. Waking up not so much, the alarm made her almost fell off the bed.

— I'm going. — Living alone still felt odd, no noisy roommate, not a single scratch in her bedsheets, no purring while she slept. — And now I'm talking to myself.

She got up for some breakfast, took a shower and was ready to go to her gym. Helping kids defend themselves wasn't exactly

what she expected to be doing but it was nice, fighting was the only thing she seemed to excel at, so why not help others do it too. She liked the kids, and some Saturdays she gave free classes for anyone who was interested. She loved when older folks came, it reminded her of Razz, she missed her. The sun started to feel warm on her skin as she got closer to the gym. A kid stood there, reading her sign. Ears and a tail making everything inside Adora scream.

— Catra? — Adora whispered as she got closer. Realizing how silly she sounded, Catra was not a kid anymore, although that's all Adora remembered.

— Hi. — The kid said and Adora smiled and waved, shaking away the feeling in her gut. — Do you work here?

— Yeah, I'm the teacher. — Adora looked around wondering who the kid was with. — What are you doing here alone?

— My mom is in the grocery store, and it's boring so I asked to walk around, she said fine, and that I couldn't pass the red car. — Adora turned to see the red car a little further from where they were. — But I'm going back now. She's definitely going to be worried if I'm not back.

— Okay. Bye. — Adora laughed as the kid walked dramatically back to the grocery store.

Adora hadn't seen anyone like Catra in forever, it shook her. She could feel the guilt starting to creep, trying to take hold of her. The tears won this time. She couldn't control it. She stepped inside and decided to let it flow as she stretched and got her body warmed up for the class. The tears made little poodles on the mat. Why was she so sad all the time? Why did thinking of Catra still hurt so bad? She didn't understand.

— Morning Dora. — Frosta as always was the first to arrive. — So! Who are we punching today?

Adora laughed and did her best to clean her tears.

— We should probably wait for the rest of the class to get here. — Frosta's groan made Agora laugh.

X

— Telling you not to talk to strangers it's the same as nothing. — Catra scolded Finn about their misbehaving.

— Yeah but she seemed nice. And she gives kids classes, she's not a bad person. — Finn did their best at a counterpoint

— How can you know she's not a bad person? — Catra held their hood as they walked to school. — You can't know that.

— Because she smells like a good person, and you told to always trust my noise. — Finn said, proud of their answer.

Catra rolled her eyes at them, she knows her kid was good at finding trouble, but also agreed with their statement.

— Alright. Promise me to be good at school, okay? no getting into trouble on the first day.

— I promise to not get in trouble if you let me do the fighting class. — They said as if they held enough power to negotiate. — We can go there tomorrow and talk to her and you will see she smells like a good person, almost like a puppy.

Catra really wanted them to like Brightmoon, to be happy, and for the longest time Finn hadn't been that excited about anything.

— We'll see. — Was all Catra said. And somehow Finn already knew it was a yes. — Now go. Be nice. I'll pick you up so wait until you see me to leave the gates.

Catra saw them entering school, their backpack still had Mini Finn inside. They loved that plushie more than Catra could've ever hoped for, sewing was hard but at the time she couldn't find any toys that look like them, so she made one and never touched a sewing machine ever again after that. She could still feel the sting

in her fingertips. Leaving them at school was still hard, she was trying to not be so overprotective, trying to let them learn more alone, although it was still very hard to say no to them sometimes, so she knew very well that the fighting class was happening. Finn had an energy she envied but maybe having the extra exercise would make them a little tired when night came.

The building she would be working on was a lot fancier and prettier than she imagined, actually everything in Brightmoon was pretty, so much purple everywhere, the streets were filled with art, everything was well taken care of, even the runes were nice, it made sense for it the be the most beautiful place in Etheria, so close to home and yet Catra never wanted to go there. A couple of years ago she would rather drink the tap water from the Fright Zone than come to Brightmoon. The rich people made her stomach twist, for a long time in her mind they were all like Hordak, just doing whatever they wanted with the power they held. Never caring about anyone else. Only caring for what happened in their precious little Brightmoon, she could thank Adora for the change in opinion, and Glimmer, and some other rich people she didn't know personally however they were up front, fighting the Horde alongside Adora. And Glimmer was obnoxious and wore a lot of pink and glitter but still, she was helping, had her heart sat on helping and even with all Catra's walls up, the other seemed to be climbing them and almost becoming her friend.

She received a very well prepared welcome, champagne included. One of the secretaries showed Catra her table, well, her own office with a very beautiful view. It took her breath away. Her maroon suit reflected and she smiled at her own reflection for a bit, feeling sexy. A not very occuring feeling for her.

— Hey. Everything to your liking? — Glimmer appeared, Catra almost jumped, sometimes it felt like it was magic, even with her amazing hearing she never heard Glimmer's footsteps, maybe it was some rich woman's shoe or something like that. — I wasn't sure what decorations you would want so…I didn't do much.

— It's fine, Sparkles. — Catra answered. — When's the first meeting? Scorpia is almost sat with the demolition team. She's going to be working from there.

— Oh. No need for a meeting. We are doing what you propose at the zoom meeting, starting with the schools and clean water. Today you have to choose who's going to work on the water cleaning, there's a handful of companies that want in, and I feel like you're the best judge for that. But I do vouched for Mermista Clean Water. She's legit. — Catra nodded. — I sent an email, you can see all the companies there. — Glimmer was out of there just as fast as she arrived.

— Okay. No time to waste, Fright Zone needs you. — Catra didn't quite understand the amount of trust being put into her until that moment with Glimmer.

She had her work cut out for her. And she did with a big smile on her face. Everything about it made her happy and she took Glimmer's suggestion, not wanting to waste any time she went and tried to contact Mermista. The teal haired lady looked tired and stressed as they talked.

— This is going to be hard. The Horde really did it's thing there, those fuckers. — Catra's eyes went a little wide at the blunt vocabulary. — But I'm up for it, I need two days of preparation. My team will send you the deets.

The call ended and Catra went straight to the phone with Scorpia, they needed to demolish Horde's property and build new schools, the Fright Zone only had three, two of them military schools and the other could barely stay functional. Catra didn't miss the military one bit. Shadow weaver had done her fair share of fucking kids up. So schools were of huge importance for Catra, they needed to get the people from there proper education, not the bullshit she was fed most of her life, she was glad Finn could learn better at Brightmoon, she just couldn't afford to drive everyday to Brightmoon just for them to studied and go pick them up and go back to the Fright Zone. She already missed them so

much, it had only been a few hours since she last saw them, they had gotten attached to each other extremely fast after the adoption, Catra was scared at the time, 26 and all she wanted was to raise them right. She realized she would end up having more free time, it would be good, her previous work didn't leave much of a choice, the only remaining job on the Fright Zone was at its last restaurant, and she was the only employee. Dark times. And she spent a lot of time away from her child.

Catra looked around her office as Scorpia did her calculations. She could see the university she technically went to, she never physically went there, everything was done from a distance, on the internet, international affairs was something she always wanted to try, even though she only ever worried about her local people. She took a deep breath, maybe she'd visit, just to see it one time in person. A university was something they had planned for a later part of the project, people would need to be living there again for it to work.

— Okay wild cat. We start demolishing tomorrow first thing in the morning, we hope to have at least two of the factories completely cleaned up by the end of the week, and after that we multitask, some teams will continue demolishing, some will start building. — Scorpia smiled brightly, she was just as happy as Catra about everything they were doing. — I'm so glad it's finally happening, and you can count on me to make everything here work perfectly. — She gave Catra a very weird bow that went off camera.

— Alright, thanks Scorpia, we'll talk tomorrow. I'm going to go grab something to eat.

— Oh wait and how's Finn doing? — Being considered was definitely a Scorpia thing to do and Catra should've seen that coming but it didn't change the little smile it brought her. She loved Scorpia although she rarely said, her only true friend. Even when Catra was an absolute asshol, she stuck around long enough to be Finn's favorite aunt, given that she was the only one they had.

— My baby is doing great, now they want to do a defense class. And they started a proper school today. I hope everything is going alright. No calls from the school so that's good, and they really want to be on my good side today. — As Catra said she felt her hunger growing. — I need to go eat now. You take care.

Scorpia waved goodbye before ending the call. Catra got a little lost and took the opportunity to get to know the place she was staying. With hopes to find somewhere to eat.

X

Adora was sweating a lot after the morning class was done. She needed a shower, some food and to do as she promised and see Perfuma. The last part was truly going to be the most difficult, talking about her feelings was a sore spot. And being so confused about her own emotions was definitely not going to help. The water in the showers there was nice, nicer than in the military school, the only good memories she had there were with Catra, some with the other kids but not many. Neither of them knew well why they were there, too young to remember, all they could remember was what happened in there, so many lies being fed, the Horde basically controlled the schools, telling the kids that they were good and fun, almost every year they visited one of the factories. Adora groaned, irritated that she was thinking about it again, it was done, she didn't need to think about it anymore.

Her lunch was well packed on the gym fridge, she ate alone, not something that bothers her too much, she did miss being thrown food now and then. Catra loved teasing her, sometimes it felt like she wanted them to get caught, most of the time. She couldn't stop thinking about the kid she saw, thinking it was Catra, she almost ran and hugged that kid. All she thought about was how to apologize, she really wanted to make amends but it had been so long, Catra probably didn't remember her by now. Almost 20 years, it was a lot, they were both in their thirties. Adora wondered if Catra had someone, all the time that kept her up at night, she knew it was odd she didn't have a partner, she saw all her friends finding someone, but Adora just didn't do well flirting

and sharing her feelings and women were so scary and she felt too tired for it, the lack of energy she felt recently made her feel unlike herself, she didn't feel like the person who did all of those protests, not even close.

As she saw the colorful flowers she knew she was at the right path after being lost for a while walking. Everything smelled nice, the garden was big, Perfuma said it would be, Adora couldn't see the pink dress Perfuma wore form from a distance.

— Adora. You came. — She said going for a hug. — I'm so glad you're here.

— Yeah, It felt like I needed to talk to an adult for once, those kids are not quite ready for what I have to say. — Adora laughed. — So, how does this work?

— We talk, we can sit somewhere you like, or walk around the garden.

— Walk. — Perfuma nodded and they started walking side by side. — I was thinking, I don't really know what to say.

— Why did you decide to come today? — Adora half knew the answer for that.

— I've been confused, with myself, a lot lately, and…— Adora blushed hard without being able to continue. — Just out of touch with my body, outside from fighting and teaching it's like it is not mine, it doesn't do what I say! — Adora sighed.

— What do you want your body to do?

Adora looked around for a while, thinking.

— Stop being so needy. — She said. — Why does it feel so needy? I don't. I'm not, I'm okay. I'm fine, I don't need anyone, I'm very independent, and I'm doing well.

Perfuma took a deep breath.

— When you feel pain, what do you do? — Adora frowned.

— If it's nothing serious I ignore it till it passes, when it's bad I put ice on it.

— Why do you ignore your body? Have you ever thought that maybe if you paid attention to what hurts it might not get to the point of you needing any ice? — Adora avoided eye contact.

— I think it is a… strength thing. Like…if I can't stand a little pain I'm weak. — She sighed again. — Probably some military brainwashing that's left here. — She pointed at her head.

Perfuma stopped Adora taking her hands.

— You are not weak, no matter what your brain tells you. You have been through a lot, you have done a lot, you don't need any more pain in your life Adora. Stop fighting yourself…is not embarrassing to feel needy, is very human.

Adora nodded, holding her hands a little tighter. Letting the words sink in for a while.

— What if I don't know who I am without the pain? What if when the pain it's gone there's no more Adora?

— Do you believe yourself to be made only of pain? — Adora nodded no. — I find that pain is often keeping people from seeing and learning who they really are. With no fear holding them back, no self judgment, no trauma to dictate how you behave. It opens so many new and exciting opportunities, it takes you further than you could've ever imagined yourself being.

— Today…I saw this kid who look so much like Catra. — Perfuma already knew about her past, most of it. — I realized I'm clearly not over what happened. I feel guilty and so so…so sad.

— Guilty about leaving?

— No…not just that, I think I feel more guilty about not reaching out, I just couldn't stay, I think I forgive my younger self about that. I should've gone back for her, tried again to get her out of there. But I didn't.

— And why didn't you?

— I'm pretty sure she hates me.

X

As Finn saw their mom they ran towards the car completely ignoring her. Catra tried not to take offense, but it was hard not to, as she turned she saw they didn't run to the car, fear was the first thing to strike Catra's heart.

— Finn! — She screamed.

— Here mom, come see. — They screamed back.

Catra followed the sound, they were staring up at a tree close to the school.

— What are you doing there? — She nagged.

— Look! — They pointed up.

Before Catra could quite place a glance up a creature jumped on her and as she screamed the animal purred. Catra stared up and saw something like no other.

— Finn, what is this? — The animal gave her a funny look.

— Can we keep them? — As if they understood what Finn said, the purring intensified.

Catra once again couldn't say no to her kid. The car was a lot more packed than she imagined it would be. The animal didn't leave her side, so they sat in the front sit.

— So what's your name? — Catra asked the animal as they stopped at a red light. They looked her deep in the eyes. — Melog. — She whispered, as if repeating a thought that wasn't hers.

— Who's Melog? — Finn asked.

— I think they are. — Catra said a little confused with what she felt. — So…do you want to check that defense class now? Hopefully tomorrow you can start.

— Are you serious? Step on it! — Catra laughed as they drove to the place Finn seemed more than excited about. — Do you think Melog can go too?

— Yeah, they'll behave. — Catra said again as if her mind was being share with the animal. — Are you sure you want to this?

— Yes! Very sure, let's go mom!

Catra couldn't control her laughter at their exasperated response, it was nice to see her child having a good time. The defense class seemed to have just started as they entered it. Most of the kids were stretching, Melog stood by the door, not wanting to scare any of the little ones. As Catra look around to try to find the teacher Finn tried to match the other kids movements.

— Okay guys, let's stretch those legs now, try touching your toes, anyone who can do gets to try a move on me. — Catra turned to see the blonde coming back with multiple gloves covering her face, the only thing not covered was her hair. With a face revealed or not, Catra knew. She would never forget that voice. — Oh, you, you're back. Nice knowing your mom didn't get mad.

— I didn't get pass the red car. — They both smiled at each other. Finn got closer to help with the gloves.

— Wanna help me? Give these to the ones on this side and the others get these. — Finn nodded as she gave them the gloves.

— Okay, I can do this while you talk to my mom. — Finn pointed at Catra.

Frozen, they both stood frozen for what seemed like eternity. None of the kids paid any attention to them, to their meaningful looks, to the tears, to the slight sob that came out of Adora's mouth. The blonde was the first to move, cleaning her cheeks as she got closer. Catra didn't know what to do, so she offered her hand, Adora grabbed it, it was supposed to be a handshake but they just held hands. Neither wanting to let go, as if they did the other might just disappear for another 20 years.

— Hey Adora

Words Unsaid

Nothing could've stopped the tears, no amount of self control could've compared to how emotional Adora felt, she couldn't believe what was happening. Who she was holding hands with nor the away Catra was looking at her, with so much kindness. It felt like a dream, her best possible dream coming true. It was nothing like the looks Catra gave her the last time they saw each other, the hurt and the anger were all dissipated.

— I can't believe it's you. — Adora choked out. — It's been so long. I have so…I'm sorry. — Catra smiled at that. — I'm sorry for how I left, for not going back. — Adora started to blurt out. — I-I I can't…are you really here?

— I am. — Catra squeezed her hand. — I'm here.

— I'm done with the gloves. Are you done talking to my mom? — Finn approached them and Catra did quick work of her tears. — Are you okay?

— Yeah. Yeah. Is just dusty in here…can you go and ask the kids to start? They know what to do. — Adora's voice betrayed her, but Finn was too focused on their task to stick around. — Thank you.

— They want to start learning here. Do you have any room for one more? — Catra said, not really acknowledging Adora's emotional words.

— Yes. I do. — Their fingers were still tangled. — Can we talk? In private?

— Don't you have a class to give? — Adora couldn't quite understand where she stood with Catra. The passive aggressiveness wasn't really what she did back at military school. — I'm sure you can wait a little longer to talk. The kids are waiting on you.

Adora swallowed her words and nodded. It meant Catra would wait. It meant they still would talk, Adora just needed to teach and not focus on the fact that Catra was standing behind her, that she could turn around and see her, that she could listen to all she said to her students, could see her moving. Adora felt extremely self aware for the entire class. The bright side was Finn, they were as athletic as their mom, fast but very strong too. Adora kept a special eye on them for being the new kid, but also because it was a very surreal experience to have Catra's child right there. It made Adora's heart sink a bit to think Catra probably had someone.

— Let's stretch again and drink some water. — The circle of 6 kids and one adult did all the stretches, but none did it as well as Finn. — Okay…so, now that we're done and you guys are going to be waiting for your parents, you can get to know Finn a little, they're going to be learning here.

The kids circled around them and Adora did her best to leave the mat seamlessly. Catra didn't quite know what to feel, she had been through some many different phases in her life so many different versions of how this would go had played in her mind. She was angry that much she had known for a while, but more than that, she was still so hurt, and somehow still a part of her was beyond the moon to be seeing Adora. A part of her wanted to hug and kiss and never let go.

— You're good at that. — Catra said as Adora got closer. It took a small blush out of the blonde. — You said somewhere private?

Adora nodded and stopped herself before she took Catra's hand in her's, she didn't imagine her body would've such a strong response, muscle memory kicked in so fast, once again Adora found herself against her body, but this time she too wanted to hold Catra's hand. The action didn't go unnoticed but the feline who was experiencing a similar feeling, not touching Adora was weird, they had been so close when young, physical touch part of their main love language.

— I have a little room there. — Adora led the way to her private space, it wasn't really an office, it had a couch and some mattresses for when she just wanted to rest a little, it also for when the kids got injured. — It' a…I don't really know what to call this.

Catra looked around and saw that Melog was sniffing around the gym and Finn was still entertained with the other kids.

— I don't know exactly what you want to talk about, Adora. — Catra couldn't hold back the acidness in her tone. It cut right through Adora.

Adora didn't understand Catra, one minute it was a genuine compliment, the other a very cold response.

— I…like I said, I'm sorry. — Adora repeated, as sincere as before. — I never wanted to lose contact. — Adora wanted to rush and blurt out everything she felt but Catra's uninterested look make bite her tongue. — I'm guessing you don't care. — Adora looked down.

Catra's eyes went wide at the defeat in Adora's voice. She was never one to back down because Catra looked annoyed. The feline was being immature, she knew that very well, she knew her moods were clashing, she knew Adora was bringing back that annoying, insecure, insufferable 14 year old Catra. So she fought it, fought the want to just push Adora away, to hurt her. She had to be better than that, she could not be a child when she already had one to take care of, she needed to do better. Catra took a deep breath.

— I'm sorry. — She said. — It's hard, you…hurt me, a lot…it's in the past but it's very present in here. — Catra pointed to her head as she sat on the couch. — I saw you on tv, I'm kinda here because of you. I'm working with Glimmer to rebuild the Fright Zone.

— That's amazing! — The puppy eyes made Catra almost purr. — I got away from that…too many memories, I just couldn't deal very well. All the military school stuff, the horde, Shadow Weaver. I-I can't go back there. — Catra stared at Adora. — What?

— You did go back. You did all those protests. You helped…I saw all the people you evacuated. — Adora blushed again. — Why not help rebuild?

— I'm not good with…creating. I don't have the mindspace for it, I can't barely draw, imagined planning something like that! It's not for me. — Adora chuckled. — I'm so happy you're part of it. I trust Glimmer, she is very smart and kind and knows how to do this sort of thing, all the boring meetings. It's not for me…the protests were a very natural thing for me to do. To fight. Going back with that fire…that anger, it was easy. Without it... If I go now all I feel is…like the same 14 teen who got treated like a slave by them. — Catra felt those words hit her core, never having some to talk about military school was a curse and a blessing, too many horrible memories.

Catra looked around again to make sure Finn was okay.

— You never wanted anything to do with the Fright Zone to begin with, don't know why I thought that would change. — Adora was used to the acid tone, to the mockness Catra seemed to always carry around her, but not that, not the hurt, not the sadness in Catra's eyes, Adora didn't know what to do with that. She looked so different at that moment. Adora imagined she looked different too, it had been 18 years. — I gotta go. Finn and I need to finish unpacking.

— Okay…— Adora felt like holding Catra in place, she probably could, she had the strength to, but that wasn't very mature, she felt helpless. — I'll see you tomorrow? Finn is doing really well already. And the kids seemed to like them.

— I'll drop them here at the same time tomorrow.

Adora bit her lips holding back the cry fighting to get out, Catra wasn't going to talk to her, she was only going to drop Finn off. Adora didn't move as the others left, she waved back at Finn, and did her breathing exercise before returning to the kids who still remained there. Adora did her best to greet the parents and send the kids off. After Catra left, everything she did was on autopilot. She closed the gym, walked home, showered, and ate. All while still processing, she saw Catra, talked to her, held her hand.

As Adora sat on her mattress she felt the burning in her nose, the warmth of the tears going down her cheeks, the tightness in her throat, she cried, sobbed, too overwhelmed to do anything to stop it, so she embraced it. She cried till her eyes were buff and her body hurt from shaking, she cried till everything in her seemed to have poured out. She didn't know what to do really other than let it pour out, what else was she supposed to do with those feelings? The love? The hurt? The Frustration? It was all too much.

Before falling asleep she asked Perfuma if they could meet again the next day.

X

Catra couldn't quite figure out why Melog kept on changing color all the way to their home. Finn talked about the class, about the friends they made in school, and Catra listened, very glad to have her child there to distracted from the emotional hurricane inside of her. They didn't live very far although it truly felt like eternity to get home. There were boxes everywhere, at the door, in the kitchen, in their rooms, it was quite hard to move around so that became Catra's next distraction. Melog sniffed everything they could as they instigated the place.

— Mom. — Finn called as they got home. — Did you smell her? — The kid smiled as they asked.

Catra couldn't disagree with her child, she had a faint memory of Adora's scent but after smelling it again Finn was right, she did

smell like a good person.

— Yeah. Now go shower. — Finn ran to the bathroom leaving their backpack hanging at the door. — Don't forget to clean your tail! — Catra shouted.

Finn wasn't as reluctant to water as Catra, she still couldn't do shower, baths were okay. Catra did her best to unbox most of their things, at least to clear a bit and show some sort of living room and most important to keep herself occupied. As she placed her decorations up she noticed how most of them were Finn's, she should stop letting a kid decorate their house, too many dragons around. Melog was close, never letting Catra out of sight, the colors were still shifting.

— What is with you? — Melog came close and started to rub themselves at Catra's legs. — I'm fine. You can stop worrying.

Catra's tail barely moved. Her claws kept coming in and out. She was holding on by a thread as the boxes were ending. Finn had gotten clean, fur all fuzzy and hair wet.

— Want any help getting dry? — Catra asked as the last box was emptied.

— No mom, I got it. — They said confidently. — I'm big now, I can do it alone.

— Alright big fella, I'm going to make dinner.

— Please make fish! — Catra laughed. If it was Finn's choice, every dinner would be seafood.

Catra saw she didn't really have any fish. Something she forgot about because at the market she had to go look for her child.

— Okay. Get fancy, baby! we're going out to eat. — Catra looked at Melog. — You're not coming for this one buddy. You can have my bed for now. — Melog seemed happy enough as they went to the bedrooms.

Catra was still wearing her suit and that made her classy enough. Waiting for Finn was a battle of anxiety, not trying to think while her body was in overdrive got her claws and fur acting weirdly. As her child got ready, Finn even got their hair in a bun and wore something that was not shorts, their definition of fancy was simply putting on pants.

— Where are we going?

— A pirate theme restaurant. Is said to be legendary and there's some fire show that goes on too.

Finn ran to the car, Catra was glad it wasn't too far because her hunger was growing quite fast, Finn was so excited she was doing her best not show him how distressed she felt inside.

— Are there going to be swords?! — They said, eyes wide as if they had just thought about the possibility. — Mom, it's going to be unbelievably cool if they have swords!

Catra would never say out loud but she too wondered if there were going to be swords, she secretly had a thing for it, but her reasons were very distant from Finn's. The restaurant was in a boat, which made Catra reluctant as to being above water. But Finn, and possible swords made her go inside.

— Welcome to Sea-Hawks Paradise! — A very strong and theatrical voice shouted as they approached the bay. — Come in for a new palate adventure, find a different way to discover the sea. — The bright smile and the poses were a bit too much for Catra but Finn was loving it. — There. We have a table for two available, just around three. I'm Sea Hawk, the owner, the chef, the one who's going to be feeding you today. And of course I'll perform, be careful with the flames. Now, have a lovely evening.

As they were scort to their sit, they could see the stage also modeled to look like a boat, soon after some staff brought the menus, Finn didn't really care about the food after gluing their eyes to the play with pirates going on, all being as dramatic as the

owner. Catra picked for them both, they had similar tastes, although Finn wasn't very good with spices.

— Mom, I can't believe this. His husband is cheating?! — Catra didn't know what was going on with the play. — What! You can't just throw his wedding ring!

As time passed she only grew more confused over what was happening and it was too late to ask, but it served as an amazing distraction, the whole night did. The food, the crazy expression Finn made while watching the play, the ending with the promised flame show. Finn was over the moon when they got back home, tired, fed and with no energy for anything other than going to sleep.

Catra took her suit off slowly, valuing the alone time, the quiet, Melog was indeed at her bed, sleeping tight. As she got ready for a bath she started to shed her clothing, and as each piece fell to the ground she felt her emotional walls falling down too. Her ears fell flat as soon as she let herself breath deeply. Her claws were still out. A couple of years ago she would have probably destroyed an entire room just to lash out. She took another deep breath and stepped into the water, the warmth made her less shaky, she sat and sank, Catra let out the scream that had been trapped in her throat all night, the water hid the pained and hurt cry she unleashed. As she emerged the tears were all over her face, her sobbing was quiet, it had to be, Finn couldn't hear, she didn't want to worry them. She pulled her mane back, and finally relaxed against the bathtub as the tears silently fell down her face. She closed her eyes, she sniffed the air as if Adora's scent was going to be there, and it was, in her memory, her voice so much clear now, her face had changed, matured, her hair was big and so was her body. Seeing her on tv was a lot different than experiencing her in person. Catra hated how pitiful she felt, she wanted to hurt Adora, to make her feel ignored, abandoned, like nothing, exactly like she made Catra feel. Catra claws were out again and she let out a frustrated sigh. She had to control her impulses, she had learned to do so, she knew it and still Adora just brought the

worst out of her. How could she feel so much longing for somebody and loathe them at the same time?

X

— So…how was it? — Perfuma asked.

— I don't know…one minute she was very friendly and the other so distant and bitter. — Adora made a confused face. — I don't know if I said something wrong, I only apologized! — Perfuma didn't comment, Adora seemed to still be processing what happened and cutting her off wouldn't help. They walked around the garden again, walking was a great way to relieve anxiety and Adora needed it. — She looked so sad too. She told me that what I did had hurt her. She said she saw me on tv and we talked about what happened in the Fright Zone…I think she expected more from me? I don't know. But by the end of the conversation things weren't really optimistic, she doesn't want to see me anymore. She basically reduced our interactions to dropping and picking Finn.

— Maybe give her time?

— What if her time is never? — Adora's anxiety sometimes spoke before her. — She seemed so uninterested in me in general.

— I don't believe that's true if you said she saw you on tv, she can't find you uninterested and still know so much about you.

— I have so much I want to know about her. — Adora let out a frustrated sigh. — I guess it was naive of me to think we would just click automatically and talk for hours over a glass of wine.

— Give it time, be patient, be kind, and maybe that might still happen. — Perfuma pulled Adora into a hug. — I don't know Catra but I know you, and you are a good friend, you're a great teacher, and you can handle this, if your anxiety feels too overwhelming, remember to meditate, do the breathing exercises. Having her around even if you don't talk much might bring a lot back.

Adora nodded.

— Yeah. It kinda did, so much of our past together is blended with the traumas from the military school…it was a bit comforting too, to have someone who understands, who has been through the same as me. — Perfuma me smiled as she saw how open Adora was, no holding back. — Catra's child, they too made me feel a little back in time, they remind me so much of her, the version of her I knew. — Adora smiled as she talked about Finn. — I can't wait to spend more time with them. I'm glad she let them do the class.

— How did you feel when Catra said you had hurt her? — Adora looked pained at the question. — I know you already have been dealing with guilt. How did hearing you actually hurt her changed that?

— I feel like absolute garbage. — Adora let out. — Knowing I hurt her, it's like… a confirmation of one of my worst fears, knowing I still hurt her, it makes me feel so awful. — Adora suddenly burst into tears. — I'm sorry.

Perfuma held her as she cried, Adora couldn't handle her guilt, knowing she caused Catra pain, the person who was her only family for so long. It made everything taste bitter.

— It's okay, you don't have to apologize…just remember, you said it yourself, you forgive the actions of your younger self, what you did was the best you could do at the time, you were just a kid… now you have better tools to work with, you have grown, you're not the same person that hurt her and maybe is just a matter of showing it to her.

Adora didn't stop crying for a while, the cathartic release made her well enough for the class. She had hope to at least have a glance of Catra and then Finn entered alone. They had their uniform on and changed quickly for the class. Adora sucked it up and did what she did best. During class Finn struggled to pick their opponents up, something all of them struggled doing in the

beginning. The other kids were a little advanced thanks to being a couple of weeks ahead and still Finn was close behind, so they had nothing to be ashamed of

— You all are doing so good! Keep going. — The encouragement made all of them work harder. — That's it, you guys got it.

As Adora made her students sweat, Catra sat in a chair in her office, she figured working was the only way to not think about Adora. The building was almost empty, she didn't have much to do as she was waiting on Mermista and Scorpia, but there was plenty to be planned and organized.

— Catra?! — Glimmer's voice echoed in the room and this time Catra did jump in her chair. — What are you doing here? It's dark outside already and you shouldn't be here anymore, your shift ended at least two hours ago. I'm not getting sued for negligence when you're doing this because you want to!

Catra rolled her eyes.

— I just wanted to be a little ahead. That's all. — She shrugged.

— Get up and come with me. — Glimmer said as Catra glared at the demand. — Seriously, we need to close and go.

Catra needed to go anyway so she went willingly with Glimmer. They walked silently to the parking lot.

— See you at the meeting tomorrow. — Catra said as they got closer to their cars.

— Yeah, see you. And oh! Saturday me and some friends are going out, so if you want to meet some people and a bit of the city, Finn can come too, so no need to get a sitter. It's better than doing after hours. — Catra was caught by surprise, she didn't expect such an invitation from Glimmer. — Before you say no, think about it, tell me what you decide friday. — She had three days to think about it. — Good night, Catra.

— Night, Sparkles. — Going out with other people was something she had done…never. But knowing she could bring Finn did made the invite more appealing.

As she got back to the gym she saw some of the kids already leaving. Catra closed her eyes and took a deep breath as she realized her claws were out already. She needed to go inside, she would see Adora again, smell her again. Nothing was enough to truly calm her down but as she saw herself in the mirror she was contented with the non murderous look. Inside there were only a few kids left, Finn was chatting and barely noticed their mom, but after one sniffe they turned around to waved and signal for her to wait. Adora's scent was all over, and she couldn't ignore how safe it still made her feel, how calm she was, no longer needing to retract her claws. The scent got stronger as the blonde got closer. Catra waited next to the door, and to her surprise Adora didn't approach her, instead she gave her a small sad smile and went to talk to the kids.

Catra looked at them talking, Finn was so fired up, sweat all over, however the big bright smile stole the look. They were so happy there. Adora smiled genuinely at them too, it was so surreal to see them interacting. Finn finally was done talking and they waved bye, Adora waved back, and stole a glance at Catra with an apologetic smile. Saying it was easy to stand there and not talk to Catra would be the biggest lie, Adora was trying to follow Perfuma's advice. The lack of any type of response made Adora sighed deeply as they left. Give it time, she repeated to herself.

The worst part was at night. Even after such a long day her body was not quitting. Adora knew what was happening again, she had touched Catra, only a little, for a very small amount of time but the feeling in her hand was still there, the shadow of her warmth. Being touch starved was hard, seeing Catra and wanting to touch her so bad and not being able to, it physically hurt Adora. She felt her chest getting tight and breathing became harder by the second.

— Fuck! — Adora grunted. — Fuck, fuck, fuck!

She rolled on the bed. She tried to think about something good, something nice, something to not feel sad or anxious about. With Catra still in her mind, she started to focus on what she wore, how she looked, the maroon suit, the brown suit, her mane was big, she looked so grown, and Adora wouldn't lie, Catra looked sexy and elegant. It made her feel pathetic that she was now thirsting over the same person who made her hate herself for almost an entire day. Catra just always had Adora feeling all over the place. It didn't take much for Adora to feel an ache building in between her legs and the blush on her face could best tomatoes with how red she got. Another frustrated sigh came from her. Adora decided to think about anything that wasn't Catra. She went to sleep trying to figure out what to wear for her meet up with friends.

X

In the next few days things were similar. She went to lunch with Perfuma so their talks were shorter, Catra still wouldn't talk to her although she waved back as she left and that did get Adora's heart skipping a beat. Talking or not, just having her presence, knowing she would be there to pick Finn was good enough for the moment. Catra needed time and Adora could see that clearly, she noticed how Catra's ears would go flat a few seconds after entering the gym, she felt the glances, the hesitation in her eyes, the emotion behind it was as intense as what Adora felt.

Friday was a very special day for the gym, it was a moment the kids put on a little show, they fought in the ring, with a lot of rules included for safety, and a lot of protection pieces. Adora would even let them choose a song and make an entrance. She would usually do it at the end of the month but the kids wanted Finn to have their experience as soon as possible.

— You can sit here! — Finn grabbed their mom to sit in her place to watch them. — I'm gonna win for you!

Catra laughed at them, they made her promise to go and see them in the ring. All the kids were doing preparations around

Adora and in that moment it was hard to not acknowledge it, to not think of Adora as an amazing person was getting harder and harder. The week had been so draining, Catra had gotten so overworked, she did it to distract herself, even with Glimmer's complaints it just ended up being her solution. She didn't have time to go through some emotional crises while she took care of her child, her career, a new pet and such a big role in the rebuild of the Fright Zone. There's was no space for Adora, no space for her stupid grin, or her gorgeous hair, nor her amazing body and definitely not for her beautiful blue eyes. Catra didn't want to stare but as soon as she realized it, Adora was already looking back at her. Eye to eye. Breaking eye contact would mean she had lost the small exchange, she liked it, having Adora's eyes on her, it was almost too much to bear, she didn't look away, the moment Adora moved in Catra's direction she was stopped by one of the kids.

— Alright everyone! — Adora said aloud for all the parents there to hear — Let's hear a round of applause for The monstrous ice monstrosity! — Adora said into her fake mic, as a kid dressed as an ice monster got on to the ring, the little girl even did a little dance. — Also known as Frosta. — Everyone cheered loudly for her. — Against the Mighty Ferret! — A kid dressed as a ferret got on the ring and they too got a wave of loud cheers.

Adora put all the necessary protection on both and hit the bell. Frosta won quite fast, it made Catra impressed. The next fights were more balanced, the kids were good, Catra smiled through the whole thing. And when Finn walked in as The Super Cat she laughed hard. They fought well, they were fast and had amazing reflexes. Catra cheered hard, screamed and was jumping when they won. The rest of the fights went by and the night was full of laughs and bright smiles. It just made it harder to not admire Adora, she did that, the whole thing, she made Finn smile like that, how could Catra not recognize that? Not praise her for it? She got up when the kids went to change and most parents had already talked to her. Catra got closer slowly, Adora turned when she sensed the feline behind her, eyes wide when she saw it was Catra.

— Hi. — Adora risked. — Finn did really great.

— Yes, they did. — She smiled. — So did you, they have been so happy with your classes and today was like the Oscars for them, you know. — Adora couldn't believe they were having a conversation. — Thank you for that.

Adora blushed, she hated not having control over it.

— I-I…thanks. — She opened and closed her mouth several times without being able to say something. — I'm happy they're liking it.

Talking about Finn was the safest route, the one she knew Catra wouldn't tried to run from.

— They broke a lamp, training at home, so it's not all flowers and rainbows. — Adora laughed. — You owe me a lamp, Adora. — The playfulness made Adora's heart full, and hearing Catra say her name gave her a full body goosebump.

— I promise to pay. — The hesitation on Adora was palpable. — You did a great job as a mom. — Catra took the compliment while holding back tears, suddenly overwhelmed with Adora's words and presence. — They're so kind and funny. — Adora wanted to reach out and hug Catra. — They remind me of you, a lot.

As one tear escaped Catra's eye she turned away from Adora. She hated how easily Adora brought her walls down, a couple of minutes and she was already tearing up. As Catra and Finn left Adora didn't look away from Catra, no smile, only concern and doubt. Unsure of what they were to each other, unsure of what they could be but with hope that they at least were something.

Deja Vu

Chapter Notes

> Tigger warning for child abusive. Nothing extremely graphic but still heavy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

18 Years Ago

Adora's ears were sick of hearing boots against the mud, stomping already echoed in her mind even when she slept. Catra didn't find herself in a very different position, so she decided to put her feet in front of Adora's, making the blonde fall over creating a domino effect that led everyone in front of her to fall too. Almost everyone got out of line. Catra handled her laughter and Adora looked absolutely terrified and confused. She glared at Catra and the feline laughed.

— In line soldiers! — Adora got up and was back in line as fast as she could. — Another silly trick and none of you will eat for a week. — Catra rolled her eyes but did as told.

The rest of the training went as demanding as always. They all did their best as they knew whoever went last would have to clean the bathrooms, a rule they implement to make the kids more competitive. Catra won like always, Adora was a sweat messy behind her. And Kyle was going to clean the bathroom again. None of them care for that rule but if he didn't, Shadow Weaver would find something a lot worse for him to do. Things were all designed there to be a competition, they didn't want the kids to feel like a family, or even friends. As they walked back to their dorms they saw their ranking right above the entrance. Adora was first thanks to her grades, Catra second, they were always the ones on top, although it didn't bring much sense of pride for Adora, Catra did love gloating and that raking made her insufferable.

School started early and training was the rest of their days, nothing else, no fun, and only one day of rest each month. For Adora and Catra and most orphans born in the Fright Zone that was all they knew. Nothing other than studying and training. They had frequent visits from the Horde, gun training, bomb training, at the age 5 they both knew how to assembled a bomb. Adora had always been good even when she didn't want to be, Catra had to try, to survive there and not suffer with harsh punishment she needed to do good. Shadow Weaver always got her the worst punishments every single time she made a mistake, a week in solitary, with bare minimum food and water. No talking to anyone, no sunlight. Being 9 and stuck in such small dark space, it was something she would never forget, Shadow Weaver had imagined it would make her compliant however it did the opposite, Catra stared pranking a lot after that, started lashing out, never really confronting Shadow Weaver the way she truly wanted to, but she was good, the only student to have only gold stars on stealth, she never got caught. No proof against her and the few times she did get caught, Adora would plead for anything but solitary. Catra ended up cleaning a lot of rooftops and bathrooms, and she would frequently lose meals. She could never forget how much Adora fought for her, sneaking her food, letting her sleep on her bed. They wouldn't be able to survive without each other.

— You could've gotten us in trouble! — Adora said when they were alone. — You know Shadow Weaver is just waiting for one single mistake to punish you.

— Let her! I'll be out of what she puts me in and do even worse. — Catra laughed. — She can't do anything, not really. Not while I'm in second. Punishing her second best student doesn't look good to her bosses. She never punishes you, ever wonder why? — Catra lift her eyebrows at Adora.

— Because I never do anything to be punished for. — Catra rolled her eyes.

— Yeah, but also because you're her golden child, the perfect little soldier. She can't punish the one that makes this place look like it

works for anyone from outside that comes in here. You're her propaganda, the showcase that this works. And I'm good! And her number one from time to time, she can't punish me for the same reasons she doesn't punish you. — Adora took in all of Catra's words.

— I still think you need to be careful. You know how crazy cruel she can get…and I don't want to see you hurt. — Catra hugged Adora from behind.

— You won't. — Catra said smiling. — I promise.

X

Adora woke up before the alarm, she took a deep breath as she saw the same roof over her head. The comforting purring made her break a little smile, she tried not to move to not wake Catra. Adora had been extremely measurable, maybe her entire life, no freedom, no control over her future whatsoever, no sense of personality or who she was or what she wanted to do, and to think she would need to wait until she was an adult to have those things made her shrink inside herself. It was getting so bad she ended up sent to the med bay because of a severe anxiety developing. She told no one about the incident, no one but she and the nurse knew what had happened in her last rank drop.

— It's like I can hear you think. — Catra suddenly spoke. — You get so still and you don't breathe, it's creepy. — Adora realized that she was truly holding her breath. — What is it?

— Just…this place. — Adora sighed.

— Give a couple of year, we'll be out of here. Leaving together and finally making this city a proper city! We are gonna rule the Fright Zone!

— And I thought you hated monarchies.

— Not when I'm in charge. — She said getting cuddly with Adora. — it's just another day, you'll survive.

Adora nodded. The alarm rang and the grumpy voices echoed together right after it. Breakfast was fast and quiet, the classes were long and quiet, the day was a big drag till training started. They were doing matches, no rules, except for two, the first was the weapons, who ever got them first could keep it, another incentive on competition.

— When you hear the bell you run to get your weapon. Return, wait in line until your name is called.

The bell ringed and they all ran, Catra took a whip, Adora managed to get a sword and they both bolted out of there, no one would tried to get it from them. There were not enough weapons for all of them, it was on purpose of course. Getting back in line, they both watched as the other kids fought each other, no mercy, the second rule was no murder so they had a line to not cross, anything else could happen. It was the day they all ended with injuries.

— Catra. — The feline went for the mat, whip ready for action. — Adora. — They exchange a conflicted look.

They had to fight. Trying to avoid it would just end up in harsh punishment. Adora didn't want to. She hesitated as she walked to mat, Catra's tail twitched as they got in position.

— No holding back! — The teacher scream at them.

And Adora saw it, the moment Catra's eyes changed, they were doing it, no going back. The bell ringed and not one minute one by before Catra whip was going towards Adora's leg. The easiest and fastest way to do it was to get one of them on the ground. Catra didn't anticipate the blonde's fast reflexes to take action. Adora bolted forward jumping closer to Catra, using the butt of her sword to attack. Catra held it with her hands, kicking Adora's middle section to push her back, Catra's knee took a groan out of the human, and the following punch almost knocked her out. Catra didn't know who to explain, but fighting truly brought the worst out of her, she wanted to win, to hurt Adora, to see her

friend on the ground, it was an instinct, she wasn't Adora's friend, she was her opponent at that moment and only that. Before Catra could attack again Adora used her sword, she swung once and Catra swerved, the second time was faster, the third swung in her direction and faltered Catra's balance, and the fourth took part of her fur. She screamed as she duck down and went for a high kick, Adora held the sword with one hand so the other could block the blow coming for her head, Catra took the opportunity to whip Adora's hand making her drop the sword at the impact. Adora screamed in pain, the other tried a new kick and this time Adora stepped back only to try and kicked Catra lower and make her fall. Adora needed to make her yield or the fight wasn't done, but Catra got up as soon as she touched the ground, turning fast and using the proximity to use her claws, her right hand slash Adora's abdomen and the other took her by the throat as a low growl settled on her throat, her claws piercing the human's flesh, blood underneath her claws. Adora tapped out.

— Very good. — Shadow Weaver's voice got all of them to turn and look at her. — it seems you're not a lost cause after all, Catra. — The feline finally looked back at Adora, her hands still choking the girl, her ears went immediately flat, terrified of her own actions, she let go. The concern settling in. — Take her to the med bay.

Catra nodded and before she could say anything Adora was already walking. The pain was bad, but the fact Catra did that to her was even worse. She was confused, how could Catra do that to her? She noticed how mortified Catra looked as she saw the blood minutes after the fight was done. She didn't understand her sometimes, she knew Catra was complicated, and yet that violence as if Adora was just anyone, not her best friend, not her family, just an opponent, an obstacle to be destroyed, it took a shiver out of her.

— Adora! Wait! — Adora kept her hands over her neck, trying not to bleed too much. — Let me help. — Catra tried approaching. Adora got scared as Catra got closer. — I won't hurt you.

Adora kept walking, still not sure on how to feel by letting Catra walk besides her. Still they got to the med bay. Adora got checked, Catra waited outside the room, worried sick, getting eaten alive by her guilt and shame.

— See, it's not all bad. Now I get two free days this month. — Adora tried on her best smiles. — Don't worry too much. I'm fine.

— Stop trying to make me feel good! I hurt you Adora! Can't you see that! Be mad at me! — Catra lashed out scaring Adora. — Why is it so hard for you to be mad?! I fucking choked you…I made you bleed. And for what? Those fuckers?! — The question was more to herself than Adora.

— I attacked you too. — Adora said. — I don't know why. I didn't want to. — Speaking hurt and her pained expression didn't go unnoticed. — We are both…like this…because of them. — Catra knew Adora was right.

— It doesn't erase what I did to you. — Catra didn't know where to put her hands so she decided to rest them on Adora's shoulders. — I don't know what goes inside of me sometimes. — Catra leaned in. — I'm sorry. — She whispered.

Adora could count on her fingers the amount of times she had heard Catra say those words. It truly meant something. They rested their foreheads against each other, and stood there for a while.

— It's okay, I'm okay. — Adora whispered.

The look they exchanged after breaking apart was different than any other before, neither really knowing what to feel about it. Adora felt a small blush growing and Catra tail played with the little bit of skin Adora had showing in her belly, Adora had never seen Catra's pupils big like that. She couldn't tell if she was about to be attacked or kissed. In the end neither came, the dorm's lights were turned off and they silently went to sleep. They both

had a lot in their minds but nothing was louder than the beating of their hearts. Catra slept closer to Adora that night.

The pain in the morning was a lot more permanent than the day before, everything was aching, it felt a like a pulse, Adora needed to clean her wounds. She got up extremely early, so much so Catra was deep as sleep even after Adora moved. All the medical suplies were put in Adora's locker room because the med bay couldn't stay open all the time, and almost nothing was allowed in the dorms. So she got the first aid kit in a safe locked place. Adora had imagined nobody would be up, but a big truck was parked right next to the locker room, she couldn't help but hear the conversation going on.

— We are delivering this to Brightmoon today, and the next shipment is going to be in a week. If everything goes smoothly we might do a more frequent shipment. It's going to be a nice paycheck. — Adora frowned. Not really knowing what was going on with the conversation.

She rushed inside to do what she set out to do. She decided to bathe first, it was not always she could do it with nobody around. Cleaning the wounds made her hiss and that made her abdomen clenched and that made it a lot more painful. So Adora had to keep her cool. Make sure she was breathing slowly despite the immense pain. She was used to it, she couldn't think about a time where her body didn't hurt in some part, ignoring the pain was her default mode.

X

Catra looked around the cafeteria and saw Adora eating alone. It was weird not having her around for the second day, her wounds kept bleeding through her shirt so she got a second day of rest. At least the neck was okay already. She was not supposed to be there, Catra was supposed to be training her aim, she was good, she didn't really need that training and seeing Adora was a much better activity. The gloomy expression was something new, Catra had never seen Adora looking so down.

— Hey, Adora. — The blonde looked up at her terrified. — Chill out. I'm the stealth master, remember?

— Why can't you just…— Adora sighed. — Nevermind…miss me too much? — The grin made Catra eye roll.

Before Catra could speak, Shadow Weaver entered the room and Adora got up in position, Catra followed suit, her tail between her legs.

— What are you doing here, subordinate? — She stopped behind Catra. — I don't remember you getting hurt.

— I'm not, sir.

— I'm sensing your loyalty is not in the right place. Adora is not and should never be more important than the military. Do you understand?— Catra nodded. — I said, do you understand!?

— Yes, sir! — Adora faced forward the entire time.

— You're dismissed. Back to training, you get two extra hours.

As Catra walked back, Adora was left alone eating again. Everything was awful, she felt awful, and seeing the way Shadow Weaver talked to Catra made her so angry, she felt so powerless but not as much as Catra did. Catra was furious, her outlet ended up being the target in front of her. She kept on shooting when everyone else went to shower, she was still shooting when everyone had dinner. And by the end she couldn't even eat, the cafeteria was closed. She could still shower. Catra was counting the days to be 18 and finally out of there, she and Adora would go and put all that behind them together, those thoughts were the only thing keeping her sane. She decided to not shower, her fur would not dry fast enough to go to bed, so she cleaned herself by getting a towel wet and going through her fur as best as possible. Not the same but it was something. She went back to the dorms with a growling stomach and no way to getting something to eat. The lights were out, she had good night vision and found her way easily, but it showed her how late it truly was and how little sleep

she would get. As she got closer to her bed Adora's scent got stronger, she loved it, every bit of it was so pure, addicting even.

— Catra? — A whisper in the darkness.

— Hey. — She said back, exhausted. — I gave her more headshots than anyone ever in this crap! — She whispered angrily.

— I grabbed this. — Adora shifted in bed and got Catra a handful of biscuits. — Was the only thing that fitted in my pockets.

Catra ate them in silence. Her body still craved more but it was something.

— Thank you. — Adora smiled big. — Don't give me that look, it won't ever happen again. — She lightly pushed Adora.

— You're welcome. — Adora laughed. — I heard something yesterday…— Catra got closer sitting almost on top of Adora's thighs. — About a shipment going to Brightmoon. — She whispered. — I think they are shipping guns.

— Who cares about Brightmoon, they are a bunch of princesses, full of money, they don't care about us, why should I care? — Catra said dismissing Adora's statement as something of importance.

— You're probably right.

Adora didn't let it go. Too curious, too nosy, she wanted to know why there was a shipment going to Brightmoon. Her conspiracy only grew by the day and a new idea too. Adora started to plan on escaping, sneaking in the truck and going to Brightmoon. She tried to share with Catra but everytime she brought it up the other would shush her. Catra truly hated Brightmoon, all the power and they never once came to the Fright Zone rescue, never once cared to help. Adora kept on trying, and the day was getting closer.

— What are you doing? — Catra took Adora by surprise as she was creeping to try to see where the secure cameras were. — We finally have a day off and you're staring at trees?

— I'm…planning an escape. — Adora said. Catra laughed, loud. — Is not a joke. And I want you to come with me.

— Where? — Catra was still giggling. — To the solitary? That's not how it works. You're always telling me to behave and now you want to escape? How?

— I told you. The truck.

— You don't think they will check? — Catra challenged.

— They didn't the last time. — Adora kept on taking notes for her plan. — They won't have a reason this time, so I don't think they will.

— You can't be serious. Brightmoon, Adora. — The feline was frustrated. — It's fucking Brightmoon, why would want to go there?

— Because anywhere it's better than here, Catra. — That got the feline to be quiet. — I don't understand why you don't see this.

Catra's tail was down, her ears flat. Adora knew there was something more about Brightmoon the other wasn't telling her.

— I'm not going! — She said finally. — Fuck Brightmoon! I rather stay here.

— Catra…come with me. We are going to have so many opportunities. So much more than this! Is our way out.

— Why can't you just wait! — She almost screamed. — Just 4 more years, what's that compared to what we already have been through, nothing! We're so close. — They looked into each other's eyes. — Just 4.

— I can't do it. — Adora could feel the tears coming but she held strong. All the pent up frustration boiling inside of her, her lack of freedom, the constant belittling, the pain, so much pain, four more years of that would destroy her. — You can't ask me to say here! *There's nothing here for me! Nothing!* — She shouted.

Catra shrink, scared, hurt, angry. How could Adora say that? How could she not see the future they could have together? The one Catra saw so clearly, so tenderly. How could she say she had nothing there with Catra standing right in front of her. Without a word Catra turned and walked out, she didn't look back.

X

Catra didn't sleep with her again, didn't talk, they ate separately, glances were stolen but no words exchanged, they saw each other training, they thought about each other 24/7. They had never drifted apart like that, they had never spent more than 5 hours without talking. Catra was hurting, feeling abandoned by her friend, and she didn't know any other way to deal with it so she ignored Adora, she pretended she didn't care if she left or stay, she had never trained so hard, never been so merciless while fighting, and still none of it made it hurt less. It hurt Adora, deeply. And when the day arrived. And Catra didn't appear, Adora cried. And as she executed her plan she hesitated every step of the way, as if waiting for Catra to join her at any given moment. When Adora stepped on the truck, there were no take backs. She was leaving Catra, her best friend, her only family, the only constant she truly knew her entire life. What kind of a person was she?

X

She didn't really know what to expect when the truck was opened. The minute it happened she jumped out of the truck and dash out there, the yelling coming from behind made her run even faster, entering the first place she saw as a good hiding place. She did her best to blend in. The big shelves were something like she had never seen, everything was pretty and colorful, the walls were

painted with purple and gold. Adora gasped. The amount of books around her made her head spin, never had she seen such big collections. She didn't even imagine there were that many genres of books. Blending in was easy. She took every single book that caught her eyes and brought them to a table to read through. They were so different, so many stories. But one got her there for hours. Reading almost everything.

— She's amazing right? — A voice came from behind her. — I read that one a bazillion times. — Adora looked like a scary cat. And the girl with the glitter shirt didn't seem to mind. — She is one of my role models. — Adora looked at the picture of Mara guiding a protest. — She was relentless…I'm Glimmer by the way. Who are you?

— Adora. — She said, trying no to seem too suspicious.

— So, what's up with your outfit. — Adora looked down, military school uniform. The scared look made Glimmer realize right away Adora was in some kinda of trouble. — Come with me.

Before any word were said they were out of there. Adora followed Glimmer, trusting the girl was her best option, but still she looked around to see if the guards were anywhere near.

— Where are you taking me? — Adora said in an almost scream.

— Taking you? You're not a hostage. — Glimmer looked at her. — But look. You're wearing military clothes and I see you need help. The thing is, just the fact that you're here in Brightmoon means something is wrong. — They stopped in the middle of the street, — And I know someone who'll definitely want to meet you.

Adora could tell Glimmer meant business, which was surprising considering she was a teenager and from Brightmoon. Adora decided to trust her. Soon enough they reached a place Adora didn't expect, the President Palace, it was big and extremely elegant.

— What are we doing here? — Adora asked as they entered the space. Every corner was well decorated, nothing looked out of place, all the frames had beautiful landscapes.

— We're going to see my mom. — Adora was confused to say the least. — Come on.

She grabbed Adora's hand and they walked past a handful of people doing their job. It function so fluidly that Adora felt like an intruder there. As they reached the president's office, Adora's hands got sweaty. Two security guards look at them, mostly at Adora.

— Who's this? — The one on in the right asked Glimmer.

— A friend. — She said simply and entered the room. Adora followed, confused.

A meeting was happening. Adora blushed quite immediately as everyone stared at them.

— Glimmer?! — A tall beautiful woman stood staring down at Glimmer with a disapproving glare. — What's this all about now?

—Look! — She pointed at Adora. — I told you the Horde was sending something here! I told you! She's proof! I saw it, they went to that mansion where Entrapta lives! Something is happening! — Glimmer said with excitement.

— Who are you? And where are you from? — The direct question made Adora's palms sweat even more. Angella knew how to be intimidating without needing too much.

— A-Adora…the Fright Zone, military school. — Adora looked at the shining eyes Glimmer was giving her. — She's right, some shipments with guns are coming here, I don't know if they're going to keep coming.

— I'll take a look at it…shouldn't you be at school Glimmer? — The brightness went away from her eyes, Glimmer took Adora's

hands and ran from there.

They laughed as they walked out of the palace.

— Hey, do you have anywhere to stay? — Glimmer asked. — You can crash at mine. It's really huge, my mom would have a bunch of questions but she will eventually say yes.

As Glimmer spoke all that came to her mind was how different she was to the portrayal Catra had made of the people of Brightmoon.

— I don't think I have anything to pay you.

— Don't care about that. — Glimmer shrugged. And gave Adora a side hug. —You are going to help pay Entrapta a little visit.

— But your mom, the president, said she's going to take care of it. — Adora said confused.

— Yeah, but not fast enough. So we'll go.

As Glimmer started planning her breaking and entering one of her mom's security guards approached them.

— You're going home, Miss Glimmer. I'm your escort. — Before Glimmer could go for another run she got grabbed by the collar. — Let's go. Your mother's orders.

Things escalate quickly after that. Adora and Glimmer did go home, and soon enough Bow joined them, and things clicked for the three of them, they talked for hours, Bow gave Adora a million book recommendations, Glimmer talked about ending the Horde non-stop. Adora laughed and smiled a lot that day, even though part of her was still hurting, she had freedom. Soon enough they found out that Entrapta was the one getting weapons to disabled them and try to use their parts for one of her projects, being underage meant shouldn't have been able to get the weapons in the first place so it got shut down by Angella. It brought relief to everyone to know it was nothing serious.

Soon enough Adora had found a rhythm, and a purpose. Going to school with regular rules, being able to eat and talk, and interact, she met a lot of great people and made friends easily. She became a regular of the local museum, Light Hope was her guide there and she learnt a lot, about so many different cultures, and about Mara, and activism, a new passion that only grew as she got to meet with Razz, a woman who had been there with Mara, trying to defend the planet. She visited her frequently, learnt a lot, and took so much advice. She still had a long way to go, a lot to unlearn. Things weren't perfect, she missed Catra every day, she struggled sometimes with letting go of military habits, she called Angella sir all the time. Even though she struggled, she was building a life, and that was all she ever wanted to be able to do.

X

— Where is she!? — Shadow Weaver had Catra by the neck. — Tell me!

— I don't know. — She said for the fifth time.

— Your loyalty to her is pointless! She left you here! Just like your parents. — Catra gulped. — You're nothing but Brightmoon's trash, they knew you were not good enough to grow up there, that's what they do, when they don't want us, they just throw us here, like trash. Adora thinks she's better than you, and you know what…she is right. — She pulled Catra by the hair and threw her in solitary. — Let's see if by the end of the week you won't know where Adora is.

As the door got closed and darkness settled in. Catra lashed out, she screamed, cried, her claws made a mess of the walls. She did it until she couldn't anymore, till her body collapsed on the cold floor. Her claws were bleeding, her hunger settling in, she spent 3 days like that. Without no one checking, no food, no water. 3 days of punishment she didn't deserve, of so much pain she couldn't stand up when they dragged her out of there. And still she said nothing. She hated Adora for what she had done, but she hated Shadow Weaver a thousand times over.

A week after that they let her off the hook. All she was left with was anger, she trained hard, no one took her from the first place, she had broken the bones of almost all of her opponents and they never talked to her, she became bloodthirsty during the matches and almost feral. It took so much strength to go through 4 years of that, the loneliness she faced, the isolation she put herself in to make sure no one could even abandon her again. And when she was finally out of there, she didn't know what to do. Where to go, how to live life like a normal person, and she barely had a foundation for that in the state her city was, everything was in shambles. Being lost, confused, abandoned. She was no longer in Shadow Weavers chains, and she felt like she had nowhere to go but back there. She almost spent her first night out of the military school in the streets. What saved her was a sign for a job to serve tables, where she met Scorpia. It was a rough start, they became roommates, Catra was an asshole all the way through in the beginning to make sure they wouldn't become close, to protect herself, and somehow Scorpia didn't leave her side. They both got enough money to go to college. As Catra so forcefully went to therapy things changed very drastically. She realized how important making the Fright Zone home was for her, she soon began to try and forgive Adora, she did better, learned different outlets that weren't violent, even tried yoga. Soon she had a nice job with rebuilding homes in the Fright Zone, it was a joint company with Scorpia, it expanded and she decided to adopt when she turned 26, Finn was a no brainer. They both needed to see themselves as not the last of their kind. They both needed each other, to not he alone anymore. And as the pollution got worse Catra and Scorpia knew they needed external help, Glimmer's company had almost the same goal as theirs so they decided to work together.

It took time, it took effort, but Catra healed. She still had all the scars in and out to prove she didn't live an easy life. She still had stuff to figure out, being a mom came easily, being a businesswoman fit her like a glove. But love, love was something neither she or Adora ever figured out.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry there's no Finn in this one. They'll be back in the next qkajshr

Phantom Syndrome

Socializing, not a skill Catra had developed well, her entire childhood she only had one friend, and during adulthood she also only had one friend, so she knew she was lacking in that department. She was happy her child was doing better than her at that. She just had felt so overwhelmed by Adora, that maybe going out would do her some good, something out of comfort zone, something new to try. She looked at herself in the mirror, trying on something a little sexy, a dark red button up shirt tucked inside her black pants, with a very elegant roll in the end, to show a bit of her lower leg.

— You look nice. — Finn said. — You should undo some of those buttons though. — Catra arched a brow at them. — What! I have a good sense of style.

They were still over the moon after the match, riding that high with pride. It had been a rollercoaster of emotions for Catra, who was still processing all of it, what it meant, what it reminded her of. Adora putting all of those rules, and protection, brought her right back to their upbringing, to the moment her claws met her flesh. Adora kept on surprising her. All the feline truly wanted was a conversation, an honest one, no hurt feelings in the way and yet every time they saw each other Catra felt so empty and sad, the worst of the worst came to her mind and than Adora would just smile, just give one the kids a nice pet and part of that melted away. Catra didn't know how to speak to her without lashing out yet.

— Alright. Style genius. — The amount of fur shown wasn't inappropriate, however it was sexy. — Are you ready?

— Yeah! — Finn decided to wear a dress, it was full of different types of flowers printed on it and to match the look, a flower crown. They looked pretty. — Can we go already? I'm hungry.

— Yeah…me too. — Catra states.

She felt a lot more present, her mind no longer lingered around Adora, or her past, she only thought about the dinner party, what to wear. Making sure Finn really wanted to go. The only thing worrying her the night was presenting Finn to other people, her child didn't know a lot of people, mainly because in the Fright Zone there weren't a lot of people to know, thanks to the Horde. So growing up Finn had temporary friends, they would always move out at some point, and Finn would be very understanding of the situation, although their away of lashing out was isolation, nothing got thrown around or broke, just silence. Something Catra had to fight her way in, talking to them sometimes didn't work so the way was to play together, Finn loved playing dress up, giving styling types seemed to be one of their favorite things, getting ready became their bonding time. Glimmer had promised her a kid space for them, if they had puzzles for them to solve everything would be good and then all she would be left with was good regular social anxiety.

They got there fast, traffic in Brightmoon was pretty neat. She kinda wanted something to hate on, but as she lived there, it was a hard struggle to find reasons to hate it there. Nice school, it was safe, no pollution, no traffic, people were nice, Finn liked it. All the past trauma and resentment about the place were thankfully in the past, even if a little grudge still lived inside of her it wasn't nearly as bad as before. She had accepted the new house, had gotten along with people from Brightmoon, she was still wary of some, but most were okay. She imagined she would feel like she didn't belong there, like a wrong puzzle piece sticking out, it didn't feel like that though, she was adapting, like she always did.

— Mom…do you think I could…— Finn started talking and Catra had never seen them drift like that, it worried her. — Nevermind.

— What is it?! — Her fur was almost standing up, seeing them in any type of distress got her to feel the same. — Spit it out. — She said more playfully.

— I talked to some kids. And they think I'm very good, and there's a tournament, a real one…trophies and all that…they want

me to represent our team. — Shy, they weren't distressed, they were shy, Catra never saw them being shy, they had been such a strong kid from the beginning, so ready to take on the world all the time. It showed her it mattered to them, so it mattered to her. — It's okay if you don't want me to.

— It's a little early. — She had a half smile that wouldn't go away. — But we can see, we need to know the dates, where it is gonna happen, the rules, if it is safe. All of that. And you need training. — They nodded.

— Teacher could help. — The mention of Adora didn't make her extremely uncomfortable, but it still did, although she thought the same. — She's good, like real good. She could prepare me, and maybe I could even win…I know it's only been a week. But I had so much fun, mom! And I know I can do this.

— I'll think about it…I promise. — She gave them a little snuggled. — But now food.

She took the last turn to park. Everything was beautiful from the get go, as they took the stairs to the rooftop the path was illuminated by very simple but beautiful lights, it led them to a open space with lots of flowers all over, the illuminating was dim, but not too much and for both of them that wouldn't have been a problem. Finn was in awe as they walked a brick path to see everyone at a big dining table, and beside it there was a little area with some board games. The illumination being a lot brighter, candles and flowers decorated the table making it very welcoming.

— Catra. — Glimmer said, smiling big as she went to hug the Feline, who didn't exactly return the hug, more or less simply stood still. — And you must be Finn. — Her child ignored Glimmer's hand to go for a hug. — Oh, I like you. We're going to be friends. Come, let's meet everyone.

— Come on, mom. — Finn took Catra's hands, making her relax a bit. — The food smells amazing.

She took a sniff and soon after that her mouth was watering. Finn basically dragged her around as they introduced themselves and Catra to everyone, Glimmer helped with the mingling a little, the older feline took mental notes to smile back every once and a while. Mermista was there, and dated the guy from the restaurant, she also met Bow, a lady named Perfuma who she would never forget the smell of, she had never smelled something so nature like, almost as if she was the woods itself. Finn at some point got off with a girl she thought she had seen before, but couldn't quite put her finger on where. They sat side by side, they mostly made funny faces for each other than talked. She sat between Glimmer and Mermista, they had work stuff to talk about at least so it made Catra less anxious. Bow was a very bright presence, and she noticed how he tried to hide how much he wanted to pet her. They all were focused on Sea-Hawk who was telling a pirate story, one Catra was sure was one of his scripts. She noticed one chair being empty.

— I'm glad you came. — Glimmer whispered to her. — You have been doing so much. I thought you needed a night to chill out. — She smiled at Catra.

— You're probably right.

— I almost forgot to tell you…Mermista has almost figured out how to clean the water in a faster but still efficient way. — Glimmer whispered even lower. — It's tricky though. Entrapta is not an easy person, and she might or might not have a shared past with the horde, but it's minor! — Said Glimmer with a little desperation before Catra could contradict her. — We really need her, Catra.

— Please tell me you're not talking business, my love. — Bow gave Glimmer a disapproving look. — We are celebrating, no work talk.

— Yeah, no work talk. — Mermista got in with Bow.

Catra didn't really wanted to do work either, but what Glimmer said definitely left a sour taste in her mouth.

— We talk Monday. — Catra responded finally.

— How long are we going to wait before eating, it's going to get cold. — Mermista whined.

— She's almost here. — Glimmer said glaring at Mermista. — Just wait a little.

— We can just have Sea-hawk setting the food on fire so it's not cold anymore. — Bow joked.

Sea-hawk didn't hear him because the pirate was still telling his tales, only the two kids paid attention to him.

— I know she's your best friend and all, but microwaving one place is better than the whole table so I vote no to waiting. — Catra was enjoying the no sense bantering. Although she didn't know who they were waiting for.

— Can you guys please just relax, enjoy the night, look at how beautiful the stars are, she's going to be here soon enough. — Perfuma's statement received a nod from Bow, an eye roll from Mermista and a very conflicted look from Glimmer. — Be nice.

— You send your daughter to beat up other kids, but we have to relax. — Mermista said joking and received an almost disapproving look from Perfuma. — Your daughter is scary.

— It's a safe space for her to unleash all the pent up anger. — Perfuma said. — And you're just being annoying. — Mermista nodded yes to that and laughed.

— Sorry, I'm late everyone. — Catra was left speechless as Adora entered. — I lost my ke-ys. — Adora saw Catra and didn't know what to do.

Adora was wearing a dress, showing her strong arms with her hair down, it was white with golden flowers in a mid thigh length. Catra had never seen so much cleavage or bare leg from Adora before, it took her a minute to understand her reaction, maybe the reason she was speechless wasn't necessarily just about the fact it was Adora.

— Took you long enough! — Mermista screamed. — Let's eat.

— Yeah, come on, Adora. — Glimmer said.

Adora sat beside Frosta, who greeted her with a fist, and Finn did the same. Things were feeling slightly awkward, Catra knew Glimmer and Adora were friends, but didn't realize they were close friends, she didn't really know anything about Adora's life other than the fact she was teaching her child, everything else, her dating life, friends, family, she didn't know any of it. For the first time in a long time Catra wondered, realizing she was too afraid to do so before. To think about how much Adora's life was better without her was a habit she had long abandoned and after it, even after meeting Adora again, she didn't think about it, about how she's now, only about what she did, about who she remembered Adora being.

It was clear Adora was older and responsible, much so Catra felt comfortable leaving Finn with her. The anxiety was still there, but she didn't look sad, or frustrated, she looked like she belonged, like she could finally relax.

— You don't like the food?! — Sea-hawk made Catra get out of her head.

— Sorry. No, there's nothing wrong. — As food was mentioned her hunger returned.

They all ate while most of them talked. Adora was panicking, she didn't speak, keeping her mouth as full as her mind, she would never have imagined Catra being there, ever, Glimmer didn't say anything. She wanted to kick her friend on the butt, at least

Perfuma was already there, and seemed to have made the connections needed as they both kept exchanging looks. Finn was engaging in all conversations, Adora couldn't help but envy the kid. Adora wondered how damaging her presence alone probably was, after thinking back, after their conversations Adora felt like salt in an open wound to Catra, and as someone who got hurt a lot, she knew how much that hurt.

— Teacher. — Finn's voice got Adora's attention. — Can you talk to my mom. — Adora's eyes automatically locked with Catra's. — She wants to know more about the competition.

— You're lucky I can't go, mom thinks I'll be too competitive and hurt my opponents. She's probably right. — Frosta was a lot more approachable when eating.— But Finn should definitely do it, they would be so great.

Adora needed to get her food more often she realized. Her response to Finn was a thumb's up, not trusting to not sound awkward. She thought about Perfuma's advice, she needed to give Catra space, but it was about Finn, Catra seemed very open to do that, it had worked before. The anxiety was showing as her hands started to shake a little. Adora silently did one of her breathing exercises and thought about how to talk to Catra.

— So Catra, tell us a little about you? — Bow asked, hopeful he'll get a positive reaction. — All I know is you're very passionate about the Fright Zone.

— She's also my mom. — Finn added. — And very good at cooking…and she's pretty, today more handsome.

Catra was stunned, Finn got her to blush under the fur.

— What does she do that's tasty? — Bow and Finn decided Catra was no longer there with them.

— Fish! Cookies, and…mom what's that food you like so much? — Everyone at the table turned to look at Catra. — She's very good at cooking. What's the name of the one Scorpia loves? — Adora

tried her best to keep her poker face, trying not to wonder who was Scorpia.

— It's just…vegan wings and salad. — She said humbly.

— Oh I love vegan wings! — Perfuma got into the conversation.

After that things went pretty smooth, Catra didn't do much talking, Adora laughed at the jokes Mermista made. They exchanged looks now and then, keeping everything civil. When the plates were all empty Adora decided it was the best time to talk about the competition, the problem was, she didn't know how to approach Catra. The kids insisted on the boards games. So they did that so her talking got delayed.

— I can't not believe you're winning! — Glimmer glared Frosta. — Your moves make no sense!

— No, they're just too advanced for your little brain, shimmer. — Glimmer gave Frosta her tongue.

— She's a child, Glimmer. — Bow remind her.

Most of them were out beast by Frosta. Finn, Catra and Sea-hawk found a pirate theme game and Mermista just liked laughing at the losers. So she asked Perfuma to go with her for a walk to see the view, she needed help.

— Catra's here! — She let out a panicked squeal. — What the fuck do I do!?

Perfuma took her hands.

— First, breathe…in…and out. — Adora took deep breaths. Trying to regain control. — She's being very civil, I don't think you need to freak out.

— I kinda have to talk to her, it's about Finn.

— So go and talk to her, take her to see the flower here, they are so beautiful. — Perfuma's suggestions provided privacy.

Adora nodded, trying not to think too much and just act, before she sat again and cowarded. She didn't have to do anything for Catra to notice her getting close. Finn saw it too, and he pointed at Adora as if Catra hadn't noticed.

— They asked me to talk to you. — Adora said ignoring her wants to chicken out. — About the competition…can we maybe go for a walk? — Adora eyes said please even though her mouth didn't. Catra's reaction was none. Maybe for the sake of appearances.

They were both grateful the others didn't mind their leaving. They got to see the rest of the city from there, the beautiful night sky, if it wasn't so tense Adora thought I could be a very romantic setting.

— Finn says you think they can win. — Catra started.

— Well, with the proper training, I do. — They looked ahead, at anything but each other. — They're good, and a fast learner.

Catra turned, she needed to look Adora in the eyes to be sure.

— Tell me, is it safe? — Took Adora a second to realize they were doing eye contact. — tell me it is nothing like the military school, tell me they'll have protection and rules and…no one like me in the competition. I want them to go but…I can't let them if it is not…empathetic.

Adora wanted to hold Catra. Her hands moved closer but didn't touch the other.

— Is very safe, a lot of body protection, no weapons are allowed, none. The matches are based on points, and there's different ways to get it or lose it. Anyone who gets too brutal is declassified and banned. I promise you, it's safe.

— I don't know if your promises are something I can really count on. — Catra said bitterly. — But I trust you as their teacher…you said something about proper training.

Adora ignored the strong jab at her.

— They would have to stay for longer at practice, training more, doing different styles, not just defense…and for at least 6 days of the week. So saturday classes too.

Catra turned to everyone and whistled, Finn got the message and joined them in the conversation.

— You can do it, on the condition that your grades are going to keep being good and that you will clean your room everyday from now on.

Finn jumped out of excitement.

— Really?! I'm going to be the best student with the cleanest room in the whole school. You'll see! — They gave Adora a high five with another jump.

They didn't wait for another word and went to celebrate with Frosta.

— They are so excited. — Adora was smiling big at them. — How…nevermind. — Adora turned back to the view.

Catra look at her, her hair being blown by the wind, gorgeous side profile, looking so conflicted.

— You want to know how I became a mom, don't you? — Catra teased. Adora bit her bottom lip.

— Yes. — She said as if she got caught stealing.

They were facing the opposite direction while lounging on the balcony, arms a few inches apart. Catra took a deep breath.

— After you left, I got worse, in every way you can possibly imagine. — Adora closed her eyes as she heard Catra. — I don't think I was truly healing before Finn…I heard about this cat kid who was in the orphanage, they were a little feral so most people could talk to them. But when we saw each other there was no need for words. They are so kind, and strong. Raising them is easy, they seemed to have more stuff figured out than me. — Catra chuckled.

Adora smiled, she missed that little raspy laugh.

— They mentioned someone named Scorpia…are they…special to you? — Adora panic peak with the silence that followed her question. — I'm sorry. You don't owe me any explanation.

— I know I don't. Scorpia is my… best friend, Finn loves her and she loves them. — Catra knew what Adora meant by someone special. — What about you, any one special? — Adora's blushing came in full force. — What? too many to name? — Catra jokes, mascarating one of her fears. — I imagined the famous mighty She-ra would have a line of people after her.

The nickname she got from the protests stuck really hard and Adora was more referenced in the media as She-ra than her own name. It was good for the press, it helped the protest so she fed the idea, even dressing up sometimes. Knowing Catra knew about that made her blush a little more.

— No. No lines, none at all. — People had shown interest, just never received back. — I was…very focus on the acts, and doing this, and doing that, making sure the horde was gone. Bla bla bla…no dating life for Adora. — She felt almost like years ago, like a child, who could tell her best friend everything, even the worst parts of her stories.

— At least you got a cool sword out of it. — Catra managed to get a laugh out of her.

Adora turned facing the same way as Catra.

— I know I said this before, but I missed you. — Catra's eyes started to water before she even processed what was happening. — Painfully so, every day. — Adora took a deep breath. — And I know you need time, and maybe don't even want to be friends again, but just know I do, I want to be friends, and hang out, and see Finn grow up, not just be their teacher, I want to be closer. And I will respect your boundaries if you don't want to, and even if you do. — The words were so full of vulnerability. — I thought I would never see you ever again. — Adora tried holding her sob, making Catra look at her and see how much she was crying. — And I would never get a chance to apologize, to reconcile. But you're here now and all I want to do is beg for your forgiveness.

Catra got closer, touching Adora's chin, the blonde looked at her, the feline delicately wipe the tears from the angelical face.

— That's a lot. You didn't do feelings very well before, everything was always in here. — Catra caressed Adora's temple. — You changed, haven't you?

Adora could kiss her, wanted to kiss her, Catra was so close, and yet she couldn't do anything but stay still. How could she even think about that in a moment like that? Catra was close, talking to her. Why did she need to want more? The tears stopped and her heart started to beat fast.

— I have. — It almost a whisper. — I played that night in my head a million times…trying to imagined ways it could've been different…— Catra did the exact same thing. — Not having you around was like losing a limp.

— If you…why didn't you…Adora, why didn't you stay? — Catra asked the question that had been bothering her for many years. She feared the answer, always imagining it being ' because I didn't have a reason to'. — Why didn't you stay, Adora? — She didn't scream, didn't cry out, she simply asked.

— I didn't realize how much I was going to be leaving behind. — Catra's hands were still in her face, she started to lightly caress

Catra's arms, in need of some type of contact. — At the time, I was depressed, almost suicidal, I didn't realized it, but I knew it deep down, I had this dread haunting me, this absolute certainty that if I stayed, I wouldn't survive. — Catra hugged her. Absolutely unable to stop herself. She never imagined it was that bad. — I feel so weak compared to you. — Adora hugged her back, arms tight around the feline. — You had been through so much worse, and faced it with ferocity, determination, and I-I had to run away.

— The thing is, I'm motivated by spite. — Catra laughed through her tears. — And you. — She took Adora's face in her hands again. — You're motivated by kindness, and there was none of that where we were. I do…I do forgive you, I think I have for a long time.

Adora was ready to cry a lot more but when they saw someone approaching, they did quick work of their tears and broke off the hug. It was Bow.

— Hi, so, do you guys want dessert? — His big smile received a very positive nod from both. — Okay, vanilla or chocolate?

— Both. — They both said and laughed a little at the synchronization.

— Okay, both it is. — Bow went to serve.

The rest of the night they mingled with everyone else. Adora had to do a quickie make up check in the bathroom after so many tears but it was all worth it, Catra forgave her, Catra said, it wasn't a dream, they could be friends, they hugged and cried together. Adora felt over the moon. Adora was the loudest as they sang happy birthday to Glimmer, no way to contain her happiness.

As everyone said goodbye Catra didn't really know how to approach Adora, she settled for the usual wave as Finn went for a hug. In the car Finn fell asleep as soon as they set off. Catra had so many emotions, she realized that maybe she and Adora were

okay, or at least starting to be okay. They had a lot of room to cover. And she couldn't ignore the tension, Adora looked at her in aways she never had before and Catra was so lonely in that matter, she was starving for it. To just lean in and taste, as if dipping her toes in cold water, as scary as it was for her, Adora was a pool she felt ready to dive into.

Adora had similar things in mind, a goofy smile that didn't leave her face and a beating heart ready to bounce off her chest. It had been too much and most clearly not enough, to have Catra's hands lingering in her face, wiping her tears, she could still feel it, as if the feline was right there with her, breathing close, sharing warmth in the breeze. She didn't focus too much on anything else, only Catra and her proximity, especially the arms around her, it brought so much comfort it made Adora cry again. It was the first good night of sleep Adora had in years.

Primeral Need

Running wasn't Adora's strong suit but she did it anyway. Keeping her form was important to her and a good way to relieve anxiety before talking to Perfuma. She and Catra exchanged numbers, they needed to make a schedule for Finn, and they settled on a coffee meeting for the conversation. Adora could throw up at how much that made her feel sick, as if someone was turning her inside out. A breakfast with just them and nobody else felt like a date, and that was causing all kinds of havoc in the blondes mind.

She was completely out of breath and still didn't want to take a sit to talk as she met Perfuma.

— So. What do you wanna talk about today? — Perfuma was watering the plants as they walked.

— I don't want to say Catra but…— Perfuma laughed a little.

— What's there to talk about her? — She said it nicely, with a very sweet and welcoming voice. — You're going to meet with her. — Adora nodded.— Anything in your mind about that? Any predictions, wants? Or fears?

— I hope it goes well… I want to be able to make sure we stand on a solid ground with each other. No fights would be great. — Adora nodded to her own statement.

— Can I ask you something? — The flowers were being water with so much care the other blonde couldn't help by smile.

— Sure.

— Have you ever dated? — Adora was stunned by the blunt question.

— No.

— Why is that? — Perfuma turned to face Adora. — Why haven't you date anyone?

— I guess, as you know, I didn't have the most healthy upbringing. And when I got out, things were so overwhelming, friendships were so hard as it was, and dating felt like a even harder task. I was scared of it, then the protests, and I had no time to think about something like that.

— It's been almost two years since the last protest. — Adora took that information in. — So what has been stopping you now?

— I guess, I don't really know how to do it, where to meet someone, or how to flirt, I don't even know when somebody is into me, something that Glimmer and Bow told me I'm very bad at seeing.

— You can try practicing, go to a bar, flirt a little, nothing to worry too much about. There's plenty of queers spaces for you to do so. — Adora nodded. Taking in to consideration. — And what about sex? — Adora looked terrified, as if it was the most scary thing in the world. — You don't like the idea of sex? Are you afraid of it? Why do you look so uncomfortable?

— I don't know. I'm not afraid of it, I don't dislike the idea of sex.

— Can you imagine yourself taking part in the act? — Perfuma indulged. — There's people who don't like sex, others that feel repulsed by it. It's okay if you feel like that. No need to try and find a reason to like it. — Adora still looked very constipated. — You're an adult Adora, you're 32, you should be able to talk about sex without feeling like it is a taboo or something forbidden.

— I know, but I never got to develop that, or talk about it. I have…thought about it, so I'm not repulsed. But I can't…I can't imagine myself having sex with just anyone. Even if I find them attractive I don't see it happening, it's like my body won't respond to them. — Adora knew her body was quite reactive around Catra.

— I think… the first time I ever felt something while with someone was Catra, I wanted to kiss her… I never felt that before.

— We don't need to label everything, and it's not something to have written in stone but I would recommend you giving some time and researching on demisexuality. — Perfuma wanted her friend to feel more comfortable around the conversation. — And I have a question that is a bit more personal, do you ever masturbate? — And then Adora was blushing, Perfuma profissional voice didn't do anything to calm Adora down. She felt so out of body to talk about those things. — You know, if ever want to have sex with someone, you're going to have to talk about it, or it's not really going to work out. And knowing your own body it's really essential for your health and helps when you're with another person to know what you like, to know what gives you pleasure.

— I have…But...maybe two times. — Adora sighed. — I don't even know if I did it right.

— I recommend trying to incorporate that a lot more in your life if you want to have sex someday. it's a good way to ease things that for you, right now, are very unfamiliar. — Adora nodded, not wasn't really sure if she was going to be doing any of that. — Just give it a try, okay?

— Okay. — She said, still red all over.

X

The day had been normal, although she announced to everyone about Finn being their representation for the tournament. She didn't see Catra, but they texted and the feline was simply busy and working a lot, nothing that felt like an avoiding tactic, plus their coffee together was still up.

Adora left her bathroom with a towel wrapped around her. She started to dry herself up. She felt tired beyond explanation,

everything happening in her mind was taking such a tool on her body.

Her loft was simple, not much to see, all the walls were dark gray, she only had color on her kitchen cabinets, her bed almost touched the ground with how low it was and instead of a functioning living room she had a work out space, no tv, some photos hanging around the walls, most of them from the protests. An entire wall for her room was a shelf of books, she was still adding to the collection. She also had a full body mirror in her bedroom, to check her outfits and hair, she liked looking nice. And as she looked at the mirror, with her hair wet, her toned legs flexing as she dried them off, something on her decided to take a better look. She hung the towel in the bathroom, a sudden nervousness got to her, wondering what she was doing exactly.

— It's just you, it's just your body. — She walked back to stand in the front of the mirror, bare, nothing covering her.

First she looked at her body from different angels, becaming more familiar with it, she could clearly see the remaining scar Catra left on her stomach, some of the stretch marks on her lower back. She then ventured to touch, her hands on her body giving her a foreign sensation, her fingertips felt the strong muscles all over, her biceps, her abs, her ass. Adora start to breathe heavily, soon her hand found her nipples, hard and sensitive to touch. She gasped, closing her eyes at the sensation. Adora moved to her bed, laying down on her back, both hands exploring her breasts, every squeeze made her eyes roll. She could feel the wetness pooling between her legs. Venturing south was a slow build up, as her finger touched closer she started to shiver, the intense reaction got her scared, breathing out of control.

— This, is your body, *is you, Is me*. — She said it again.

The moment her fingers circled her clit she moaned, relieved, gasping for more of it, and she gave herself more, till everything had faded out, it was only her and the pleasure she was sinking into, every moan made her more enveloped in the act, every

move of her hips to meet her hand made her feel a deeper connection to herself than any meditation had in a long time. She didn't know what she needed as she was searching for it, for the moment of release. Adora wasn't eager to finish, she wanted the waves of pleasure to keep coming strong at her, to take her body to a breaking point, and the moment she pinched her nipple, it came, taking every last bit of energy and consciousness out of her.

X

Melog was purring on Catra's lap. Who decided to work from home since she was meeting Adora during the morning and she didn't want to be late. They would meet before the defense class. They talked on the phone, exchanged some text, and it was nice and odd to have a more permanent contact and talk when they felt like it. She had to postpone the meeting about Entrapta, her mind was still not sure on what to do, she didn't want to have her but it was the fastest solution and the betterment of the Fright Zone needed to come first.

— I wish I could just sleep and pur, you have it so easy. — Melog was deep asleep as Catra mumbled.

One of the things she had spent a lot of time thinking about was Adora's questions regarding her love life. It was a new subject for them, they had never talked about it, neither had any crushes growing up so there was nothing to gossip about in the department. For Catra there was nothing much to talk about still. She wondered if Adora was jealous of Scorpia, but shoved that thought away right after it occured.

— You have to move kitty, I gotta go meet this cute blondie who's very pontual.

Melog stretched and left for Catra's bed. While the other feline tried to keep calm for breakfast. She wanted to be friends with Adora again, badly, and she talked to Scorpia who said ' She's your friend and potential lover, do not screw this up, I love you

but you need to get laid, Adora is a very nice person and Finn likes her. So be nice, dress up, and go get the girl, wildcat. ' to which Catra rolled her eyes.

She didn't want to date Adora, she barely knew if they were friends, she did agree on the needing to get laid bit however she would never say that to Scorpia. After Finn, things were very bleak in the sex department, nothing in her mind worked the same after them, and being a mom for some reason changed her sex drive, she couldn't really separate herself from that role, she could still feel very attractive but being Finn's mom was the thing in her mind 24/7 and as they got older that came down to sometimes somebody eyeing her different and she remembered that she was desireble. She couldn't really do one night stands, she wondered too much about the constant exposure to STD's, and she lived with Finn, nobody could come to their house, she would've to find a babysitter too. She avoided all together, being a single mom was already hard enough, she didn't need to bring instability by hooking up with some random who'll come in and out of their lives.

She knew the only way sex was happening for her was with a very stable relationship and that was something she was really looking for. At some point hiring a sex worker came to her as very good solution, and she still though about it, she had been very close with Double Trouble during college and her waiting tables time, they had a great living with all types of different sex work, camperson, luxury companion, even dominatrix. She thought about contacting them again but then she would once more think about Finn, and everything was thrown in the trash. She loved her child, more than anything, and didn't feel like too much of a sacrifice while her toys still had batteries.

The place was near Finn's school, it was a very small place, but there were enough tables. Adora was already there. The blonde wore a red tank top and matching sweatpants that were also red with a white stripe. Catra tried a more casual look, leggings and an oversized shirt, all black. The day was warmer than most, the heat wasn't the feline favorite, it did nothing for her fur and mane.

— Hey, Adora. — The blonde turned smiling.

Unsure on how to proceed she got up and waved, only to sit down as Catra went for the chair opposite her.

— Hi, Catra. — She bit her lip. — I didn't ordered anything yet. — She showed Catra the menu. — So, about Finn, any thoughts about how we can proceed?

— I'm thinking they could meet you after school, so instead of going home later they just meet you earlier. They had been doing an extra hour for the first week, as part of their adapting process, and this week they started getting home earlier. — Adora nodded. — It only works if you can pick them up from school at 1pm.

— Yeah, I can do that. — Adora smiled. — I'll have to reschedule with my therapist.

— You go to therapy? — Catra asked intrigued.

— Yeah, it's a very recent thing. Like not even a mouth. — Anxiety was on check, her hands were sweating more than what she would have liked but nothing crazy.

— I haven't been to a session in a while and now with the moving I have to find a new one. — Catra called the waiter. — I want this one, and an orange juice, please. — She said while pointing at the menu. — She'll have a chocolate cake and cappuccino. — Adora's eyes went from Catra to the waiter, she nodded.

— How did you…?

— Every time we could pick something to eat, that's what you'd ask for, although they usually only had the cake. — It was one of the good days of the military school, the most human side, letting them have a day where they could choose what to eat. — Always the same. I figured that hadn't changed, if you didn't got bothered by it after 10 years.

— You always had tuna sandwiches, I hope your taste for food got better. — Catra laughed.

— It has…so it's therapy helping? — The feline truly wanted to know.

— I think so… I'm figuring some things out. — Adora said. — And for you? Was therapy helpful?

Catra's tail flicked at the question, she wasn't uncomfortable but it wasn't the most easy subject.

— I don't think I would have ever adopted Finn if I hadn't gone to therapy. — She admitted. — It was a strange time.

— Strange how? — Adora was starving for any details regarding Catra's life.

— I was working, studying, figuring out my sexuality. I got into a lot of fights, did a very crazy trip to the Crimson Waste with Scorpia. — Catra laughed. — It was the stupidest idea ever, we had no money, we fought, I can't even remember why, I was probably being a jerk, I remember dumping her and going somewhere with a woman. — Adora tried not to look bothered. — And then doing a lot more of stupid things, and I wasn't quite sure why.

Hearing it was somewhat good and bad, she had a confirmation of Catra's interest in women but it also meant Catra had been with others. That rubbed Adora in the worst possible way. Jealousy was not a feeling she was used to. It wasn't like Catra was her property, she didn't feel possessive, only jealous. She wanted to be the girl Catra took somewhere, she wanted to be there for her in that way and she knew it, she also knew she was not going to risk flirting and losing Catra now that they were on speaking terms.

— Here are your orders. — They both thanked the waiter.

— So after that I got very lost, had to deal with my abandonment issues, had to find new ways to cope and not just try to find some easy fix with somebody. — Catra's honesty pulled some strings around Adora's heart. — And after it, everything was less hurtful. Before, I felt like the world was trying to get me, I thought that everyone was going to either leave me or hurt me. I had a severe case of trust issues. — She laughed. — I still struggle, but not as much.

— I probably should've done that, going to therapy earlier in life. Now I'm just so used to how things are that it's hard to see what's not working. — It was Adora's turn to be honest. — I have big intimacy issues, the more I think about it, the more terrified I feel…it's the military training, the time after time we were told not to be vulnerable, to not let our guard down and even after it, I had too keep this up for the protests, I couldn't let my guard down. — She felt like she was over sharing.— I'm sorry…you didn't come here for me to unload on you.

Catra eyed her while taking a bite from her lemon pie. Adora was nervous again, the feline felt sympathy in a way some part of her still didn't want to feel. Being unforgiving was something her past had hardwired her to be, and she had to fight it.

— It's okay. I don't think I have ever been intimate with anyone. Not really, people say that they are intimate when they have slept with somebody but I don't personally believe that regards intimacy. — Catra shrugged. — I think letting someone see you cry is intimacy, letting someone hold you when you're really sad, asking for help, letting someone take care of you when you're sick, intimacy is a lot more than sex.

Adora took all of those words in, realizing she had done all of those things for Catra, and Catra had done all of those things for her.

— You…have a point. — Adora sighed.

— What it is? — Catra ears fully turned in her direction, the sound making her instincts take charge.

— Nothing. I'm just…dumb with these kind of things.

— You were the first to know when somebody was sad. — Catra stated. — I think you're quite good at these kinds of things. — Adora blushed a little, but she was unaware of it. — Maybe you're just bad at it when it comes to you…I mean, I have always thought too much about myself, you were always the opposite, too selfless. I knew that hadn't change when I saw you on tv, and I guess it's still the same now.

— I've been told that before. — Glimmer, Bow, Perfuma, even heard from Mermista. — To take time for me…my therapist suggested I go out to flirt, I don't really know how to do that.

Catra laughed, hard and loud.

— You have never flirted? At all? With anyone? Oh princess that's no way to live. — Adora blushed harder. — Tell me what you would do.

— Right now? — Adora frowned. — I guess it depends on where, if is a club or something I should get the person a drink, maybe? I see it in movies.

— That's not that bad, but it can be a little creepy if you don't talk to them first. Do have any pick up lines? Although those don't necessarily work, it's just a nice away to be funny and show you're interested.

— I don't think I know any. — Adora confessed. — Maybe something like… hey…I like your shirt, where did you buy it?

— That just sounds like you like someone's shirt and wants the same one for you. — Catra was amused to say the least. — Just imagine, it's a gorgeous person, like stunning, beautiful, they look at you, clearly wanting to see what's hiding under all of that red,

they get closer but not too close, waiting for you to go and say something. What do you do?

Adora was out of her body, Catra's voice narrating got her to another planet, her brain was completely empty. It took her a minute to come back to earth and realized she was asked a question.

— Uh… I would go to them, say hi, and maybe do something like. — Adora gave Catra her best grin followed by a very subtle bite on the lips. — And hope she got the message. — As Catra recovered from the well performed fake flirting Adora decided to eat her cake, not falling to notice the additional 'she' Adora put in the end. — But then again, I don't know how to proceed from there. If I get a positive reaction, I just go and kiss them? Do I wait? I don't even know if I want that, I think I'm just going to freak out and have a panic attack. — Adora was frustrated.

Catra frowned, her eyebrows almost touching.

— What scares you so much? — Catra asked. — I have always seen touch as one of your main love languages.

— It's just overwhelming…and I don't, I don't really want most people to touch me. So flirting and hooking up is not for me. — Parts of Adora told her she should feel embarrassed, but Catra wasn't judging, so why should she really feel ashamed?

— I think it is time for us to pick up Finn.

They did quick work of their food and beverages. Nothing went to waste. They decided to take Catra's car as they left.

— Do you ever feel… I don't know… lonely to be raising Finn by yourself? — Adora's question made Catra's hands gripped the wheel a little tighter.

— Sometimes it is hard. — The raspy voice was but a whisper. — I…never really had someone, so I don't really know what it is to raise them any other way.

— But are you…are you lonely? — That was something Adora had wondered about when she left. Catra didn't have any friends, and apparently that list grew from zero to one, which was not much. — I know Finn is good company, but there's only so much you get to share.

The question felt too personal, too real. Catra's defenses were suddenly up, she was not ready to be so open with Adora, she didn't want to spill all of her secrets, to depend on the blonde again as her safe net.

— I'm…look, there's the school, there they are. — She deflected.

Finn was already waiting close to the gate when they got there. They were happily surprised to see Adora and Catra.

— Mom! Adora! — They gasped. — Are we going to train today?

— Yep. Just me and you, you're mom is going to pick you up when we're done.

X

Catra went home to find Melog playing with one of Finn's toys. Adora's question still on her mind, was she lonely? She had been, but what she felt wasn't exactly that. She wanted someone to touch, but maybe it was beyond that, maybe she was seeking companionship.

Catra decided to go back to work until it was time to get Finn.

The weeks ahead of their breakfast together were filled with text exchanges regarding Finn. They had been doing great with training, and Catra was occupied with her work. She barely talked to her child so when they asked to cook dinner and invited Adora, Catra didn't think to say no. And that's how she ended up setting a nice table on a Friday night. The most special thing was cooking with Finn.

— Baby, try slicing those tinner. Or is going to take a lot more to cook them. — Giving Finn a knife was not the hardest decision given they had very sharp claws and they knew how to handle those. — And did you salted it?

— Aham, and what now? — They said very eager to help.

— Now, you go and take a shower. I'll finish here.

As Finn went upstairs, Adora stood at the door, nervous, really nervous, paralysed. She didn't know why but going in felt like a huge step. After almost a month of their reunion, and being able to call each other friends again it just made Adora not want to screw it up, therefore she was freaking out. Catra was even sending her memes, they were okay, more than okay, they were friends. Although it was Finn's idea, Catra said yes to it so it had to be fine for her to be there. For her to visit. It felt intimate, that's why it freaked Adora out. She knocked, breathing slowly to help calm herself down. After some minutes the door was open.

— Hey, Adora. — Catra opened the door, she was wearing an apron and somehow looked extremely sexy with it. — I ended up coming home late, so dinner's not ready yet. Sorry.

— No worries, I can help. — Adora offered.

As she saw Catra still rocking her work outfit, she felt less self-conscious about wearing one of her nicest dresses, it was a black silk one that hugged her body in a very sexy way so she had a cardigan over it that made it look more casual. She just never had anywhere to wear it, so she decided the dinner was a good opportunity. They both went to the kitchen together, Adora found herself an apron to. She soon caught on to the meal, fish and salad as mentioned by Finn at the last dinner they shared. They worked together in silence, in sync, another moment that felt rather intimate. As they both went for the same bottle of olive oil their hands touched, they smiled at each other, a tingling feeling left in both hands.

— Now we wait for the fish to finish roasting. — Adora nodded. — Finn told me you guys are making progress, are you?

— Yes, they have been so great, they're quick to catch on to things. Punches are looking better, and their kicks are almost as good as yours. — Catra rolled her eyes. — What? Is true, you were very good…ever think about fighting again? Doing martial arts or something like it?

— No. Never. Is not good for me, it just makes me lose control and I hate how angry I feel, how completive. — They were side by side on the kitchen counter. — I'm glad you found a nice way to keep that part of you.

— Me too. If you ever want to try something, I have some special classes on Saturdays, afternoon. — Adora stole a glance, Catra's side profile made her want to do things she couldn't even try to mention. — Where's Finn?

— Taking a shower. — Adora's eyes went wide. — Don't ask me why, they like it. I don't get it. Baths are so much better and less aggressive.

The image of Catra taking a bath invaded Adora's mind in the most inappropriate way possible. She gulped.

— Glimmer said you guys are in need of help to clean some spaces. I was thinking maybe I could take the kids to help, like a school trip. — Adora took the conversation to a more safe subject for her very horny mind to not play any games. — I would just have to take them somewhere as safe as possible.

— That's a very good idea. — Catra turned and hugged Adora. — Oh, that would be so nice. — Adora's arms held her tight. — And yes, somewhere safe, we planned to clean around a lake, to build a park there. Nothing too dangerous, just litter.

— Sounds perfect. — They kept hugging for a while.

Neither were sure to why they held each other for such a long period, slowly Catra loosened her hold, her hands caressing Adora's arms on the way, soon finding her wrist, palm, fingers. She looked up to see Adora's eyes were closed. Cheeks bright red, lips apart, breathing getting quicker by the second, the change in her scent, something Catra had never smelled before on her, although subtle it was strong. She didn't push away, Adora's body was pressed against hers, still and yet so responsive. Catra's tail decided to play around her legs, doing a loop around Adora's left tight, keeping her even closer as their fingers slowly intertwined, something that could be so sweet and innocent felt so erotic.

Footsteps made Catra move quickly to the living room. Adora was left alone, breathless, unsure if her legs would move, she felt so hot, her cheeks burned and her lower belly ached in the most pleasurable way possible. She took a calming breath before opening her eyes again to her surroundings.

— Mom, Melog is hungry. — Finn's voice made Adora smiled. — Adora, you're here.

— Yeah, your mom and I were finishing up dinner. — Finn did quick work of getting Adora out of there.

— You need to help me with this puzzle, mom doesn't have the patience for it.

As she passed Catra, the feline's pulpils were in a way Adora had only seen once before.

Facing Fears

The puzzle was big, really big, they had so many pieces still to be in place Catra was shocked with the determination they both had while assembling it. But it helped her body to calm down, their exchange in the kitchen only served to highlight how needy she had been. Seeing her and Finn getting along so well while doing something that wasn't fighting made her heart so full. It scared her, feeling so right, having Adora there like a missing piece found. She went back to the kitchen to make sure everything was ready for dinner.

Melog was around, asking for pets. The feline was being extra cuddly which meant they definitely were catching on to Catra's needs.

— I'm okay, I promise. She's just…pretty, and I'm needy. She's also very good with Finn, has those nice muscles all around…is kind, she even offered to take some kids to help clean the Fright Zone…but it was a spark of the moment. It won't happen again. — The sound coming from Melog was telling, they didn't believe her. — Is not like we're going to…she definitely doesn't want that…— Another disapproving sound. — Believe me, I know…very close to when she…left. I did everything I could to show her that I wanted to kiss her and she didn't do anything, it was like she was very set on ignoring the signs I gave her. — She could hear Melog basically telling her that sounded like irony. — What do you mean?

Melog simply sniffed the air before leaving Catra. Confused by the action, she took a sniff too, realizing Adora's scent was there, fainted but there, and that strong addition was easier to distinguish. She had smelled that before, a slightly different fragrance with the same meaning behind it. Adora was aroused by her, Adora wanted her. There was no way to deny, was she too ignoring all the signs? They weren't teens anymore, she should be able to be more up front, and they could take things slow. But that meant being serious, being in a relationship and they barely started to hangout. She needed to take it step by step and some

part of her held on to the idea that maybe it was just a fling, or her needy brain mixing all the other things she felt for Adora and thinking it meant she wanted her like that too.

Attraction was the hardest thing for Catra to control when it came to her body reacting, her tail would just linger anywhere it wanted and her eyes, a big tell. And she had to keep that in check, it was easy, they just needed Finn to be around and everything would be fine and kid friendly.

— Food is ready!! — She screamed for them both to hear it. — And hopefully good.

Adora came down, and as soon as she saw the kitchen counter she blushed. Finn, unaware of what had happened, sat next to their mom. The food was good, and that kept everyone's mouth occupied. And as soon as the young hybrid was done they yawned.

— You're sleepy? Already? — Finn laughed and nodded.

— Very much so. I'm sorry Adora, I don't think we can finish the puzzle today. — Catra felt like her child was plotting a way for Adora to visit again.

— Is alright, we will preserve over 2000 pieces. — Finn hugged her and gave their mom a kiss.

— Wait, you don't want dessert? Who are you and what have you done to my kid? — The teasing made them laugh.

— I'm just too full already. Night, mom. But Adora should definitely try the dessert.

— Don't forget to brush your teeth, extra strength on those fangs! — Adora was always the one to tell Catra to brush her teeth, seeing her doing the same to Finn was heartwarming and hard to process.

Melog went upstairs with Finn, she found the action odd, they shared the bed with Catra most days, it was like the feline was implying something by their actions, as if Catra would need her room to be Melog free.

— Thanks for reminding them. — Catra said. — That's nice of you.

— Oh…force of habit I guess…And I don't have to stay for dessert. — Things were weird, they both knew what could've happened in the kitchen. — I don't want to be a bother.

— You're not. — Honesty, why was it so gut wrenching? — It's nice having someone over, even though your host bolted to go to sleep.

— Should we…address what…what I talked about, you know, the kids. — Acting awkward was becoming a habit Adora wished she could stop. — I think next week is good. If you can arrange it.

— Yeah. I think that's great…so did you figure out how to see your therapist, I forgot to ask. — Catra's eyes were half lidded. Not to be seductive, they just did that whenever she felt comfortable.

— We see each other in the mornings…and did you find a therapist? I'm sure Perfuma could see you too if that's something you want.

— I didn't, but I don't have the time anyway, not for now. — Work had her putting a lot on hold. — I'm sorry about…what happened in the kitchen. I shouldn't have…

— Hugged me? — Adora didn't shy away from eye contact and that meant Catra wouldn't either. — Nothing happened, and you can hug me anytime you want. — The awkwardness mixed with the reassurance went better than Adora expected.

Catra realized they were going to brush off what happened, Adora wanted to, so she went with it. Nothing happened. But then again

it did, the scent, she didn't want to brush off what happened or shove her feelings down a barrel, she had learned to do better.

— Something did happen Adora, you know it did. — Catra sighed. — But if you want to pretend it didn't, that's fine.

Catra's ears went flat. Adora imagined she had said the right thing, but should have known better.

— I don't know what you want from me. — Adora braved. — You said you forgave me, we're friends again, at least I like to think we are… and what happened or almost happened there isn't something friends do. And I don't want to ruin this and complicate things. That's what I want, for us to be cool and I don't know if I can be cool if we…— Catra got up.

— If we…what? — The blonde got up too.

They stood in front of each other, close.

— If we…if…I kissed you. — The beating of their hearts was deafening. — Can I?

Adora was craving Catra's lips like her lungs needed air. Everything around them felt hot all of the sudden.

— Are you sure that's what you want? — Catra pupils were dilated to a hypnotizing degree. — A minute ago you wanted to forget what didn't happen.

— I…— The weak whisper faded to no sound as Adora couldn't help but get closer, their lips brushing, giving each other the faintest taste, a mere preview of how soft they were.

— Use your words*, princess*. — Catra whispered against Adora's mouth.

— I'm sure.

A sudden thud coming from the top of the stairs made Catra turn away. Adora figured the other one was teasing but realized that wasn't the case.

— I think Finn just saw us…you need to go. — Catra was distant, both physically and emotionally in an instant, behaving as if Adora was already gone. — Please, go.

Adora realized her friend was panicking.

— Hey, it's okay. Finn won't be mad.

— I can't do this to them, okay? — Catra snapped at Adora. — If they get attached to you, or start seeing you as anything but a temporary thing, it is going to hurt them when you leave! I can't have that, I can't have you doing that to them! — The feline claws were out but she didn't use them, simply kept her distance as Adora winced at the harsh words coming at her, claws or no claws it felt like being ripped to shreds. — You're their teacher, something they know doesn't last forever. But if they see us together, if they think you're my…I can't do this to them. So please, leave! Go, Adora.

— I won't do that. — As scared and ashamed as she felt she knew she couldn't just stay quiet. — I'll never do that…you said you forgave me, why can't you see I'm not just someone who ran away? I had to. It was killing me to live there. — Catra looked at how broken Adora was. — I'm not…going to abandon you again.

— You don't know that…you don't know anything about raising a child. You don't know shit about how hard it can be. — Catra didn't want to scream, didn't want to escalate things, and yet she was growling, low but still. — Is not just fun puzzles and good night kisses. Is hard, seeing them sick in a hospital bed because of air pollution, and thinking it is your fault because you decided to stay somewhere you knew was not good for them! You hear them crying because everything hurts and they just couldn't breathe right! Is being so fucking clueless sometimes you think you're the worst mom on the planet and everytime they get hurt

you wish to be their shield, you so desparately want to protect them from the world and the cruelties out there. — The growl was gone but the tears started. — You can't just come into their lives, into our lives! And changed everything. I can't just tell them you're here to stay…— She looked deep into the blue eyes. — Kissing me is one thing, Adora, but them thinking you're more than their teacher, that's a whole different thing… I did forgive you, but I don't trust you. — As the blue eyes started to water Catra pointed at the door. — They'll see you at practice.

As Adora left Catra went upstairs to check on Finn. She gave two soft knocks on the door.

— Come in. — As suspected, they were awake. — Hi, mom…I'm sorry for…creeping.

— What did you see? — Catra asked calmly although worried.

— You were going to kiss Adora. And I realized I needed to give you privacy. — A deep sigh mixed with a laugh was Catra's response.

— It was nothing, just a goodbye kiss. Now go to bed. And no more sneaking anywhere. — Finn received a forehead kiss before their mom left. — Melog, come. — She calls on the third feline of the family.

As Catra laid down, hugging Melog was the only comfort she could find before going to sleep.

X

Adora curled into a ball as she cried in her room. Feeling restless she got up, her punching bag felt like the best option to get herself tired enough to sleep. Every punch delivered took part of the unbearable pain taking her sleep away. Nothing was more cathartic to her than a good punching bag and aching muscles. And she would focus solely on that for the rest of her month. Punching bags, lifting weights, training and training, doing all over again, till her body only needed sleep and food. She missed a

whole week of therapy, she barely even text any of her friends, canceled on Bow, their movie night pushed to after the tournament. The only time she smiled was during practice with Finn, who so politely didn't mention anything about the night.

She still held up on her promise to Catra. So there she was, giving the kids their bags before all of them entered the bus, everyone had their safety kit and all things needed to grab trash and not touch it. Most of their parents allowed the trip to happen, only two kids didn't go.

— Are you guys ready?!— Adora teacher persona was the easiest to fit into. — Everyone, this will be a long drip. We will stop to pee, and eat, so no need to ask. Everyone has their lunch? — All the kids put their thumbs up. — Very good. And remember to stay close all the time. Now, seat belts.

Adora took a little tour to make sure all of them had their seat belts buckled right and as expected they had. They were very chatty, nothing knew there and it was nice to have her inner thoughts overpowered but middle school gossip. The kids were so well behaved Adora couldn't help but feel a little proud. She knew getting there meant seeing her hometown again after such a long time. As they reached the limits of the city Adora's hands started to sweat. Passing the military school gave her a full body goosebump, a ghost of her past, one that still haunted her. She remembered very little of the rest, she remembered where the Horde factories were, she protested there, but everything else she didn't know anymore, the parks, all the restaurants, all abandoned now, left to rot and crumble. Almost none of the buildings were intact, all around there were signs of caution, danger, unstable buildings, poisoned water. And no sort of wildlife, not one single animal. She hoped the kids wouldn't feel scared, they knew it was bad, they were warned. But not even Adora imagined it was that bad.

Catra might have been right, she never really thought that was a way of rebuilding. The more they saw the town the more she wondered why Catra fought so hard, why she stayed, nothing

looked promising there. Reaching the lake didn't change her mind one bit. Trash all over it and around it. The water was less brown and toxic, although still very bad and no water life in sight. A machine, one Adora had never seen before, was working to clean it, it made no noise but the water around it trashed all to all directions creating waves bigger than normal for a lake. At each wave the water seemed to clear more.

Adora watched as the kids grabbed their bags and started to pick up trash. It was going to be a hustle but a do-able one.

— Okay kids, 7 of you go right, and 7 of you go left. We meet on the other side. — Adora was ready to start when a car parked next to their bus. — Just a second.

As she went to check, a very tall woman appeared. Finn came running in her direction giving her a huge hug.

— Oh hey little kitty. — They hugged for a long time. — Hi there, you must be Adora. — The look she received was borderline disgust. She was definitely Catra's friend. — I came to help. Sorry I couldn't bring my team, they had a lot to do.

— No problem, we're just about to start. — The kids all received masks to help breath and clear the air, something Catra said was crucial for their time there. — Did you bring a mask? I think we have 2 left if you need.

— Thanks. I won't need it. Let's get started. I'll take the left, Finn! Come with me?

They nodded and soon jumped on Scorpia's back. Adora felt beyond jealous, seeing Finn so happy and cuddly with someone who wasn't Catra was just weird. They saw Scorpia as family, and Adora was just their teacher.

A little annoyed, the blonde grabbed a trash bag and went to work, taking the right. She couldn't stop the eye rolls every time she looked across the lake and Finn was clacking like never before. She just couldn't stand it, Scorpia didn't even seemed to

be that funny. Catra had sent a lot of messages regarding Finn's health and not letting them take their mask off for more than 2 minutes max, so she had a reason to be staring.

Her arms were built for the task, her back not so much, the kids had a much easier job grabbing the trash since they were closer to the ground. She and the kids talked about their favorite fighters, and it made everything more easy going. As they were approaching the end everyone was tired. But looking around and seeing everything clean was beyond satisfying. They all sat on freshly clean grass, all masks in place. Proud of their work, the kids started to jump and celebrate.

— We're the best cleaners in the world! — Frosta's response was a bit too aggressive as always. — No one can beat us! Yeah!

— That one has a lot of energy. — Scorpia commented.

— Her mom is very much the opposite. — Adora caught herself saying. She missed Perfuma although it was her fault she did. — This is so crazy, to see the lake like this, the water is almost all clean now too. — Adora was having a hard time processing it.

— Yeah, is what we want to give this entire town, a fresh start, to clean it, and nurture it. — She sounded dreamy. — Me and Catra, we're gonna do it. Now with Glimmer's help is a dream coming true. There is a lot to go…including the military school, we're demolishing it tomorrow if you feel like sticking around. — Adora felt exposed. — Catra said she isn't coming, work and stuff. But she asked me to send her a video of everything destroyed.

— That...sounds like Catra. — They smiled at each other. — So… you're from here too right?

— Yeah, I was the mayor's daughter when the horde got here. Soon the horde came knocking on our door. — The bright spirit looked sad. — My parents didn't want them here and then a mysterious accident happens and soon there's all those of factories everywhere.

— I know a very good therapist. — Adora said, trying to be funny and it did take a laugh out of Scorpia. — Like seriously, she's great. I can give you her number if you want.

— I'm good now, I dealt with the grief. — It seemed no one from the Fright Zone had a nice life. — And I get to rebuilt this, bring it back to the glory my parents knew and loved…is my way to cope.

— That's beautiful. I never thought about coming back here after I left. — It was the truth. — Too much pain.

— You're here now, helping, that's a big step. — Scorpia scooped her into a hug. — Think about it, come tomorrow, is going to be good for you. I promise.

X

— Can you please stop checking that damn phone?! They're going to be fine, Adora is great with kids. — Glimmer took Catra's phone from her. — See! Much better. We can look each other in the eye again.

— Ha ha. — Catra pouted. — I miss my baby, and I'm worried, they never did a school trip before.

— Is not the end of the world. — Glimmer ate her food with so much devotion it made Catra try hers, it was indeed good. — And you'll see them tonight, they're not gone for too long.

— I guess…and how are you? — It felt awkward, a little bitter as it came out of her mouth, asking Glimmer how she was, establishing a clear care. The thing is, her sparkly friend was a bit off. — You came late today and you're not wearing any sparkling clothes.

Glimmer frowned, a bit shaken by the question.

— Is my mom's…she…passed away and today is completing 9 years of her passing. I was supposed to go get flowers and you

know, that whole thing…I just couldn't. — Glimmer held the tears. — Is just a little too much.

— I'm so sorry about your loss…I'm very free after work, if you want company. I can go with you. — The offer caught Glimmer off guard. — I don't know much about moms, but I can stand in silence and just let you do your…thing.

Glimmer did take her up on that. Surprising them both. Going with Bow was a good option but he was also taking the day to grief, Angella was important to him too. Adora had left her flower there before going with the kids.

They decided to walk there, as a way to get Glimmer prepared.

— Thank you for coming with me.

— No problem, sparkles…were you two close? — Catra asked.

— Oh, yes. We only had each other for the longest time, we fought a lot, argued a lot, loved each other so much. — The smile on her face made Catra smile too. — When she passed, having Adora and Bow was the only thing that kept me together. She was such a good mom, very protective and I was not the most careful daughter.

Catra couldn't help but think of Finn.

— I hope my kid thinks the same of me one day. — The confession made Glimmer give Catra a side hug. — Growing up I never imagined having a kid, I just thought I would ended repeating a cycle and fucking my kid up like me parents did me, although they didn't do much other than just abandoning me…and then my parental figure was a cruel bitch who basically kept me locked up whenever she could. — The feline didn't expect to unload so much on Glimmer. — I just do whatever I can to not be anything close to that.

— That's not so hard, since those people were very horrible, and I'm sure Finn already thinks you're their awesome mom.

They walked in silence for a little, getting closer to the cemetery.

— What about your dad? — The question was carefully put. — Don't need to answer if you don't want to, I just never heard you talking about him, don't even know if you have one.

— It's a bit crazy, he was a doctor, traveled to places where he was needed. He left one day when I was still little, we got no news after the trip, it had been so long we thought he died. My mom…she passed thinking he was gone. — Catra would never have expected Glimmer life to be so full of grief. — 7 years ago he just came back, he was lost for years, deep in woods and was found by a group of adventurers. Crazy, right?

— Yeah, very.

— The horde was responsible for the crashing of his plane. And it kinda got me fired up during the protests, piled with everything else that had me around furious.

They stood in front of the cemetery. Catra accompanied her inside, walking in silence as Glimmer took her time. She brought a vase meant to accommodate the flower already there.

— Don't you want…a hug? — Catra decided to offer before they left. — Or a minute to be alone.

— No. Me and mom, we talked enough. You know, that's something you should make sure you do, talk to your kid, share all can with them, secrets just pull you away from each other. — Angella had plenty of secrets, and when those were no longer a barrier, that's when she and Glimmer were truly close. — I promise it's going to make you have an amazing relationship with Finn. Let them know who you are, who you really are, not just their mom, but a person, with a great heart and a hard past.

Hugging Glimmer was happening whether she wanted or not. Catra didn't receive a lot of advice regarding being a mom, she missed that, but socializing with the school mom's was not really a

situation she saw herself in. So she appreciated Glimmer more than ever before at the moment.

X

The military school, nothing had really changed, the dorms were the same, the training room, all dusty and rusty. That alone made her whole being feel weightless, no one was ever going to be broken there again, no more Shadow Weaver. It was old and in the past. Unused. Nothing to fear, this place had no power over her. And as she saw everything falling to pieces she loved every second of it.

— *Fuck you!* — Adora screamed as the buildings were torn apart.

She let out the most primal scream she could master, not knowing Catra was right behind her. Instead of saying something, she let out a scream of her own. They both looked at each other and laughed, and soon they screamed together. Releasing all the pain, all the anger, all the trauma, crying while everything was demolished, the relief settling inside making them reach a sense of peace they never knew before. Even if it was just for that moment.

— I'm sorry about what I said. — Catra pulled Adora into hug. — I'm going to talk to Finn, and I'll be honest about who you are to me. And who you can be. If you still want to try.

Adora gently lifted Catra's face, taking in on her beauty, the heterochromia never failing to mesmerize. Her thumb slowly brushed against the soft lips. Catra kissed it. Her hand grabbed Adora's wrists, guiding her hand to settle on her cheek, Catra sank into the touch.

— I do. I promise I won't disappoint you

Safety Net

Catra's fur stood up, something was wrong and her body felt it before she even could register what had happened, Finn, something inside of her alerted the mom to go see them. As she got closer to their room she could hear the heavy coughing. She went immediately to their aid.

— It's okay baby, here you go.

She had everything she needed to help in case of an emergency of that sort. She turned on the air humidifier and brought the nebulizer. Finn did everything half asleep, muscle memory from their time in the hospital made it easy to navigate what was happening. They had been fine the day before, Catra knew it was risky sending them back to the Fright Zone but nothing had happened when they got back, not a single cough. So why were they like that? Asking them was out of the question, they needed to wait until the coughing had stopped and their breathing normalized.

Catra got on the bed and started to play with their mane, as her finger lightly scratched their scalp a low pur joined the nebulizer was a white noise. It was soothing and soon Finn was breathing normally. They waited until the nebulizer was done.

— Can I take this off now? — The kid pointed to their face.

— Yes, and you can also tell me what exactly did you do. — She knew her child and knew they had a big hand on why they were like that.

— Today we had our first swimming lesson and I know you told me I couldn't be part of it…

— But you went into the pool and did the class anyway. Well now you won't be going to school for the next 3 days, no training either, and we're going to the doctor in the morning. — Finn

pouted at the small lecture. — Your bed is too small for me to stay here with you, and I need to rest too. So everything you need is here, and I'm going to bring Melog to stay here with you for the next nights. Anything, you call me. — They nodded, still pouting.

Melog appeared before even being called, they did as Catra asked but thankfully nothing happened during the rest of the night. The exam results were good, Finn was going to stay home and had to rest, which was a nightmare for the child, Catra needed to take care of them but she also needed to go to important meetings during that entire week. She finally got started on thinking about the market, and getting together with sustainable brands to get the economy on the Fright Zone going. Finn would forever be first, but they could handle it alone, just follow the alarms to take the meds prescribed and use the nebulizer when needed, that was not the hard part, the hard part was getting them to stay still, to rest, to not start jumping all of the sudden, they had to let their lungs heal.

If things were different she would've ask Scorpia. But that's not an option at the moment, the only person she could ask to keep an eye on them was blonde, muscular, had a very stupid grin and an amazing heart. Adora didn't flinch when asked to stay home with Finn.

— They promised to behave. There's food ready for you two, I cooked before you got here. I will be home for dinner, and you have to send me news every hour. — Adora kept on nodding as Catra gave her the right meds and a key. — I'll send you instructions so you can't lose it, and it's better for the environment than paper. And please, if they do anything they're not supposed to do, call them out, they'll hear you…I haven't talked to them yet about us, but I will…so please just be their very nice teacher today, okay?

As Adora nodded once again Catra got closer, giving her a kiss on the cheek, dangerously close to the blonde's mouth.

— Have a nice day. — Was all Adora could master after that stunt.

Finn was in bed, sleeping. Going to the doctor at 5am got them tired. Melog stared at Adora for some seconds, making the human a bit uncomfortable till the feline started to rub their head on her, she obliged and gave them all the pets they wanted. The purring was nice to hear and somewhat nostalgic. Catra had yet to purr at her again for more than one second. Catra had yet to tell Finn about them and really, Adora tried being mature about it but it hurt a little, it made her feel like a dirty secret.

— It's not like is easy telling your child you were basically torture as a kid and raised like a fucking brainless killer robot. — She countered her inner thoughts out loud. — I wouldn't know what to do either.

Empathy, always the strongest response when it came to her. She ended doing what she could of her morning workout. And it was odd being at someone's house without them there, especially being Catra's, she didn't know what would be considered private, and as much as she wanted to snoop away, she knew she needed to keep good boundaries. As she finished her workout she decided to take a look at Finn and make sure they were still sleeping, and at seeing the kid out cold, the shower seemed tempting.

Things there took a turn Adora didn't quite know how to feel about as she saw matching underwear on the ground. She figured Catra rushed to go to work after arriving from the hospital and maybe that's why she forgot to throw it in the basket. Adora should have been normal enough to pick it up and put it in the basket but she was Adora and instead she was freaking out. Somehow feeling like a pervert even though she didn't do anything.

— Just grab the goddamned clothes, Adora! — As she got closer to the item her mind gave her a little scare as her imagination tried to show her how Catra looked wearing it. — For fuck sake!

Her burning cheeks got her nowhere, Adora did her best to not think, just do. As she touched it, the fabric was incredibly soft and just knowing that detail made everything in Adora feel ablaze.

— You're like the worst horny teenager, fucking pathetic. — Before Adora could turn on the shower she heard Finn coughing hard and calling for their mom. — I'm going!

X

Catra heard everything being discussed and she tried her hardest to absorb what was being said, thankful she had warned Glimmer of what happened to Finn, so as a good friend she was taking the lead during the meeting.

They were already working with Entrapta, Catra's standard had to be lowered to allow things to move faster, however it wasn't the case for the current discussion, she needed stability, a good deal, a very hard yes coming from at least 3 of the 7 people on the table, in the best of days Catra would be the most impressive person, the best sells woman, nothing would satisfied her but a yes, but that wasn't one the best days, Catra felt like she would settle for anything at that point to just get the meeting over with it.

Glimmer held it together. And they got 5 positive responses, and 2 of them were ready to start working with Scorpia and building in the Fright Zone. Part of Catra was jumping and smiling, they had clear water running again and now people actually wanted to go and build something there. Catra took the win as well as she could.

— I know you want to celebrate, but I really just want to go home and check on my baby. — She said before Glimmer could say something.

— I figured you'd say something like that, no worries. We can celebrate another day. — They exchanged smiles. — Now go, go take care of your baby….and give Adora a hug for me. — Glimmer winked and smirked.

Catra had no time to fight the woman so she just growled loud enough to be threatening and then retreated. She made sure to

buy enough food for the three of them, including ingredients to bake a cake for Adora. She felt confident Adora hadn't said anything to Finn as much as she felt guilty for not being honest sooner.

It was hard to tell what made her hesitant, scared even. It wasn't like Finn believed her life to be easy nor did they think Catra was perfect. Maybe it wasn't about her at all, maybe it was just about Adora, letting Finn see her from another light, as someone a lot more meaningful in both their lives. It was scary, to introduce her to them. Scorpia had always been there, Finn learned so much from her, and they were learning a lot from Adora too. Saying it out loud would just changed things, and with the moving, the new schools, new people, it just felt like a lot of changed had already forced it's way into Finn's life and adding more to that? It could be a little too much for them.

Finn had become such a priority, Catra didn't know exactly what her own feels were, everything was seen through a lense, the lense that kept Finn's needs in the front of her mind. She wanted Adora, more than physically, she wanted a commitment, a real relationship, she wanted to take that step with her best friend, no one else. Finn would be fine, even if not right away, they would be eventually.

As Catra drove rain started to pour, growing stronger but the second. It was the first time she saw a storm happening in Brightmoon. Oddly it wasn't scary or extremely windy, it just rained nonstop and from time to time a purple-ish lighting appeared. Catra was not enjoying it, rain, water, too similar to a shower, not to mention scary sounds. And she knew Finn hated thunder as much as her. Seeing her house brought maternal and internal relief. She dashed out of the car and tried her hardest to not get too wet.

— I'm home! — She said as she put the groceries on the kitchen counter.

Adora was the first to appeared. The grin on her face made Catra feel a little more calm even though the storm had her on edge.

— Hi…huh, Finn's is wearing headphones to minimize the sound of the thunder. I gave them mine, they are very good for isolation. So I don't think they heard you.

— That's every thoughtful of you…thank you. — Catra smiled at her. — I brought some things, and I thought we could…bake something. — Why was Catra feeling like a helpless teenager? — Maybe tomorrow morning.

— Oh…so you want me to stay the night? — The flirting stole all the bravado from Catra in a instant.

— No…it's not…it's very bad out there, and if you want to go and catch a cold, be my guest.

— I'd love to stay the night. — Adora went to the kitchen. — I can help with dinner…like last time.

They both thought about the hug, the almost kiss, the last time they were cooking and smiling, tasting each other cosine, it almost overwhelmed Adora, her cheeks were warm even though she was the one to bring it up. Catra simply nodded trying to look nonchalant, keeping the appearances as best as she could.

She changed clothes and went to take a good look on Finn before heading down to the kitchen.

— Thank you again, for taking care of Finn. — Catra felt really grateful, she was genuinely moved by Adora's actions. — I owe you one.

— I might take you up on that.

They kept on preparing the food. The synergy as good as the last time, not one single bump into each other. The kitchen had a nice size, but the moment melog started to hang out closer to them things got trickier, they weren't bumping but they were close, they

could hear each other's breathing, feel their warmth, one step away from touching.

— Mom! — Finn gave Catra the biggest back hug. — I didn't know you were home already.

— I went to check on you and you were sleeping so I decided to let you. — The mutual purring made Adora smile. — Dinner's almost ready.

— Catra, if you don't mind, I'm going to shower. — Adora said trying to get clean and to give the two a moment alone.

— Okay, I can take it from here. I have another assistant now right?

— The best assistant. — Finn added.

— See, I'm in good hands, Adora.

The blonde made her way to the bathroom as the felines finished dinner.

— You know…I'm not a kid anymore. — Finn started. — And you can…have dates with people if you want. I don't mind.

Catra stood quiet for a while before taking a deep breath preparing herself for the conversation.

— Why are you talking about this? — She tried to not sound too hard on them.

— Well…I saw aunt Scorpia and she…told me about you and that you felt you couldn't date because of me…she didn't say like that but I understood it. I really don't mind…and I want you to be happy, mom, and if that means having someone…I'm okay with it…especially if she's a nice blonde who teaches a defense class.

And that was the moment Catra feared, she knew her child wasn't blind or dumb, so of course Finn had noticed their interactions

were a bit different than hers with anyone else.

— Things with Adora are a lot more than that…— The small feline almost dropped a plate at hearing Catra's words. — She's an old friend… I meant to tell you but that evolved telling you about my past and I'm not very comfortable talking about it. So just know, Adora is really important to me, she has always been…and we spent years apart. A lot of years…we are still just friends but you might start seeing her around more often outside of the mat, because she's my friend and I like having her around.

— I'm okay with that, just tell her to do her exercises at home, she was so noisy, there were so many grunts and effort sounds. — Finn frowned as they remembered.

Catra didn't know how to react at how easygoing Finn was about all of it. Not pushing, not trying to investigate, no questioning, just understanding. It was her turn to give them a back hug.

— Thank you. — She said simply.

As they arranged the table the rain had settled. Adora was taking quite some time upstairs and as the adult and the host in the house Catra had to make sure she was okay. She used her nose to find Adora who was not on the bathroom but surprisingly in Catra's room. The feline took lighter steps as she got closer to her door, it was open.

Adora had been clumsy as always and somehow knocked one the boxes on Catra's room. A bunch of photo albums were spread across the floor, and as she collected them it was impossible to not look through it. Curiosity took over the blonde. They had the year labeled in the covers. To see Catra growing up, to see her becoming the beautiful woman she was. Adora wouldn't miss that change ever. She forgot about time, dinner, she even forgot she was in someone's house. She sat on the ground and flipped through pages and pages of photos. Teenager, young adult, single mom, all those phases and she didn't seem to have a date in any of them.

Catra had been as lonely as Adora.

— Yes, Adora, of course, you can totally look at my pictures in silence, hiding in my room, like a stalker, I'll love that.

Nothing would ever be as funny as the expression Adora made, a mix of scared, surprised, and embarrassed, that ended in Adora getting up in the most clumsy way and knocking down three other boxes.

— I'm so so sorry. I didn't mean to be sneaky about it, I should've asked. — She said as she tried to put everything in place. — I'm sorry.

— What were you looking for? — Catra got closer. — Anything in particular? I'm sorry to disappoint you but you won't find any unflattering photos of me, unfortunately for that to happen I would have to be ugly, and we both know, I'm not. — Catra said, posing against the door.

— You are definitely not. — Since when did Adora say what she thought out loud? — Sorry…no…I'm not sorry. Well I am but about the sneaking not about you not being ugly.

Catra tried to hold her laughter, Adora was almost cool and flirty for once and she completely ruined it in the next seconds.

— Dinner is ready, I came to get you.

X

— They are asleep. The medicine got them really good. — Catra joined Adora on the living room couch. — I gave them your headphones again…thank you, for being with them this afternoon, and not working…the kids are probably not that happy about that.

— Oh no, they understood, they just want Finn to be okay. — Adora assured her.— They did a quick facetime too, so they all talked, it was messy but it worked.

— You'll be happy to know it wasn't in vain too, I got people to sponsor the project, and people willing to bring their products to the Fright Zone whenever it's ready. — She couldn't hide her smile. — So thank you again.

The odd eyes analyzed Adora up and down, the blonde was stiff, well stiffer, Catra didn't understand why, wondering if the blonde was uncomfortable or just wanted to leave.

— I…uh…had a very good time with them and Melog, I don't think I ever spent so much time with such a creative kid, they were so strong too. — Pride bloomed in Catra heart, she knew Finn would be okay and behave but hearing Adora sound so fond of them made her undeniably happy.

— I told them.

— Told them what? — The blonde was genuinely confused.

— About us…a little, not every detail. But they know we are childhood friends, and that you are going to be around more often.

— I am? — Adora asked hopefully.

— If you want. — They exchange a look hard to describe. What was that feeling? Nervousness, excitement, attraction, relief, maybe it was simply love. — I…want you to.

A very loud and deafening thunder scared them both, shortly after it, the lights were out. Catra's tail was wrapped around Adora's leg.

— Are you okay? — Adora whispered in the dark.

— I didn't have a heart attack so I think so. — It took Adora longer to adjust to the lack of light. — I don't think the energy is going to come back today…and this storm…I know you want to go home but I think it is better if you stay.

— Who says I want to go home? — Again, very confused the blonde asked.

— No one but you seemed like you want to leave…you're sitting there like a rock, like you want to run away from me. — The choice of words made them both frown. — It just feels like you don't want to be here.

— I do. I'm just not sure what to do with my body. — The deep sigh the followed the confession was buried by another thunder. — Being around you makes me want to touch you. Every since you got back I just don't know what to do with myself, when we were kids we held hands, we slept in the same bed, shared food, we showered side by side…and my body thinks it's the same, like nothing has changed, that I can still hold your hand whenever I feel like it. So I get stiff and in my head, and anxious because I know I can't, and I'm scared I'm going to lose this battle and do something you don't want me to.

Catra extended her arm enough to hold Adora's hand, she pulled the other as she slide closer, their sides touching, Catra laid her head on Adora's left shoulder in a sign of reassurance. Slowly Adora relaxed into the touch, reluctant to lay her head on top of Catra's but she did as soon as she felt the purring. Catra was purring, she couldn't hear it but the buzz, the vibration, it was impossible to not recognize.

— Do you want to go to my room? We can sleep there. — Catra offered. — There's less noise.

— I'll like that.

Neither wanted to let go of their embrace, so they walked upstairs with their fingers intertwined. Before they could entered the room Adora stopped.

— What is it? — Catra turned, she could see the worry growing and growing, the worse coming to Adora's mind. — Hey, tell me what's wrong.

Catra had to wait before Adora could look her in the eye.

— It's uh…what are we doing? I know you talk to Finn but you… you didn't talk to me. — She squeezed Catra's hands. Searching for some comfort. — Am I your friend? Is that all that I am to you?

— Is that all that you want to be?

— Catra, you…know.

— I don't, Adora. — The feline said quietly. — I really don't…I used to hold your hand, I used to share food with you, wrapped my tail in every bit of skin I could, scent marked you, purr like crazy…and still, you only saw me as a friend.

Oh, how Adora felt like a fool, like a complete oblivious idiot.

— I…I didn't know. — As she started, Catra let go of her hand. — I thought we could never be anything but friends. Things were so stressful but then, I barely even thought about it…I know the others there were sneaking out and doing whatever but breaking rules for a long time wasn't my thing.

— Yeah, I know, Adora. — The feline sat on her bed. — Don't bother, I'm over it.

— You are?! — Adora almost tripped over as she entered the room. — I mean…that's good.

— I can't be mad at you for not liking me back when we are 14… it's very behind us. — Catra started to undress, first her shoes. — don't worry.

— What makes you say that? — Everything inside Adora was catching fire.

— Say what?

— That I didn't like you. — Catra got up to take off her blazer and went to the bathroom. — I sure as hell did. — Catra turned. — well I do, I like you, a lot…I wouldn't be such a mess if I didn't. I don't want us to be just friends, Catra.

What preceded that almost killed Adora, she wasn't sure honestly if it did indeed kill her. Because as Catra started to unbutton her shirt Adora wasn't sure of anything anymore, not even of reality itself. All she had was the light coming from the moon, but it was enough, enough to see the lace peeking underneath it made her brain short circuit. The moment Catra's hands touched her belt Adora legs trembled and a slight ache settled on her lower belly. Adora didn't know what to do, so she didn't do anything, she stood there and watched the belt being removed. The odd eyes didn't blink for a second, taking in all and every single reaction, she could smell it too. It wasn't necessarily a power play, she wanted Adora to take the first step in that direction, after hearing her talk about sexuality she had made her mind up about it, she would not initiate anything, even though she badly wanted to.

And as soon as her hands touched the button of her pants, Catra turned to her closet to grab her clothes and change into something to sleep, leaving Adora aroused beyond her comprehension.

Adora was already wearing what she planned to sleep on, a black tank top and loose unicorn shorts. When Catra returned to the room Adora was nowhere near recovering, which meant seeing Catra's thighs wasn't helping her at all. She tried no to focus too much on the way the silk molded her body, or how her nipples were extremely visible.

— Do you have any side you prefer to sleep? — The question brought Adora back to the realm of the living.

— No, not really…— Her gaze kept on wandering as Catra walked in front of the bed.

— Adora. — The blonde looked up. — I need you to relax. I won't do anything, don't worry. — Adora somehow had almost all of her muscles flexed, she was tense and they both knew why. — You can touch me if you want. — Catra sat on the bed and offered her hand.

Blue eyes softened when they held hands again, they ended sitting side by side, the exact same way they were before, resulting in the same relaxed Adora, who could now hear the low purr. Their hand stood between their bodies, which allowed Adora to caress Catra's thigh with her thumb, it wasn't inherently sexual, it was simply intimate.

— I'm sorry. — The sadness in her voice made Catra immediately stop purring. — I wish I could do this with more…I wish I could just go for it, I'm sorry. I don't know…

— What are you talking about? — Catra sat up straight to look her in the eye.

— Sex. — She didn't blush. — I am not sure what I'm supposed to do.

— I'm not mad at you because you're not jumping me, Adora. — They both laughed. — I won't rush you…but it's weird you're thinking about sex when we haven't kiss yet.

— Is that not…what leads to sex? — The Innocence almost made Catra purr again. — I didn't want to start something I can't finish.

— Kissing is not just about getting somewhere after it. Kissing it's is own thing. A different form of intimacy. — Catra sat on her lap, almost at her knee. — Take this for example. — She took Adora's hands gently, placing a kiss on top of each. — A kiss is a show of affection. — She moved again, this time almost getting out of bed. — Or devotion. — She lifted Adora's right ankle to place a kiss on the side of her foot. — You see, there are many things you can show with a kiss. — Blown out pupils were a dizzying sight.

As Catra moved up Adora pulled her by the waist, bodies pressed together making them both shiver. Adora brushed her nose against the feline's.

— *Can I kiss you*? — The question made Catra's head spin.

— Please do. — She said smiling.

The touch of their lips came slowly, tenderly, like two clouds gently becoming one. The way Adora seemed to be tasting it drove Catra mad. Her shy tongue pressing against soft lips to feel, to learn, and Catra let her, she let her bit, suck, lick as her hands made a mess of Catra's fur. The kiss ended but they didn't pull away, they were still brushing their noses. Adora felt like more and more she understood what intimacy could be like.

It could be sharing a meal, sharing the news about your day, even just laughing together. It could be a kiss.

Building Trust

Chapter Notes

Trigger warning for mention of bullying.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The kiss developed into a lot of kisses, one better than the other. Adora was getting better and better and the problem was Catra didn't know how much of it she could take without at least a little more skin contact. Adora's hands roamed inside of her night gown, caressing her back and that stunt made Catra choked a moan.

— Adora. — She broke the kiss. — I think…— Being apart and breathing properly again knocked all of her senses out, the smell of arousal made her dizzy and lustful. — I need some air.

The feline got out of bed and went to the bathroom. She took deep breaths there. Unsure on what to do, Adora was taking things slowly but Catra's body was so needy and touch starve she was afraid of coming from just the kisses. She soon heard a soft knock on the door.

— it's everything okay? — Even Adora's voice was making a mess of her panties.

She opened the door.

— The smell in the room is…hard to be there and not let it influence me. — She said, still very much smelling said smell.

— Influence you how? — The energy was still out and at the moment Adora wasn't not seeing much but silhouette. She wished she could see the feline expression, but at least Catra's ears weren't flat.

— By making me touch you in a way you might not be ready for. — Adora took her by the hand.

— I trust you. And we can…use safe words. This way you will always know my boundaries.

Catra giggled.

— What do you know about safe words, princess.

— Pretty much that they exist, and that's about it. — The blonde squinted her eyes as she tried to elaborate. — And you know, what they're use for.

— it's usually a bdsm thing but we can definitely use them too. — They laid in bed facing each other. — It's a good idea. And we can do the color system.

— The whole red, green. — Catra nodded.

— And yellow to slow down…it was my color for what we just did, I think yellow because I'm not sure what I can or can't do. — Adora took the change in position to sit on Catra's lap. — What are you doing?

— I always wanted to do this. — Catra loved the view from under her. — Your legs feel so soft…and I'm not sure myself what it's fine, but we can figure it out as we go. And use the color system. If I were to kiss again now, what color would you give me?

— Green.

Adora laid on top of Catra, her lips touched the soft lips briefly to soon kiss Catra's neck and collarbone. The feline felt a bit exposed by how their dynamic was going.

— Adora. I want to… touch you more, what color? — It was hard talking while Adora's lips were making her body shiver.

— Green. — The blonde locked her eyes on Catra's.

— Where? — As much as she was eager she was big on explicit consent, she wouldn't push anything Adora wasn't verbally okay with.

— I can guide your hand. — She offered and Catra nodded.

Adora gently took Catra's wrist, and right when she touched Adora's thighs, another thunder hit, she had to pull her hand away to not claw Adora.

— I fucking hate thunder! — She said exasperated.

Adora held her, petting her mane, she started to do her best to soothe Catra. They both knew nothing was going to happen for the rest of the night, so they did their best to sleep. It was crazy for Catra to have someone besides her the entire night, they kept caressing each other up until the point of falling asleep.

Catra was the one to wake up first to make sure Finn was alright. Only in the morning the energy had returned and the storm calmed into a heavy pouring rain. Finn was alright and shared the bed with Melog. As she went back to her room Adora was awake and yawning.

— Sorry to wake you. — Catra got under the covers again and got closer to scent mark Adora. — Do you need to go now?

Adora missed being scent mark, Catra's fur felt nice and cozy, and the meaning of it just made her happy. She pulled her into a hug.

— No, I can stay for a while…I have something to ask. — The daylight allowed Catra to see the slight blush. — There's this… event that I was invited to and don't want to show up there alone. You said you owe me, and I was wondering if you…

— Yes, I'll go with you. — Catra gave her a little peck on the lips. — What's the event?

— It's a celebration of our victory against the horde. Something like that, I'm not quite sure. — She shrugged. — It was all Bow…

he asked Glimmer to invite Scorpia too. So I think she's coming… they were going to invite you too but I wanted to ask you myself.

Another peck.

— If I can bring Finn with me than I can go. — Catra whispered against Adora's mouth.

Adora got lost in her touch, soon deepening the kiss and laying on top of Catra. The feline bit her lower lip and Adora moaned, melting into the feeling.

— Sorry. — The blonde said.

— Is okay. — Catra was more than okay with her. — Is it too much? — She tenderly put a strand of hair behind her ear to be able to see Adora's blushed face.

— I don't know. — It was the truth, at moments it felt like too much but mostly it felt like not enough. — You're amazing and everything feels just so good.

— You're amazing too. — Catra said getting ready for another kiss but heard coughing.

They both stopped, Catra could hear more clearly and when nothing else came she knew it was nothing serious.

— Should we check? — The used of 'we' took Catra by surprise. Not even Scorpia talked like that, mostly because she was scared Catra would think she was somehow saying she was not fit to do it alone.

The thing was, she didn't want to do it alone, not anymore, she had nothing to prove to anybody, and Adora was so willing to be part of the family.

— No need, they're okay. — They went back to cuddling, soon Catra was purring and it was her turn to snuggle the blonde. — Adora… — She whispered to see if the other was asleep but a

very low 'huh' stated the opposite. — Do you still have nightmares? You trashed a little during the night.

— I did? Sorry. — Catra caressed her waist over the shirt and still that gave the blonde goosebumps. — It's hard sometimes to sleep, I don't know really what the dream was about, sometimes is just anguish taking over me…waking up and feel all the sweat and my heart is going crazy and can't barely remember what caused it…I talked to Perfuma a lot about triggers and I don't really know what mine are.

—You don't think I am one of them? — Adora couldn't see the ears going flat and how still and lifeless her tail was as she waited for the answer.

— No, we are the only good thing of my past…being around you has actually brought the happy memories back and I thought I didn't have any…I rather hold on to that. — Adora took Catra's hand and started to play with her hand. — I had to deal with a lot with guilt, but finally having closure and being with you now it's just peaceful.

— So why the nightmares? You don't have to lie if you do think it has something to do with me. I'm a adult and I can handle it.

— It's not about you. It's about me…I think before going to bed I was just anxious that now that we're together I'm about to fuck everything up because I have no experience.

— That's bullshit, Adora. I don't mind going slowly, honestly I'm pretty sure I need us to go slow too. — Catra's admission made Adora turned and face her. Blue eyes full of love and curiosity. — I told you already…after Finn, things got a bit dry to say the least. After being a mom, even if I didn't birth them, it's hard to see yourself pass that role, I just don't put myself in situations where I'm more than a mom. I know mom's are desirable, very desirable — Adora laughed. — That's not really it…it's more about how I feel, I think about Finn first in every situation, like yesterday I didn't want anything to go past kissing because what if they

needed something and I was too busy with you to notice. And I honestly don't want to see it as a distraction from motherhood, I want to fully enjoy being with you.

It was Adora's turn to give a peck full of adoration. It made her at ease to know they both needed things to go slow, it was comforting even. The desire was there, burning and waiting, but they had been waiting for such a long time, they could do it for a little longer.

X

Catra's head was spinning, a headache like no other throbbing in between her eyes. it had been almost a week since she and Adora had started to be more than friends. Communication was hard for them those days because of work, being away while Finn was sick meant a million things needed to be done and as fast as possible.

It was taking a lot for everything to come together, the project needed years to be finished and every day it seemed further and further. A accident happened during demolition, five people were injured, doing everything so fast had proven to not be the best option, they needed to it right, Catra never wanted to say fuck it to deadlines as much as she did that week.

She couldn't just push people and put them in danger in order to get what she wanted, she wasn't a dictator. Her military brain really had her running everything like everyone working for her was a soldier following orders, no matter the risk. Scorpia had given her warnings about pushing it and trying to squeeze as much work as possible in the shortest amount of time. She did care for them, she cared for everyone working with them to build a better Fright Zone. In the end, they decided to focus on demolishing every single factory with carefulness, making sure no more accidents could happen and that everyone was safe, all deadlines be damned. They were also working on a way to clean the air, mostly Entrapta, who also managed to create more efficient masks, preventing other people from being as sick as Finn was living there.

She barely saw them too. They had very few minutes during dinner and the practices were getting tougher, the kid was sleeping like a rock. Adora was training as hard as them at the rate they were both going. Both were closer now that Adora felt comfortable sharing stories about her past, she told them very little about Catra though, not wanting to take it away from her.

Catra sighed as she remembered their last dinner, she had been so tired she barely had time to process everything probably. She had kissed Adora, multiple times, she could say hi with a kiss, she could hug and cuddle her, everything she wanted, it was hard to believe. She still wanted to make an official request, they were together but none of them said the word girlfriend or partner, it was a label and Catra didn't care much for it but knowing the both of them it was clear they needed everything to be laid on the table, miscommunication being such a issue, one they both were trying hard to get through.

— Catra…can I come in? — Glimmer's voice somehow didn't make Catra's headache worse and that was a sign she truly saw the other as a friend. — I brought these.

A cup of water and a pill sat on a plate waited her. She had barely mentioned the headache during a break. She smiled thankfully at Glimmer.

— Thank you, sparkles. — Everything in her office was dim, the light was truly hurting her eyes and somehow Glimmer was shinny still. — How are you holding up? I bet having so many meetings with Entrapta is driving you insane.

— I think I'm getting a hold on how to explain things to her…more or less I'm just teaching her about human rights, and laws and safety of other people. — Catra couldn't help but laugh. — It's funny, haha, laugh all you want, we need her.

Glimmer sat at the small couch in Catra's office.

— Scorpia sent me a photo of her and the guys who got hurt. — She turned her computer screen for Glimmer to see the three people posing in hospital gowns and Scorpia lifting two others. — I think they're better. — They laugh in a way It showed they were clearly tired.

— Are you alright? — The question as always didn't have the most easy answer. — I know it was hard, but is not the end, it was just one accident, and we know now what to do to prevent it.

— I've been worrying a lot and I don't know if we can really do this. — That came out effortlessly and it showed who tired Catra was, no energy to waste on whether or not she should unborden on Glimmer. Why wouldn't she when all the other had shown her was support and kindness? — In the paper everything seems so easy but it's not, it takes so many people to be able to do this. It's an entire city being rebuilt. It's a fucking insane thing to do…I should've listen when they said it was stupid to do this.

Glimmer got up.

— Hey, no, you shouldn't listen to any of that…okay? It's a lot of work, and it takes a lot of people, but all of those people believe in the same thing we do. Do you know how many of them are from the Fright Zone? More than half, they want their home back as much as you do. And we are the only ones willing to try and do this. So do you really want to throw all of this away just because we had our first accident? There's going to be a lot more of them. Believe me! — Catra closed her eyes. — I know you're tired, I'm tired too but I know you want to see this through, it's just a rough week, it'll get better.

Catra nodded. Truly acknowledging her friend's words.

— Did Bow said that to you? — She humoured.

— Haha…maybe. — They both laughed. — Talking about my husband, I hope you're going to the event, the celebration of the

horde defeat… don't tell her I told you but Adora is freaking out trying to find a dress you'll like.

— She is? — Catra would never imagined Adora caring about her opinion so much in that area.

— Yeah, big time, never saw this girl wanting to impress so much.

How could Catra not be impressed? Adora didn't need to do anything and she already looked beautiful. She realized very quickly she and Finn would need to go shopping or find a tailor.

— Any clues on what color she might be thinking?

— Why don't you ask her? I'm sure she will love to be matching… okay I gotta head out and let you finish up…just another boring meeting. The things I do for you. — Catra blew her a kiss.

The feline did ask Adora about the color of her dress, and as she read the word black she couldn't help but feel alert, to say the least.

— Oh, fuck me. — She cursed and then laughed a little at her choice of words. — Yeah…as if that was bad thing.

Catra rolled her eyes at herself for talking alone. She hadn't seen the dress yet but just knowing the color had enough of an impact.

X

— Come on! Let me see you! — Catra got out of the dressing room. Very unsure of how she looked. — Oh…I don't know, mom.

— What?! Is that bad? — She looked in the mirror and the fishtail really was a poor choice. — Yeah. I see it.

They got closer to examine the fit. Catra didn't understand how she ended up raising such a judgmental kid when it came to clothes, hers at least.

— You need to look good. Is your first date with Adora.

— It's not a date, there's going to be a bunch of people there. — She went back to the dressing room to try their next pick. — And Adora is going to be surrounded there. I'm just going to look pretty next to her and that's about it…and you need to find something too.

— I already pick out my suit and kilt. — They said very proudly.

Catra got out of the dressing room again, the pants looked fine and she loved a silk shirt, but the blazer was too big. She didn't need to ask Finn's opinion, she simply went to change again.

— This is hard. — She growled. She eyed the last and most bold choice. — Please work.

As she put on the outfit and looked in the mirror, right away it was the best she had ever looked.

— Let me see! — Finn whined.

— You're going to love it.

As they left the place, Finn had asked to eat out, mostly because Sea-Hawk told them about a new play happening in the restaurant. Adora was still teaching so she couldn't join. But it was nice for Catra to have a moment with Finn.

— So how's training? — The kid looked less tired than usual.

— Hard. Adora makes me run, and that's the worst. But I've gotten strong and I even beat Frosta. — Catra smiled proudly. — Adora told me a lot about her childhood…and how rough was after running away, to fit in.

— Are you? Having a hard time to fit in? — To say she felt worried as a euphemism. — Is anyone bullying you in school? — The way Finn's ears went flat told her everything she needed to know. — Really? Did they hurt you?

— No. It's just stupid name calling, and…somebody left a dead rat on my locker. — Catra's claws damaged the table, she didn't meant to look so aggressive but it was impossible to control it. — They didn't touch me, I promise.

— When was this Finn? Why didn't you say anything? — She didn't want to sound mad at them, but she was frustrated with the situation.

— Because…I thought I could handle it alone…I'm big enough now, and you're so busy. — They grabbed their tail to start petting it, it helped them relax. — I didn't fight, but I…I got into the pool to beat them, and I won. He was supposed to be the captain of the swim team and he lost!

— I can't believe that's why you went into the pool…because of a bully, Finn. I told you a million times you're so much more important than stupid work! I love you, you're my child, my kid! My responsibility, Finn! You're my responsibility, you're not supposed to be doing things like this by yourself. — She took a deep breath to make sure her fangs didn't seem like a threat too. — I'm going to go to your school tomorrow morning, we're both talking to the principal.

They nodded. It blew Catra's mind to know something like that was going on with her kid, it broke her heart. Finn really needed to open up to her more, she didn't realize they felt grown up enough to try and hide such a big issue, when younger Finn would always tell her of any signs of trouble, she didn't realize nor felt they had grown apart but that, that attitude, it showed differently. She new more people around them meant a lot more trouble but nothing like that crossed her mind.

— You're okay, mom? — They took her hand.

— If I'm okay? I'm the one who should be asking that…it's not easy to got through something like that, no matter if it was just name calling. — Catra held their hand tight. — I love you and I

don't want anything bad to happen to you ever even when I know they will.

Finn smiled.

— I'm okay. Some things they said hurt for a while but being with Adora helped, I was using what happened as I don't know…fuel maybe, and they had such dumb comments, about my ears and tail…those were just stupid. — They said with such acid to their tone, Catra felt like she was looking at a mirror for a second. — And the ones about my pronouns were even dumber.

Another deep breath and a gulp of water.

— I want you to talk to me about this things, and if you don't feel like you can, I want you to talk to somebody else. A therapist. — Their food arrived and the play was about to start. — I know being with Adora is helping and it's a good way of dealing but you need to talk about it too. Trust me when I say this…— Another deep breath. — I have been through a lot, and nothing helped like talking, as much as I hate to admit it.

— Good night my little seashells. — Sea-hawk voice shortened the conversation. — Today is the debut of our new play, I hope everyone loves it as much as I know you all love me.

X

Melog had gotten used to sleeping with Finn and it was a change Catra didn't mind too much while considering Adora was going to be around a lot more. She decided to tuck Finn in bed but the smaller feline was sitting on the ground as they put some puzzle together.

— It's late. — Finn looked at her for a second before returning to the puzzle. — Go to bed, Finn.

It was their turn to take a deep breath.

— You say I need to talk to you about things, but you don't talk to me about…things. — Finn got up and stomped their way to bed.

— It's not so simple. — Catra got closer and sat on the bed to tuck them in. — I don't know if you're old enough for me to tell these things…I don't think I will ever think you are…I'm scared of what you'll think of me after knowing it.

— You're my mom, no matter what it is, I'll love you still. — The eager eyes looking at her made her smile. — Please, mom. I want to know you.

Catra nodded. As she laid next to them Melog joined in, thanks to them there was a soothing color lighting up the entire room.

— I was raised in a military school, and I had a lot bad things happen to me there, I was thrown into this small dark place with no food for days, I didn't control much of anything I did.— She closed her eyes to say what scared her the most. — *I hurt people*, a lot of people, I was merciless, and I honestly don't know how I didn't kill anyone at that time…and I didn't care, at all, I just wanted to win. — Melog started to purr next to her. — I had a lot of help to deal with all of that anger, some of it was because of how my life was and some of it was because of Adora.

— Adora? — The kid who was only listening couldn't help the small shock. — What about her? She hurt you?

— Like I said in the beginning, it's complicated. — She started to pet Melog. — Adora grew up with me, the same terrible childhood, she found a way out, to run away. She did and I didn't, I stayed behind, it was my decision and I blamed her, I blamed her for so many things after that, including leaving me…but that's not fair to her, after meeting again we talked a lot about it…we're okay.

— How okay are we talking. — The smug question made Catra regret telling them anything.

— We're not talking about that today. Now go to sleep. — She got up and kissed them good night.

— Mom. — Finn said before she left the room. — You know you're not a bad person right? Even if you hurt people in the past. Right now you're the kindest person I know, working so hard to give everyone from the Fright Zone their home back. You're great.

She went back and hugged them tight.

— I love you so much.

— I love you. — They whispered back.

She walked out of the room before she started to cry and to avoid any uncomfortable questions that could surface. She felt weightless when walking out of the door. So happy to have finally shared with Finn and to see that they were not judging her. To think such an amazing kid was having a hard time at school made her heart break into pieces. But she's going to fix that, and make sure Finn was safe and well, physically and mentally.

She texted Adora before going to sleep, hoping for a video call with the blonde. Catra did her best to look good in the camera, even if she was just planning it to further explain what had happened to Finn. The screen was black at first.

— Adora? — Catra wasn't sure if the call was working. — Are you there?

— Just a second. — The voice from the other side made her smile instantly. — Just putting on a shirt.

Catra wanted to say something snarky but decided to stay quiet, she didn't want to side track from what she decided to talk about.

Adora's forehead was the first thing to appeared on the screen and soon she started to place it right.

— It's everything alright? — The blonde was wearing a very baggy white shirt that was a little transparent. She could see Adora's silhouette. — I know it is late but I really need to talk to you.

— It's alright, it's not that late.

— Is about Finn…they…they've been bullied. — She said in one long breath. — And I'm going to school tomorrow to see if I can do anything to make sure it doesn't happen again.

Adora's expression was blank for most of what Catra said.

— I…they told me…they told me there was a little competition between them and this swim team boy, and I didn't know! I…fuck.

— I just wanted to tell you because you guys are spending a lot of time together, if anything, I mean anything seems off to you, please tell me. — Adora nodded. Still processing. — They said nothing physical happened and I believe them but this boy needs to get expelled or something.

— I promise I'll tell you. I want them to be safe.

The phone's battery was dying.

— I think I'm going to hang up, my battery is about to die. — She sighed. — I love you, good night.

Saying it felt so effortless, nothing in her could've stopped her from say those words, no denial or self sabotage could tame how much love and appreciation she felt for Adora just being there in that moment even from a far.

— *I love you*.

Chapter End Notes

I ended up turning this into a series.
I'm going to be continuing this story in the next part of the series. So after chapter 10 if anyone is interested in knowing

what's next I'll be posting part two soon after this one is done.

Take Your Time

Adora walked and every step felt heavier, the air in her lungs grew fainter, she looked behind and saw nothing but a huge chain behind her, the same chain wrapped around her body, the same chain the was taking her strength away, she didn't know for how much long she could do it, the chains were so heavy her skin was breaking and bleeding as the metal seemed to be fusing into her skin. Adora screamed, loud and desperate to be released, to be free, to not hold on to those chains anymore. Her scream came out muted, no sound, nothing but the air escaping her lungs, she looked around desperate, she needed help, she needed someone to free her. But why was she still walking? Why couldn't she just stop and take a break? Why couldn't she try herself to break the chains? She screamed again and nothing, no sound, no response. Adora knew her body was about to give up, and as soon as her face hit the ground, she opened her eyes.

— Oh fuck! — She took deep breaths, the sweat made her shirt cling to her body. — Fuck, fuck, fuck.

Almost as a mantra it helped her grounded herself to keep on repeating. The nightmare's feelings lingered in her skin making her squirm involuntarily, the metal breaking her skin felt so painful Adora needed to take a look around her loft and make sure she was truly awake. Her dress took a smile out of her in the midst of all that agony.

Thinking about Catra's kisses had been her way to settle into reality, remembering her body of the good sensations, of the times she was treated with care and love.

The other step was routine, her morning workout, shower, breakfast. It was one of those rare days that Adora didn't have work. She had to be ready for the evening, and before that she had no plans on what to do with her day. So she did the only thing she could think about and went to the museum.

It was hard going there again without Razz to tell her stories and even stranger when Light Hope wasn't around. She missed them both so badly. But it was still part of her. There were always new exhibitions in the lower floors but the last one was reserved for She-ra.

It was so crazy that Adora took on that mantle. She still couldn't believe that later that night her own part was going to be assembled in the hall. Bow had planned that and Adora had no clue, no clue at all, she would never even imagine herself out there, with legends. All those women who too fought for a better future through protests. Even when being called She-ra was more of a burden than an honor, I would always in the end be an honor, no matter what. Maybe she was sentimental, she wanted to see the place before her image was part of it. She felt that seeing herself there with them somehow symbolized those days were over, no more fighting the Horde.

— You…— She whispered at Mara's statue. — I can't believe I get to be here…with you.

All anxiety had dissipated at that moment. It was just Adora geeking out as she read for what could be truly the millionth time, about Mara's past and achievements, it did what it was did, and made Adora feel motivated and inspired, although mostly she felt loss, even if she never met Mara she felt like she knew her. She and Light Hope would watch old tapes of her and the blonde felt like they could be best friends, even the bad jokes, it felt like they were the same sometimes.

Adora walked back to see the new exhibitions, lingering around the She-ra tributes would only make her sad and anxious.

She liked museums a lot, seeing new art and sculptures just brought out the emotions she dare not say out loud. The place was fairly packed, she thought Bow was going to lock it down but he was probably too worried about denying people art. She also noted to thank Bow's dads for their part in the whole thing, being

big historians had a huge impact in getting the place to hold the party.

— The beauty of women. — Adora read the title of the next exhibit without much thought to it.

As always she entered with an open mind, she was met with something she had never seen before in display, erotic art, to be more specific, saphic erotic art. Every portrait was indeed beautiful, the passion in the paintings, the way they touched each other. Those were truly invoking feelings Adora was very much used to shoving in a box. She couldn't help the slight sweaty hands, or how her breathing was short, nor the warmth all around her body. She didn't shy from it, she faced every single one of them head on.

The diversity in body types made her happy, each couple so different from the other, beautiful women loving beautiful women. One of them was titled 'Not a woman nor a man', and that portrait made Adora unbelievably happy. She took her time, walked around, and tried to exercise something Perfuma had asked of her, to understand her own pleasure she needed to know what she liked, and why not do it through art? She moved from one painting to the other trying to decipher what made her mind and body lustful, to soon find out, all of them did.

X

— Come on Adora. — Bow shoved her as they drove to the event. — There's no need to be nervous, you spoke in public a million times, why is this different?

She rolled her eyes at him.

— Before I was speaking for a cause, Bow! This is just bragging.— He looked at her with the most seriousness he could master. — I don't know what to say, ask your wife.

— She said you should do it…please, Adora. — They gave her the puppy eyes.

Adora tried her hardest to ignore them, she truly tried.

— Oh fine! — She let out. — But I need to prepare something, I will not improvise.

Bow smiled big. They were almost there. She decided to meet with Catra at the entrance because Bow decided to pick her up to convince her to make a speech, his plan was successful.

The museum had all the lights on, each with a different color, it looked like a completely different place from outside, she couldn't even begin to imagine what they had done inside.

— I'm gonna go inside and see if my dads are here already. — Adora nodded as they got out of the car.

— Okay, Catra said she's almost here. — Adora looked down to make sure her dress looked okay. — I'll be right there as soon as she and Finn are here.

The chill music coming from inside helped her calm down as she waited. Anxiety was not the best companion ever but it was even worse on that particular night. She truly wanted things to go smoothly with Catra, it was their first time going out together as an item. She took calming breaths to make sure she wouldn't throw up.

Catra's car passed the building and she parked a little far from the entrance however Adora could still see her, not as well as she wished but still. Finn was the first to show and hug her, wearing a maroon suit with a matching kilt, Adora loved the chains around the kilt.

— You look so gorgeous. — They said, gasping at Adora.

The black dress sparkled and Adora stood out easily, it had a bit of volume to it making a bit princess like, combined with a very nice cut that showed enough cleavage, the spaghetti strings letting the strong shoulders shine and at the bottom the leg slit, the star of the dress, exposed muscular thighs to take everyone's

breath away. Her long hair was down, she wore very little to no makeup, the most striking part was the black lipstick.

— You don't look bad yourself, Finn. — She smiled. — Frosta is already there if you want to go ahead. —They didn't let her finish and ran inside. — Wow. — Adora said as soon as Catra was in sight.

The other wore a full suit, black, the thing was, it had a very unique cut, and not because of her tail, Catra's back and waist was exposed, no shirt under it, she could easily see the sides of her breast and the lines of her lower back. Adora had no words.

— Cat got your tongue? — Catra said as Adora stood with her mouth agape.

— No, but you could. — Catra smiled at the response. — You look so beautiful…just wow.

— Have you seen yourself? I thought art was supposed to be inside the museum, not out here. — They both ended up laughing, but it didn't stop Adora from blushing, hard.

— May I? — She offered Catra a hand.

They both got in together, holding hands and blushing. Glimmer was the first to notice the pair, speaking loud enough that Bow saw them and joined in the overenthusiastic reaction. It only made the blushing worse.

— Where is my kid? — Catra whispered to herself, ignoring the couple. — Adora, I'm gonna go look for Finn.

— Oh yeah, I'll tag along. — They kept their arms locked as they walked.

Adora hoped they had closed the floor above because she wouldn't be able to handle Finn seeing the same thing she saw in her last visit. Thankfully they were staring at sculptures as Frosts tried to replicate the pose and then it was Finn's turn to try.

— Let them have fun, if they need anything they'll find me. — Catra held Adora's waist and the blonde choked on air. — So…I was thinking…Scorpia is coming later today and she offered to take care of Finn for the night. — Adora tried to not look too alerted. — We don't have to do anything, but I'll like to spend the night with you…I like sleeping next to you.

Adora nodded, words failing her as she tried to not spiral. Catra was going to go to her house, just the two of them, alone, in a bed, no pressure, but a lot of want. And Adora didn't trust herself at that moment, not when Catra back was all exposed and her curves looked so good in those pants, and oh Adora needed to calm down.

— I'm very okay with that. — Adora ended up saying. — So… how's the project going?

Catra took a deep breath as they walked around.

— We have a lot to do, but Glimmer is keeping me sane…I do think that at some point I might need to go back there myself, and I don't know how exactly because Finn can't go back there, not yet.

Adora let her arm rest around Catra's shoulders.

— You'll figure out.

— Yeah…probably. — Adora guided Catra to the beginning of the exhibition. — Do you know a lot about this?

The sculptures were metal bent, melted and painted to create art.

— It's about self love, this one is when you don't, that's why it is so sad and heavy and you can't barely see a figure. A ball of metal, a ball of burden that doesn't allow you to see who is there, in the middle of this. — Adora wished she didn't identify with that sculpture in particular as much as she did. — I feel like this one most days, like everything that happened will always be a shadow that swallows me whenever something good happens…so.

Catra hugged her.

— I feel like that too, not always but sometimes. — The hug allowed Adora to smell Catra and that scent was home itself. — And look. — Catra took her hand to see the next sculptures. — It gets better, you can see more and more of the person, and less of the burden.

They saw the rest of them in silence, both taking in art in their own way, feeling and understanding, the touching project was still being imitated by the kids trying to pose. It was nice to have them there, bringing a more light mood to the environment. People came little by little and when almost everyone had gathered, Bow started to serve drinks and tiny food, a request Adora didn't know where it came from.

— Bow asked me to do a speech…I don't really know what to say. — They ended up sitting on the tables that were spread across the place, it was like the most beautiful and artistic restaurant ever. — I was wondering if you wouldn't happen to… I don't know, want to talk? Like… it's a nice group of people and you can talk about the project, and get more people to know about your work.

Bow was waiting tables and soon got closer to them, giving them an extra wink as they left.

— He's unbearable, I understand now why Glimmer is married to them. — Catra mumbled. — It's he going to be mad about you not talking?

— I can introduce you. — Adora wanted her to say yes. — Please, is just…what's the point of me going up there and saying 'hey look I'm special and did things, give me an award' and it wasn't just me…plus the fight might be over but you have the fallout to deal with, I want to help you.

Catra nodded. It was hard to think about work when Adora looked like that, it was hard to think of anything really.

— Thank you. — Knowing there were a lot of influential people at the event meant that speaking could truly help them.

— Wow…you look so beautiful, wildcat. — Scorpia's voice took them by surprise, Catra smiled at the nickname, even though she wasn't the most fond of it, it was just so Scorpia she couldn't help the little grin.

As she turned and got up she saw Scorpia in her red gown.

— You're not falling too behind. You look nice. — Scorpia did a twirl. — And Finn is going to flip when they see you.

And soon Scorpia was surrounded by two kids who barely let her wave to Adora as they pulled her to try and pose like them.

— Finn really likes her,huh…the other day at the lake, they were inseparable. — Adora commented.

— Yeah, I think they like her a lot more than me. — She eyed Adora — Don't be jealous.

Before Adora could protest, Perfuma sat next to her.

— Do you guys know who that is? Frosta is oddly comfortable around them.

Adora took another look to see Frosta climbing Scorpia somehow.

— She helped us clean the lake, so Frosta met her there and Finn grew up with her. — Perfuma took note. — She's great with kids, but you can totally ask Frosta how she feels about her.

— No. Is fine. I trust your judgment. — Perfuma took another look at her daughter and felt at ease to see her smiling. — She never plays with me like that anymore.

Catra couldn't help but me feel the same.

— Yeah, Finn is like that too, they never ask me to play anymore… but with Scorpia…is a different conversation.

— Don't be jealous. — Adora whispered in her ear. — Oh no…Bow is coming.

As the host of the event got closer Adora looked at Catra, hopeful the feline was going to do as she said.

— Ready? We're going to uncover your photo here and it will be on the right floor tomorrow. — Bow said and smiled. — I can't believe we get to put you there, you deserve it so much.

— Yes, she does. — Glimmer appeared, scaring Catra as usual. — And now she has a speech to make. Right 'Dora?

They had improvised a little podium, no mic, just somewhere for her to be the center of attention. She walked slowly with no rush to get there, Catra followed behind taking a quick look at Finn before moving a bit further from where they seemed to be in a staring contest with Frosta. Seeing them like that made her wonder if she should talk to Perfuma about the kids maybe visiting each other. And it would be nice to have a place for Finn to go when Adora and her decided to have a date, something she hoped would happen soon.

— Hello everyone…first of all, thank you all for being here. — The blush was so visible already. — I'm honored, and I can't even believe this is even happening…but I'll like to give this moment to someone who really has something to say and something to fight for still. So please give a round of applause to Catra, that person who is responsible for the project phoenix, which aims in bringing the Fright Zone from the ashes to a new and better city.

As they switched places everyone was clapping.

— Thank you. — She took a little bow. — I am not doing any of it by myself, so your claps shouldn't be for me alone…I'm honestly here to say it has been hard. — She sighed. — We don't have enough support to make this happen in our planned calendar, we

are struggling a lot every step of the way… I'm not one to ask for help, but this is not for me or about me, a lot of you here are rich, and have power and could do some good by helping us. I'm not begging, so if you're truly interested, you can talk to me or Glimmer during the rest of the part. Just know it's a real change to help better this world with your money. — Catra had swallowed her pride like never before. — Thank you for your attention.

She left the little podium with shaky hands and thankfully Adora was right there to anchor her. The people whispered as they clap, she tried not to stare and act polite. They went back to their table.

— You did good. Didn't curse at any of them. — Adora joked. — I'm sure someone will come talk to you.

Before Adora could even finish Glimmer showed up with someone or rather someone grabbed Glimmer and took her to their table.

— Catra, this is my aunt Cas, Who wants to help. — Castaspella gave Adora a big hug.

— Yes, I do! Glimmer never tells me anything, I would've helped from the beginning! It's so obvious you guys need all the funding you can get your hands on and lucky for you I know a lot of people in this party and they love me. — She smiled at them both. — I'll make sure you guys get some signed checks and more people involved. Leave it to me.

— Okay, thank you. — Catra smiled at the lady who was definitely Glimmer aunt, the energy was very similar. — Thank you, very much. — They smiled at each other and soon Castaspella went to do what she said.

— Oh, she is so getting you guys money. — Adora had strong faith in the woman. — You two, don't worry.

X

Soon the party turned into different conversations, the kids looked tired, Scorpia had gotten to met Perfuma and Mermista finally arrived, somehow already drunk. Catra did talked to some people, they offered help and exposure, something she did her best to accept. Adora was getting a bit anxious with all those people thanking her, as if she was some sort of god. She felt dizzy with all the attention.

— Do you wanna go? — Catra whispered to the blonde, pulling her to a corner. — We don't need to stay any longer. Finn and Scorpia are tired too, they're going already.

Finn was fast asleep in Scorpia's arms.

— Are you sure? Don't you need to talk to some other people here?

— Glimmer has got this! Plus Bow and Castaspella are helping… we can go.

Adora nodded. They said a quick bye to everyone and went to meet Scorpia. In the end, Catra dropped them at her house. Finn already knew she was going to spend the night away.

— Good night, have fun. — Scorpia wink before living the car.

At that moment Adora's blush returned.

— Night. — The blonde said back. — So…are you sure you want to come with me?

— Very…are you sure you want me to go? — Catra double checked.

— Yes! — It came out a little louder than she aimed for and with Catra's sensitive ears she felt like the worst person on the planet. — Sorry…yes.

Catra laughed.

— Are you drunk? — The car was still parked.

— No. Just usual me...I don't drink very often and thinking about tonight...I wanted to be sober. — They looked at each other, everything inside them burned, passion mix with fear, anticipation building in levels neither even thought possible. — I didn't want to ruin anything by being drunk.

— Let's go to your house then. — As the car started, so did a new type of tension. — Did you like tonight?

It was harder for the blonde to concentrate in even the easiest task.

— Uhum…yes. — She tried not to look, not to stare, but her eyes were fixated on Catra, on her lips, her eyes, all the exposed parts of her body. Adora wanted to touch her. — Did you?

Catra nodded. Driving meant she needed to focus, not that she didn't notice the way Adora was looking, or how every time they stopped at a red light she could hear how heavy Adora was breathing. She wondered if it was anxiety.

— The best part of tonight was you, especially that dress. — Catra did an over dramatic wink. — But seriously, thank you, It meant a lot to me that you did that.

— Anytime. — As they parked again, Adora tried to get out of the car faster than Catra, doing her best to get to the other side and open the door for her. The perplexed expression made her smile. — Let's go? — There was no pressure behind her act.

She offered her hand and Catra took it with a pounding heart.

— So old fashioned. — She joked. And yet Catra was blushing and couldn't hold her smile.

Getting into the spirit she linked their arms like an old couple would. Going upstairs was sweet and a bit clumsy as they tried to keep their arms together.

— Here we are. — Adora opened the door to her loft. — There's not much to it…I've only been living here for two years, it's not very…home. — Catra walked around inspecting, it was very empty but still cozy. — I don't have a lot of time to decorate.

The gym gear and the photos were the things that piqued Catra's interest.

— Is nice. — The feline turned back to her. Only to see Adora taking her heels off. — Do you need help with the dress?

The truth was, Adora didn't, it was a very easy dress to take off.

— I'd like that. — She shivered even before Catra got close.

First her claws pulled the strings down her shoulders. She couldn't help but kiss the revealed skin.

— You smell so good. — Catra dragged her nose along Adora's collarbone.

Adora placed her hands around Catra's waist, pulling her closer.

— What color? — Her question regarded the tongue she was so gently gracing Catra's lips with.

— Green. — Was all that was said as they start to finally feel each other fully.

There was no fear, no reason to hold back, they could indulge in one another, pulling closer and closer till there was no space left. Tongue met tongue, lip met lip. Adora couldn't help but explore all that was there for her to touch, the soft fur on Catra's back, her waist. Catra's fangs felt so nice during the kiss, a soft pinch now and then was more than welcome by Adora.

She was not aware of her desires, let alone any kinks but one thing she did know was the wanted anything Catra was willing to give. She had no doubt about wanting to go forward, to be as close as she could, to shed herself, as she already felt she was.

She felt bare in front of Catra, bare because she had shared her soul, what was her body but the next thing for Catra to know? To explore? To love as much as she did Adora as a person.

— Catra. — she breathed out. — *Will you be my girlfriend?* — It was the last thing, the last thing she needed so that night could go perfectly.

It took the feline some seconds to go back, to be there, to be present in that moment and not floating away.

— Yes. I'm pretty sure I had already called you my girlfriend to some people at that party. — Her hands felt the shivering. — Adora…what are yours…what are we doing? What are we not doing?

The smell in the room was once again not helping the hybrid. And she was so sensitive, she was never like that, Adora hands burned where they stood and she could feel herself throbbing and aching. She didn't know what to do. Depending on Adora's answer, spending some time in the bathroom was not out of her options.

— Anything you want…I mean it. — Adora took Catra's hand, guiding her to the only thing holding the dress together. — I just need us to go slow…is that okay?

— Very. — She kissed Adora, smiling midst kiss.

The sound of the fabric slipping made them both anxious, the beat of her heart was loud in her ears, she wanted to be calm, to not overreact.

— I think…you have too many clothes on. — Adora whispered, eyes closed as her dress fell on its own.

Even though Catra had better hearing she didn't register anything after the dress fell. No words come to mind, nothing. She didn't touch but oh did she look, admiring every single detail of Adora, mesmerized and feeling a deep guilt as she saw the scars on Adora's abdomen, her claws. Marked there was someone she

wanted to forget, she soon let go, there was so much wonder, and so many scars not done by her, she wanted to care for Adora, to kiss every part, to showed love where others showed pain.

— Beautiful. — Adora's hand didn't try and cover up, all she did was pull Catra close again.

— What color? — Her hands teased at Catra's buttons. — For your pants too.

— Green. — Adora barely waited to start opening the blazer. Catra helped, taking her shoes off and unbuttoning her pants.

Soon they found themselves in equal ground. Only one fabric away from complete nudity.

— Can you lay down? — As Catra nodded they both moved to the bed.

Adora was once again on Catra's lap. And the feline did her best not to moan, the view of Adora on top of her, her breast, her smell, her warmth. It was almost too much.

— Yellow. — She let out surprising them both. — I'm just a bit overwhelmed.

The blonde fixated her eyes on Catra's face.

— Do you want me to move? I can lay next to you? — Adora offered.

— No. Just, come here for a second. — She gestured for Adora to lay on her. — It's a lot. You, your smell, our scents.

Adora could hear how fast her heartbeat was, beyond excited, nervous.

— It's okay. No rush, no pressure. — Adora kept on saying. — We don't have to do anything.

The need building in Catra's underwear was not so kin to the idea. Nor was her starving body. She wanted Adora, so much it was scary.

— Kiss me. — She plead.

Adora tried to go slow, but Catra's lips took all of her reasoning. And being so close, bare, so much skin in contact, she moaned shamelessly as they kissed, managing to keep her hands on the pillows afraid she would overwhelm Catra even more if her hand went anywhere else.

— Fuck. — She moaned when Catra bit her bottom lip pulling inside of her mouth and sucking it.

Adora hips thrusted, she didn't mean to. She wanted to apologize but soon the feline's hands were on her back, moving south.

— Color? — Her question was lost when Adora kissed her deeper, somehow needier. — Ado…ra. — Catra whimpered. — I need you.

Adora nodded, willing to go to the ends of etheria for that woman. She used her hand and mouth to touch and explore. Touching her waist as she kissed Catra's neck as another hand creeped up her belly. She felt Catra kneading her waist. And that little sting, oh that was heaven right there.

— Can I? — Her finger was inches from touching Catra's breast.

— Y-yes.

It was all Adora needed to move, to touch and squeeze and make Catra tremble under her, the response of her body made her hips thrust into Adora, the added friction making the blonde roll her eyes. The quiet moans turned into needy ones. Adora rubbed Catra's nipples with her thumb, slowly, just to hear the weak whimper. She then lowered herself to suck them. Something she had thought about a million times.

— Color? — Adora decided to check in before she kept going.

— I'm okay, green. — The way Adora's tongue swirled around her nipple took her to a different realm. — That's…so good.

Adora did it again only to receive a lovely moan once more.

— Catra. — Adora looked up, not sure why she called the other. — Sorry. — They smiled at each other. — I'm still a little nervous. — Catra palmed her face, kissing her to try and calm the anxious heart. — I don't wanna mess this up.

— You won't. We can do it together. — Catra moved from under Adora. Sitting on her ankles, Adora did the same. — Can I touch you? — Adora nodded. — Words, please.

— Yes. You can touch me. — The full sentence for some reason made Catra blush.

— Mirror me…I'll show you what I like…and this way we can both touch each other.

The claws were safely hidden as she touched Adora's neck. They were close, knees touching keeping everything as intimate as possible. Catra leaned into the warm touch of Adora's hand, she loved Adora's hands, and as her finger made their way to her arms so did Adora's causing the feline to shiver all over. The moment her hands brought other's free hand closer to her mouth she saw it, the way the blue eyes were dominated by lust, for that time Adora didn't follow, too caught in the moment, soon she did it, she had Catra's index playing with her lips and as they parted she suck the same way the feline started doing with hers.

The rise and fall of their chest was synched, the texture of Catra's tongue made Adora moan, she could feel the deep purring too, it was driving her crazy, the feeling, the view, the taste of Catra's finger in her own mouth. Said finger was pulled and went south, wetting her nipple. She did the same, and at the moment she truly couldn't tell if she had come or not. It felt so good and the throbbing on the middle of her legs was absurd.

Keeping eye contact was important for Catra, it was a way to make sure her girlfriend was okay and into it. Catra palmed Adora, making the blonde bite her lip. She didn't give it much attention because overwhelming the blonde wasn't her plan, not for that night. Her hands made their way to her waistband. Not moving further.

— Tell me what color. — Catra could smell the arousal oozing off of them both.

— Yellow.

— Is it okay if I touch you over them? — Catra searched for the best course of action.

— I think so, yes.

She could feel so much even over the fabric, the wetness, the throbbing, the warmth. The second Catra started to rubbed lightly Adora's head fell on Catra's shoulder, shuddering. She held Catra's waist and mimicked the movements over the soaked underwear, the feline could feel who close she was already, and Adora. Adora was seconds from an earth shredding orgasm. Her moans became desperate and so did her ministration, Catra tried not to move but she found herself rocking on Adora's palm. She did her best to rub a little harder but being extra careful with her pressure, Adora was so sensitive that it could easily turn into a painful experience.

To push the blonde to the edge she put her unused hand to work, and the moment her thumbs caressed her nipple it was too much to hold, too much to even keep her hand moving against Catra, she could only cried out and shake, her hands holding Catra close, pulling her into a hug, not being able to talk or do anything as her body shivered, Catra didn't touch her after it, not wanting to hurt Adora.

Even before being able to talk, Adora pushed through, moving her hands, one teased Catra's nipples as the other rubbed her with more precision than before. Adora paid attention to her sounds,

searching for what felt right, what made Catra whimpered, what made her purr, what her come undone, and she did find it, the moment her lips met her neck, she kissed her in every part she could, making her way to the parted and moaning lips. She kissed her, deep and wet, Catra came. Hard and with such need, she held Adora by the wrist making her hands stay there as she thrusted, Catra wanted to make it last. She bit Adora's lips before letting her wrist go. The blonde's body was still having aftershocks.

— *I love you*. — Was the only thing Adora could conjure at that moment.

Receiving the most passionate kiss as a response.

First Steps

Chapter Notes

> There's some rough sketches i did in the end of this chapter. I thought it'll be nice to share in this one.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It took Adora a while to come back down. She didn't let go of Catra for one second, but the embrace was good, it was healing for both. She melted at the feeling of the soft fur.

— Are you okay? — Soft hands caressed the back of the blonde, feeling the scars and muscles.

— Yes, very, I just need us to be close. — It took a lot out of her to go through all of that and most importantly to let go, to finally feel love and care, she could never describe just how weightless she felt. She needed Catra to be in her arms, to make sure it wasn't a dream and most important that all the love was still there, that she was still caring for her.

Catra felt the tears soaking her fur, she held tighter. The silent sniffing made it more apparent that she was crying.

— Talk to me. — Catra spoke softly.

Adora didn't understand how could she feel so nice, how could it be possible to not feel anything pulling her down, bring back the horrible things of her past, nothing whispering dirty thoughts into her mind. The relief just poured out of her, the tears were unavoidable.

— I feel good. — She said in the middle of a broken sob. — I don't think I ever…felt like that before. Not really, not until now, because now I know how it feels. — The tears quieted down. — It's so nice…thank you.

That was the moment Catra realized what Adora meant and felt when it came to sex, it was a lot more than physical, a lot more than just pleasure. She trusted Catra, she was a haven for Adora, full of love and protection, that's why it was so overwhelming, all her emotions were at play, it was not something to take lightly.

— You don't need to thank me. — Catra kissed her forehead. — We can stay here as long as you like.

And they did. Until Adora felt in hold of her body and emotions again, she rested her head on Catra's and slowly went for a kiss welcomed enthusiastically. As they broke the kiss their eyes met, a smile imprinted in both faces.

— Do you want to…keep going? — The reason for the question was Catra's pupils.

The feline felt embarrassed.

— Do you?

— Answer me. — Adora played with the wild mane. — It's different for me. I want you, I want to stay close, in any way you like.

— But I can smell when you're aroused. — She said as the scent once again knocked her senses.

— I can't help it when I'm with you. — She confessed. — It never happens unless it's you. Not like this…before it was hard to feel those things, my body would feel needy and I just wouldn't do anything about it…I fought those feelings, that ached. — Catra listened attentively. — It was a battle between me and my body. Perfuma taught to not see if like that anymore…the…the reason was lack of touch, any sort of touch, and my body just tried to make it up with mes-mesturbaring. It helped, with anxiety and some of my issues. — She leaned in Catra's shoulder again. — It was not like this. I crave you, like I really do, even if you don't touch me I would enjoy doing it. Although I do like it when you touch me, a lot. It's not a burden, you don't have to feel…limited.

Catra nodded. Understanding the best she could as her mind could barely focus after the flash of images of Adora touching herself.

— I have a very high sex drive…well I had. — She look a bit a shame. — It's been awhile.

Adora kissed her cheek.

— Well, I'll do my best to keep up. — Adora kept on kissing her, shoulder, arms, right on her throat before pulling her to a kiss. — I'm sorry for not…letting you touch me… there.

— Hey, no sorrys, not about this. I'm happy you know your limits and I'll always respect you. Always. — She said while keeping eye contact.

Adora nodded.

— I do…want…if you'll like of course. To feel…— Adora couldn't hold her blush. — Your…— Her eyes drifted to Catra's lips.

She settled on placing her index finger on her bottom lip.

— You want me to kiss you…— Adora nodded and brought Catra's hands to her chest to soon guide them down. — Oh…I'll love to that.

Soon Catra's tongue was all over her uper body. Living small bites and kisses, while her claws kneaded her thighs. Adora rolled her eyes at the sensation, moaning mindlessly. She closed her eyes to try to focus on the sensation, on what she was feeling. Soon realizing she wanted Catra's hands somewhere else. Before she could act on her thoughts Catra sucked on her nipple and that alone made her entire body quiver. As she kept going Adora moaned louder, Catra could tell she was getting close from just that, so she stopped. Leaving the blonde confused.

— Why did you stop? — Adora really tried not to sound demanding. Although it did sound like whining.

— Sorry. Force of habit…— And that added little more to Adora's confusion. — Is it okay to touch you over your underwear?

— Yes! — The enthusiastic response made Catra giggled.

They kissed while Catra's hands switched places, the soaked underwear made a deep purr erupted from the feline, Adora wanted to touch her too but she felt so close that nothing on her body was obeying her.

— Relax, Adora. — Catra whispered against her mouth. — Just let go…I'll catch you.

Kissing her again, Adora came, it was as strong as the last one and it took her a couple of minutes to be able to open her eyes. Catra stared at her with heart eyes, observing the lines on her face, the few wrinkles, the 3 strands of white hair. They had been apart for so long and it always hit her hard the same, they were adults.

— *Cat*…what is it? — The blonde managed to look up.

Catra blushed and smiled.

— Nothing, I'm just happy we are here. — A yawn came without warning. Making Catra feel a little embarrassed. — I guess it is not just Finn who has a bedtime.

— I sleep early too. Do you want to take a quick shower?

That idea was good but Catra's sleep was not going to allow her that luxury.

— No but can I have one of your biggest shirts to sleep in?

Adora got up and found the best one she could and tossed it to Catra who put it on and then carefully took her underwear off, throwing the ruined fabric somewhere on the ground. Adora decided to change underwear instead of ditching it completely.

— Good night. — She whispered as they snuggled in each other's arms.

— Night Dora.

Adora would never grow tired of the heavy purring as they fell asleep together.

X

Waking up next to each other was a nostalgic feeling, especially when Catra's tail was somehow trapping Adora close. She didn't have any bad dreams, nor did she trash during the night. She felt completely rested and oddly calm. She couldn't help but still feel certain worry, she wanted to do more for Catra in bed, she knew she would excel at any other task, she could be the best partner and co-parent if she was allowed to be, she really didn't want bad sex to be the reason those things don't get come true.

— Hey, Adora. — The sleepy voice made the blonde smile. — Been awake long?

– Nope…I'm gonna make breakfast for us. — she kissed Catra's forehead before leaving the bed.

It didn't take long for them to feel hungry as the last night activities did take a lot of energy out of both.

Catra watched as her girlfriend made them breakfast, it was sexy, Adora wearing nothing but a shirt making them so over complicated toast, her hair in a messy bun, the strong legs were completely exposed. Catra couldn't look away.

Adora didn't have a table, so they ate in bed. Silently munching and slurping. Adora had never seen Catra eat so much, the feline never had an appetite as big as Adora's.

— Your toast is so good. — She didn't doubt it. — I need you to make me breakfast everyday.

— I'll love to. — They eyed each other. — Can I ask you something?

— Shoot. — She didn't seem worried as she went for another toast.

— Last night…you did something, and said it was a force of habit, what did you mean by it? What was a force of habit? — It took some seconds for the other to realize what they were talking about.

Catra looked at Adora, unsure.

— It's a…thing I did a lot during sex…edging. — She said simply. — Do you know what that is? — She didn't want to sound condescending but she also didn't want to explain to Adora something she might already know.

— Yes…I think. — The blonde had a very vague knowledge of sexual things thanks to her lack of interest in it until Catra. — Is like teasing.

— I guess you can say that.

Adora took a bite of her toast.

— So…you like doing that? — The question made Catra choked on air.

— Adora…why are you asking me that? — Why was she so defensive? Was it still hard to be vulnerable? To open up? To talk about herself.

She didn't know exactly how their conversation should go and that was making her act a bit on the defensive side, although Adora didn't sound demanding or mad. She knew that her side of things would play a maior rola in their sex life, but having Adora ask her about it was weird in a way and at that moment Catra didn't know any other way to feel.

— You don't have to tell me if you don't want to. — The blonde took the hint as claws met the bed sheets. — I was just curious…

— It's a…something someone I slept with liked. And I got used to doing it. — She swallowed her food, avoiding eye contact at all cost.

Adora hummed in understanding.

— Is everything okay? — Adora let out. — Did you…hate last night or something? I can handle it, if you think it was bad, just tell me. — Adora tried to sound adult and mature about it.

— What are you talking about? — Said the feline. — Of course I don't. Adora…we had an amazing night. But I have never done this type of talk. Not like it is with you.

— What do you mean? — Catra looked her in the eyes.

— Other people just told me what they wanted, or I ordered them. It was an exchange, just pleasure. With you is so much more…and even talking about it is different, I care for you, and I don't want to push your boundaries or force an idea onto you, we can try our own things, we don't have to do the things I did with others... — Adora took Catra's hand. — And we don't have to rush…hell, we don't even have to have sex again with you don't want it.

— I told you already, I like sex…*with you*.

Catra's phone rang, cutting their conversation short. Scorpia was calling to talk about Finn, nothing major but she had to go get groceries and they stayed with Melog. As much as Catra wanted to spend the day hanging out with Adora she had responsibilities.

— I gotta go. And Finn is expecting to see you tomorrow morning for training.

— Oh yeah, I can't believe is almost time.

Catra got up and stared to collect her clothes. Adora observed as she put her suit back on. Before heading out she kissed Adora, really kissed her, the blonde bushed.

— We can talk more later? Call me?

— Okay.

X

Before meeting Finn Adora had scheduled to see Perfuma. After everything that had happened she figured it was a good time to talk to her therapist. It took her longer than usual to find the kind woman, who was sitting on the ground and planting new seeds.

— Hi. — Adora said as she got closer. — Can I help you? — Perfuma nodded.

They spent some time in silence, just planting.

— So, tell me. How are you? — The warm smile made Adora less nervous about what she was about to say.

— I had sex. — She blurted out. — And I liked it, a lot.

— That's great…with Catra I presume.

— Yeah. She's officially my girlfriend. — Adora sounded proud. — But I don't know…this lack of…experience on my part is bothering me. I don't want her to feel like she has to teach me. I feel so… helpless sometimes.

Perfuma took Adora's hands on hers.

— Hey, I know that is hard to feel behind, to feel like you missed something everyone else seems to know. But is it okay to learn now, and who better to help you than someone who loves you? — Adora tried to not feel guilty. — And you can research, read, watch, learn alone about things she might know, maybe even try something with her. Sex can be an amazing experience, and is

one with a huge learning curve, often things go wrong, sometimes it is even funny.

Adora groaned.

— Yeah, I guess you're right. — The blonde sighed. — The tournament is in two days, and I think Finn might actually win.

— I know, Frosta told me. We'll be there. — Adora smiled at that. — Listen. Don't let your insecurities ruin what you have with Catra, be open and honest with her, don't bottle things up and wait to talk to me about it… she's your girlfriend now, and she's a mom and is leading a very demanding projet, she won't have a lot of time to think about what's in your head or what signs she might be missing, you need to tell her, you need to communicate.

Adora nodded. She agreed, even though it was easier said than done.

— I want to be a comfort for her, not another worry. She's got plenty of those. — Another sigh left her lips. — I been thinking a lot about…my life, how I've been this way for so long is hard to change and evolve into something better, but I'm trying so hard. — She closed her eyes. — You know…spending time with Finn made me realized I never really had a childhood, never had a loving parent, a helping hand, I was the helping hand, I was my own parent! I didn't have a lot of chances to get things wrong or to mess up, I just followed the rules until I couldn't anymore but than I still had to be organized, training everyday, I still train everyday. For what? I don't even know. It's like I want danger to find me.

— Do you?

— No! I don't, I want to relax, to be calm…for the first time I know what that feels like, I want to chase that feeling, I want to break free from all the chains that keep weighing me down. — She opened her eyes. — Sometimes it feels impossible to do so, but now I have time to work on it. To work on myself.

X

Catra had never imagined getting help was going to mean more work, because now she had more meetings, and more side projects to worry about. All of it and the demolition was going slower because Scorpia was sticking around until the tournament, something Catra just couldn't be mad about. What she was mad about still had something to do with Scorpia, more particularly how the taller woman was freaking out over a certain therapist.

— I don't know what came over me?! I invited her for tea! Who does that? — She exasperated. — We had just met! Maybe she's going to think I'ma creep.

— Didn't she say yes?

— Yes, but I definitely came in too strong!

Catra was annoyed at how inconvenient the situation was but Scorpia was such a support friend, and if letting her vent while laying on the sofa of her office was what she needed, Catra was going to endure it.

— Oh my crab! What I am going to wear! — Scorpia got up in distress. — I need Finn, right now!

— Hey, leave my kid alone, they got enough on their plate for this week. And you better calm down. — Catra stood up. — We'll figure this out, and we can take Glimmer as a third opinion. But after work, because we still need to do that, you know, work.

Scorpia nodded and went to her assigned office leaving Catra alone. It had been a tough start of the week, and she really wanted to talk things out with Adora, they had to figured out a lot of things, especially what exactly their relationship meant when it came to Finn. Catra was not sure how much she wanted another person involved with raising them, and she needed to be sure it was a stable deal. She didn't want Adora to overstep.

They hadn't done much after sleeping together, granted it had been only two days and Finn's tournament was right around the corner. Texting had simply been to make sure they were okay, and healthy. Adora sent some cute messages in the morning and before bed, Catra couldn't say she expected anything less.

She hadn't exactly told Finn about Adora being anything beyond a friend yet. And that was eating her up alive.

— Hey, so we're shopping later? — Once again Glimmer scared the shit out of Catra. — Scorpia told me…do you know who the date is?

— You would never guess.

— Is someone I know? — Glimmer's eyes quite literally sparked.

— Yes. — Catra decided to have some fun with the situation. — If by the time we get there you haven't figured it out, I want a raise. — Glimmer's frown was hilarious. — Okay, no raise, but you'll be my babysitter whenever I need you to.

— Finn's not a baby.

— No, but they're a bit irresponsible and a child and I won't leave them alone.

— Is this about sexy time with Adora? Because if it is I can totally help you out, plus, Bow would love to. — Glimmer smiled big.

— Is a deal then. — They both nodded and Glimmer walked out of there already trying to figure out who it was.

It would be a little awkward to have Scorpia and Glimmer interacting out of work. Hanging out used to be something Catra was good at, especially when she and Double Trouble were together, however those times were completely different than just going shopping with a friend.

— So…where are you two going? — Glimmer was starting to put her plan into practice.

— We're going out for tea, I hope she likes it there. I've never been but is tea, I don't think they can go wrong.

Catra had never seen Scorpia that nervous about something, not even when the accident at fabric happened.

— So…— Catra pulled Glimmer to the side. — Who do you think it is?

Glimmer took a deep breath.

— I think it is Mermista, she told me last week she and Sea-hawk decided to have an open relationship. — Catra did her best to not laugh.

— You couldn't been more wrong. You can pick Finn up Friday, how that's that sound? — She smiled wickedly as they returned to walk besides Scorpia.

— I was thinking…maybe a floral dress?! — Scorpia turned to them yet again a bit deranged.

— No. — Glimmer said. — I think the right choice is training on a few things and them we can decide.

Catra practically just tagged alone till it was time to pick up Finn. Scorpia did find a cute dress and Glimmer had her answer but the time they were walking out of the flower shop.

Finn got in the car and fell asleep as soon as they said hi. She hoped they would have enough energy to keep up during the fights. It was going to be an entire afternoon. She was a bit nervous to go, to be in such a competitive environment but she had to. She had to be there for her child.

X

— Mom! I can't find my shoes! — Finn shouted from the stairs.

— Did you check under your bed?

The small blonde didn't wait a second before bolting into their room again.

— Found it!

They had been all over the place since waking up. Catra could see they were nervous and excited. Finn did their best to play it cool but it was not working.

— Come down, I need to talk to you.

It didn't take long for them and Melog to show up and Catra to woman up and stop the delaying.

— Before we head out. I want you to know…me and Adora are dating. — Melog purred at the announcement.

Finn on the other hand didn't seem to be taking it well.

— And you tell me this now?! I'm too stressed to be happy! And now I don't know what to feel. You should've waited a little longer… and how could Adora not tell me.

The response ended up being the most teenager thing they had ever said. Catra tried not to take it too personally.

— Relax. You're going to be fine. You trained a lot, trust your training. — She got closer to hug them. — And if you lose I'll be there to cheer you up, even Scorpia is going to support, so chin up.

They nodded.

— I'm ready, Adora is there already.

Finn basically ran to the car. Everything in the preteen's head was spinning. They had worked so hard that not winning really felt like

the worst thing that could happen to them ever. Their fur was a mess, and Catra tired to brush it but it didn't end really well so Finn was not looking their best. They had a kimono on, it was tailored for them and it had Adora's gym symbol on it. Melog couldn't go because the venue didn't allow pets, another thing that added to the kid's turmoil of feelings.

— So… is Adora coming to live with us? — Finn asked out of nowhere.

— Uh…is not something we talked about.

— We have space for her. — Finn's support was a relief once more.

— I'll tell her that. — Catra reached for their hand. — You're going to be fine…I have been in some fights of my own, and one thing I can tell you is never let your opponent know you fear them, if you do, you become the prey, and as much as fooling your opponent into thinking you're weak is a very good strategy, is not ideal when you're really nervous, so… like I said before, chin up.

Finn nodded to their mom's words. They spent the rest of the drive working on their breathing, it was important for the fight and it helped with their trembling hands.

As soon as they got out of the car Finn fixed their posture, entering the place with renewed confidence.

— Buddy! — Adora grabbed them by the back lifting them off the ground in a tight hug. — Hi. — She said timidly to Catra.

The feline took into her hands to show Adora it was fine and gave her a quick peck.

— Hi, *girlfriend*. — Adora smiled big.

— Okay you two, let's go. I need to know who I'm fighting first.

They both nodded and Adora took them by the hand. Catra went to find her place on the grandstand.

Finn's first opponent was a little taller and from a taekwondo group.

— Remember, let them attack first. — Adora whispered before it was time for Finn to step on the mat as she placed their protection helmet.

The first to go to mat three times was out. They both waited in position for the fight to start. And soon as the fight started Finn took the offense, waiting for the right moment to strike. And it came fast, the first opening allowed Finn to grab the boy's legs and throw him on the mat. As soon as the point was granted Finn helped the guy up.

They kept it up, waiting and just defending as well as they could, but the other guy was strong, and during the second round Finn was no match when it came to a battle of strength, they soon fell.

Adora's face showed nothing but support, giving them a bit of confidence to keep going.

— You got this! — Adora yelled.

Third round started and the boy rushed towards Finn, who used their agility to dodge. The stunt made the boy trip and step off the mat.

— Oh! — Was all the feline could say with their first win. — I won.

Adora hi fived them and they tried to keep it cool.

— Just four more to go.

The next two fight were somewhat easier, Finn wasn't as nervous and they were a lot more confident in their abilities. Catra and

Scorpia cheered like no other, only losing to a father who wouldn't stop screaming as loud as he could to cheer for his daughter.

It was hard seeing some of the falls Finn took, but they seemed okay from a far. And Adora didn't look worry making Catra a bit calmer.

Finn got around to the semifinals, the two fights would happen simultaneously and the rules had changed to only two points. Meaning stakes were a bit higher. Finn looked around at the other three kids, because they would have to fight at least two of them if they won.

— Good luck. — They said before moving to the mat.

One of the kids didn't answer. And she soon walked to the mat next to Finn's. When their opponent arrived it was safe to say Finn was already thinking about the next match, the last one. To say they felt cocky was an understatement, although Finn knew that at that moment it was different, they were just sure they would go to the finals. They used the same tactics as in the first match, waiting for the opponent to attack. And they did the minute the 'fight!' was yelled, the problem was, the kid was fast, real fast and they had a tail too, different, a lot rougher than Finn's. And it took them down. Back hitting the mat with an loud thud.

Before their spirits could get down they got up. Shaking the pain away. They got ready to strike first, they couldn't wait for that to happened again. So Finn attacked and had to defend right after, the tail movement almost hitting their face, it was hard following the moves but they did their best to dodge and not fall. The boy had incredible balance too, it was looking a lot dangerous. Finn decided to take the defense again, and hoped they could dodge in time. They now were aware of the tail, so as soon as they spinned it in their different Finn jumped and rolled, kicking the legs of their opponent, making him fall.

The tie was cheered loudly.

Finn took a deep concentration breath. They wanted to go to the finals.

It was fast what happened afterwards. As the guy came in their direction Finn tried to dodge by rolling as they did before, only this time their opponent had caught on to their tactics and so they stepped on Finn's tail, the pain was sharp, they felt it in their entire spine. A yell came from somewhere and they couldn't say where. Someone helped them up. As soon as they got on their feet again the commotion had already started. Adora was arguing with the kid and their teacher. Finn felt their ears ringing, and every movement hurt, they suddenly felt panic when they couldn't move the tail.

— Adora… — They called her and she turned. — I think is broken.

The tears came and Finn couldn't do much about it, it hurt a lot.

— Where are the damn paramedics?! — She yelled again.

Soon they were laying on their belly on a stretcher. The first thing the paramedics did was give them something for the pain.

— How is it? — Catra got into the small room after fighting her way out of the grandstand. — Is it bad?

— It hurts. — Finn said, holding a sob.

Catra looked petrified.

— I'm so sorry. I know I told you it was safe but what that kid did was not allowed! — Adora apologetic tone was lost by Catra.

— Not now. — Catra took their hand. — I'm here. We're going to take you to the hospital soon… Adora, go get my car and follow us to the hospital. — She handed the keys to her.

Without much to say Adora did what was asked of her, following the ambulance that took Finn. She couldn't help but feel like it

was all her fault. Not ignoring how much it reminded her of what Catra had said about being a mom. It was the time to show up, to not let Catra down. She wouldn't be scared off by it.

Finn was taken to the emergency. And She stood by Catra's side as they did an x-ray and than when directly to surgery. No words were said, Catra's shaking hands were a sign she was not handling it well. Adora decided to not push or talk, she did offer her a hand to hold.

— I can't see them like this again. — Catra whispered. — It was so bad, Adora, we spent an entire month on the hospital trying to get their lungs to not give up. — Adora pulled her closer as Catra seemed to sink into awful memories.

— Hey, we are going to be out of here with them in no time. — She kissed Catra temple. — And *I'll be here right next to you* untill is time to go.

It had been 4 long hours when they finally got to talk to the doctor.

— So…They'll be fine. — The doctor said to the two women. — But we had to cut a part of their tail, is only some inches shorter but if we didn't, they could end up not being able to move it again. — Catra had signed the papers and talk to the doctor before but still it was a hard decision. — So now all you guys have to do is make sure to let it heal properly from the surgery, the fur is probably going to grow back in about two weeks. All the meds and prescriptions are here. — Catra was too space out to grab it so Adora did.

— Thank you…any restrictions we need to know? — Catra asked.

— Not much, just tell them to not do anything crazy, the tail will gain its movement back soon, they're only going back home once it does. — The doctor said. — So. We need someone to spend the night here.

Catra had already missed work for the tournament.

— I can stay if you want, I can spend the night. You stay now and later we can switch. — Adora suggested. — I know you have to work early.

Catra nodded.

—I'll text you to come, thank you.

X

Catra sat next to Finn who was still sleeping thanks to the meds. It was hard seeing them in a bed like that again. It was getting dark outside but she truly wanted to talk to them before heading out.

— Baby. — She whispered. — Wake up, just for a second. — Their ears twitched, signaling they were hearing her. — Adora is coming to stay with you. But I'll be here to take you home tomorrow. I need to feed Melog and go to work in the morning. — She kissed their forehead. — I love you and I'm not mad so you can stop pretending to be asleep now.

— Don't break up with Adora. — They whispered. — It wasn't her fault, I knew that I could get hurt, she told me that *everytime* we trained. And we trained a lot. Okay? Don't break up with her. Not because of this.

— I just said she's coming to stay with you. I wouldn't do that if I was planning on breaking up with her. — Catra scent marked them. — Now, rest.

— Okay... Bye mom. Good night.

She wouldn't lie, she had thought about blaming Adora but in the end they all know it was a risk. She just wished Finn didn't have to stay the night at the hospital.

Adora was waiting outside the hospital for them to switch places so they didn't get to talk, but Adora did steal a hug. A tight one.

X

It had been two months since Finn got Injured, their tail was back on its full performance. And after a while they got over not being able to finish the tournament. And for Catra's displeasure, they were focusing on the next year's tournament.

— Are you sure you want to do this? — Adora whispered as she brought a box inside the house.

— With you living in a different house we barely get to see each other. I am very sure I want you here and Finn does too. — Catra said, bringing another box. — So move, *princess*.

Adora nodded and placed the box on the ground of what was now their house, for the time being, Catra still had hopes of living in the Fright Zone.

Melog greeted them with a loud purring.

— Mom, I'm going to Luke's. — Finn said before leaving the house.

— Who's Luke? — Catra asked.

— A friend they made in the neighborhood, they live on 14. — The info Adora had on the kid made Catra more at ease. — Is good for them to have friends.

— It is just a friend right?! They are too young for any dating.

— Relax Catra, they are just playing. — Adora laughed a little.

It was so odd to be putting her stuff in the shelves. The moving was done in pieces. It started in the first week of Finn's recovery, Adora had spent so much time in there that almost all of her clothes were already in Catra's closet. And soon they all got used to being together and the days Adora wasn't around were the weird ones.

— Finn made me promise you can only do exercises outside or in the garage so I'm putting the gym stuff there. — Adora agreed.

— Catra. — Adora called.

— What? — The feline turned with a box full of comics Adora had collected.

— Thank you for letting me be part of your family. — She didn't mean to say it but it came out.

Catra put the box down getting closer to Adora and kissing her.

— *Our family*.





Chapter End Notes

So those are the outfits from chapter 9 and some tender moments of their night together.

See you guys in part 2.

Heads up

Just a heads up that the prologue for part 2 is up. I will be deleting this later.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!